# Do Not Forget

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/56358799.

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Teen And Up Audiences

**Archive Warnings:**
Graphic Depictions Of Violence, Rape/Non-Con

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F/F

**Fandom:**
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

**Relationship:**
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

**Characters:**
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra)

**Additional Tags:**
Angst with a Happy Ending, Angst and Hurt/Comfort, Post-Canon, Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder - PTSD, Betaed: We may yet live, Past Rape/Non-con, Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Adora Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Everyone Needs A Hug, Misremembered last words, Adora Has Issues (She-Ra)

**Language:**
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Part 10 of Tell Me Everything, Part 5 of Stories Never Shared, Part 6 of Unchained Heart

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# Do Not Forget

by Paganaidd

Summary

The memory of Angella's last moments, her sacrifice, haunted Adora. She had never been able to share Angella's exact last words with anyone, not even with Bow—how Angella had told her to look after everyone.

Everyone was overjoyed to hear that rescuing Angella was possible. Adora shared that joy, of course, but did not know how she would face the Queen. How could she tell Angella that, once again, she had failed?

Notes

This begins right where "Swapsies" ends.

Tags and rating may change.

Beta'd by Doc

# Chapter 1

With the sound of tiny windchimes, Glimmer blinked Adora, Catra, and Bow back to Mystacor, appearing just outside Micah's door, her face wreathed in smiles. "I cannot wait to talk to Dad!" she burbled. "I just… I cannot believe she's alive! It's… Oh!" Glimmer grabbed Catra in a tight hug for the third or fourth time. "Catra saves the day again!" she squealed.

Catra smiled, showing one fang, her ears and tail drooping. She hugged Glimmer back. "Yeah, okay, Sparkles. Don't think I like you or anything." She stepped back and nodded at the door. "Why don't you two go tell Micah the portal is ready."

"Don't you want to come?" Glimmer asked, her eyebrows going up.

"Yeah!" Bow chimed in, grinning. "I mean, if it wasn't for you…"

"Naw. It's okay," Catra said hastily, taking another step back. "I just… That should be just for you." Her cheeks reddened under the peach fuzz of her face, her ears tilted back, and her tail remained low. She wrapped one arm across her chest and looked away. "If it works… then we can celebrate."

Nothing could dim Glimmer's enthusiasm, but she looked disappointed. "Oh, but…"

"Really," asserted Catra, her voice wavering slightly. "You guys… You guys should just have a minute to yourselves. Just…" she trailed off, a profound sadness flashing across her face before she covered it with a lopsided smile. "We'll talk in the morning."

Bow touched Glimmer's arm, and they exchanged looks. Then Glimmer nodded. "We'll talk later." She turned away to knock on Micah's door.

As Catra and Adora walked through the hallway, a heavy silence settled between them. Adora was more grateful than she wanted

to admit that Catra had gotten them out of talking to Micah. Adora had not spoken to him much since the end of the war. When they were bringing him up to speed after his rescue, she had told him how Angella had sacrificed herself. He had thanked her for telling him with a sad gentle smile and excused himself. Hours later, he returned from a walk in the Whispering Woods, eyes swollen and red, his voice rough as though from screaming.

Adora had never been able to share Angella's exact last words, even with Bow—how Angella had told her to look after everyone. Micah sometimes would press people gently when they talked about Angella. He said he wanted to know as much about her life without him as he could. He always seemed to know she was keeping something back. Nevertheless, he was kind to her, even though she knew she did not deserve it.

Both were preoccupied with their thoughts, walking in silence back to their room. Catra rubbed the back of her neck and looked at the floor, her eyebrows wrinkled. Adora watched her out of the corner of her eye, unsure what to say. Today had been too much.

*It would have been nice if Catra told you what they were planning today.*

Adora bit her lip. It would have been nice. They kept getting blindsided by crises. What was Catra thinking? Glimmer had been angry enough to spit nails when Scorpia mentioned the new portal. Why couldn't Catra tell her?

*You know what she's like. She can't help it.*

A wave of heat rose in Adora's stomach as she realized Catra was keeping secrets again. She glanced at Catra, who was still in her own world, seemingly oblivious to Adora's rising indignation. She did not want to get into a shouting match in the hallway, but they had just been over this. Was Catra just going to discard all those promises they made to each other? How could she?

*Just a deceitful little animal.*

A soft sniff alerted Adora that Catra had probably picked up on the change in her scent. “Adora, I…” Catra began.

“Not here,” Adora growled, her boot heels clicking on the floor more loudly than necessary.

“Yeah. Yeah, okay.” Catra agreed far too easily.

By the time they got back to their room, Adora was seething, even as her mind reeled from the news about Angella. She sat heavily on the little couch tucked in the corner. She looked up at Catra, who hesitated near the door she had closed behind her, her posture tense and uncertain. The late afternoon light flickered off the crystal and silver accents, mirroring the unease in Catra’s eyes.

“I thought we weren’t going to keep secrets anymore?” Adora asked, reigning in her hurt and anger. She felt hot and suffocated. Grey silk curtains hung heavy at the windows, muting the late afternoon light. A somber, diffused glow cast soft shadows across the plush blue carpet. The luxury of the Princess’s palaces always seemed to mock her. An enemy could easily hide in the opulent textiles of the room, and her ears were not as sensitive as Catra’s, leaving her vulnerable.

Once Adora had woken to Shadow Weaver looming over her. Why had Adora not killed the evil bitch then? She had the hag at the business end of a dagger. If she had just done that one thing, Catra would never have pulled that switch. Angella would not be lost in some pocket dimension.

Adora’s mind still reeled from the revelation that Angella lived. However, the weight of yet another secret hung heavily between the two women. Adora wanted to say more, but her breath caught in her throat. Her heartbeat echoed in her ears as she wrestled with her emotions. She felt sick.

For a moment, Catra stood on the threshold, staring as if she saw a ghost. Finally, she seemed to pluck up her courage to speak.

“I’m sorry. It’s just that…” she trailed off for a second. “You’ve been so busy. There just was never a good time.”

*Oh, please. Is that the best she can come up with?*

“That’s the best you can do?” Adora echoed the voice in her head.

Catra’s gaze flickered away before settling back on Adora. She opened her mouth, closed it, took a deep breath, and started again. “You’re doing a lot. I can see how stressed out you are.” She wrapped her arms around herself and looked away. “At first, it was just Micah and Melog. I knew they had some magical thing happening. They didn’t want to get anyone’s hopes up, but then I asked Melog where they were going in the evenings. It turns out they were hanging out with Micah, and they started to need me to translate. Aunt Casta asked about it, so Micah suggested we talk to Entrapta and Scorpia, and then, you know, Perfuma…”

“So, pretty much everyone knew, except for me, that my wife was one of Entrapta’s experiments?” Adora snarled, although some small part of her wondered why she did not realize Melog was gone in the evenings.

Catra flinched, then nodded almost imperceptibly. “It was just a test,” she admitted quietly, her expression strained but devoid of hostility. “It was Melog who came up with a way to give Entrapta’s portal coordinates. And then Melog found the old queen. Angella, I guess her name was?”

“Yeah.”

Catra hunched in on herself, and her shoulders trembled slightly. Melog pressed against her knee, chirping as though offering comfort. "Yeah, yeah. I’m okay," she whispered to Melog.

A flare of heat rose in Adora’s chest, but she fought to keep it under control. It was irrational to feel so sidelined, she told herself. Catra had every right to lean on Melog, especially when Adora had been less available. Yet, watching them now, a part of her couldn’t help but feel a pang of jealousy. Unlike Swiftwind,

whose words everyone could understand, Melog's silent counsel left her feeling shut out and irrationally upset.

*She does not trust you.*

The silence stretched, laden with unspoken accusations, until Adora couldn't hold back. "You were working on another fucking portal, Catra!" The words burst out more harshly than intended, echoing off the walls of their small room.

"Yes."

Adora's voice grew louder. "Why can't you trust me?" she demanded, clenching her fists on her lap.

"You're right. It was a mistake." Catra's voice was sad, and she held Adora's gaze. "I… it really was an accident. We decided I should be the one to test it because Melog could find me no matter where Entrapta sent me. I went today because it was ready today." She ran her hand through her hair. "You know how Entrapta gets excited. I didn't call you because you said you were working on decommissioning that Temple, and I didn't want to bother you. I know how important it is to you."

Catra sounded way more reasonable than what Adora was expecting. There was no pushback, no anger, no defensiveness. Just an almost eerie calm. Adora was silent for a moment, processing, suddenly acutely aware of her own hypocrisy. She did not want to talk about what she had been doing at the Crystal Castle.

"But it's about Angella, Catra. How could you think I wouldn't want to know?" Adora's voice cracked, a mix of hurt and anger bubbling to the surface. The memory of Angella's last moments, her sacrifice, haunted her. Adora automatically assumed Angella would have died when the dimension collapsed. That she could be alive and no one had bothered to look for her seemed cruel.

"I know, I know. It's just that everything was so uncertain. Melog and Micah said it would work, but…" Catra paused, looking down

at her hands. “I wasn’t even sure it was real. And it would be worse if I got everyone’s hopes up.”

Okay, maybe Adora could understand that. If it turned out that Angella really was dead after finding out she could be alive, Adora was not sure she would be able to bear it. Perhaps it would have been kinder to let Glimmer know afterward.

“And… and anyway,” Catra went on, her voice barely more than a whisper. “I felt like if this was something I could do for Sparkles and her dad.” She shrugged jerkily and bent to rub her face in Melog’s mane. She straightened up, wiping her eyes. “Melog knows where she is, but their magic isn’t strong enough to make a portal stable enough to bring her back. So, I’m going to go get her.”

Adora sighed deeply, the initial rush of anger giving way to a reluctant understanding. And a bone-deep exhaustion. The pain from her phantom injuries still throbbed, but it was not enough to clear her head. She rubbed her temples, feeling a headache forming. “I get it, Catra. But I needed to be a part of this—from the beginning.”

They had all mourned Angella, presuming her dead. With that, everything went to shit. After Glimmer became Queen, she started listening to Shadow Weaver, drifting away from Adora and Bow. Catra took over the war and started kicking the Alliance’s ass.

Catra nodded, her own shoulders slumping. “You’re right. I should have told you sooner. It’s just... it felt like a chance to… to fix something. And after today, when Entrapta activated the portal...”

“The portal that sent you somewhere without telling me?” Adora interrupted, unable to restrain her ire. “The one that sent you back in time, or whatever?”

“Yes,” Catra admitted, looking miserable. “And then everything spiraled out. I’m so sorry.”

Adora took a deep breath, trying to calm the storm inside her. Perversely, she almost wanted Catra to fight her. She had no business being so reasonable when Adora was falling to pieces. "We need to be honest with each other, Catra. No more secrets, okay? Not about this. Not about anything."

Catra seemed to take that as some kind of signal and finally came fully into the room. She reached out, taking Adora's hand in hers, and sat beside her. "No more secrets," she agreed softly. "I promise." She searched Adora's face and used her free hand to push back a piece of hair that had escaped Adora's ponytail. "Entrapta said she could probably make the adjustments if the Sparkle family helped her. She said… She said it would probably be ready tomorrow."

"Tomorrow?" gasped Adora. Everything was moving too fast.

Catra shrugged. "I want to do it as soon as we can." She smiled sadly. "Glimmer told me how her mom got stuck in the portal when we were… you know." She waved her free hand vaguely at the ceiling. "On Prime's ship."

Adora stared at Catra. "She-she told you?" The air in the room thickened as Adora struggled to process Catra's words. What had Glimmer told Catra? That Angella was dead because of Adora? That, once again, Adora had failed everyone?

The room was too hot, the luxurious trappings even more oppressive and stifling. Sweat trickled down Adora's back under her shirt, and her vision blurred. Glimmer's words echoed in her mind: Your best isn't good enough. If it was, my mother would still be here.

Adora felt disconnected from her body, as if floating above the scene, watching herself struggle to cope.

"Yes," Catra whispered, her eyes full of concern. "Are you okay?"

Adora tried to nod, but the gesture was stiff and robotic. She needed to pull herself together for Catra, for Glimmer, for

everyone who depended on She-Ra. Yet, at that moment, she felt utterly overwhelmed, barely tethered to the world around her.

“Yeah, I… I just need a minute,” Adora murmured, her voice barely audible as she struggled to ground herself. Everything seemed muffled, distant. The room swayed like the deck of a ship.

Catra was talking, but her voice sounded far away. Adora could tell she was worried by the set of her mouth. She looked at their clasped hands, but they did not feel like they belonged to her.

Angella was alive. That should mean something. Adora should feel something, right? And she did, sort of. She felt floaty and detached, as if she were looking down at herself sitting here as she tried to grasp the gravity of what was happening. The walls pulsed with her heartbeat, which was too loud and too fast. It was disorienting. Catra's hand was in hers, her eyes worried. Why did she seem so far away?

Adora remembered Angella’s last smile. How the Queen commanded She Ra to look after everyone.... no, she shouldn’t go there. That was too real, too painful. She needed to stick to the now. Except, what was 'now'? The moment didn’t feel real. Nothing did. Was this what falling through a portal felt like? Unmoored, adrift between dimensions where nothing made sense? Is this what she had condemned Angella to? Forever?

She squeezed Catra’s hand and tried to slow down her breathing. She had to pull it together. They needed She-Ra, even if Adora was a ragged, gasping mess.

“Hey, Adora?” Catra put one hand on Adora’s cheek, giving her something to focus on. Adora closed her eyes and leaned into her hand, covering it with her own. “You don’t look good,” Catra whispered. “Have you eaten?”

Adora shook her head.

“Idiot.” Catra’s voice was far too gentle. “Let’s find you something to eat, and then we’ll get to bed. I know Sparkles will have us up

early in the morning." She stood. "You. Stay put." She pressed her hand down on Adora's shoulder, stopping her from standing.

"Okay." Adora was unsure what she agreed to, but she followed Catra's directions. She heard Catra ask for some food to be brought up. When it arrived, Catra made her a plate and brought it to the couch, sitting beside Adora with her own.

Adora shoveled it into her mouth, barely tasting anything, acutely aware of Catra's sharp eyes resting on her with concern.

"What?" she finally asked, feeling oddly vulnerable under Catra's gaze.

"Do you remember when you were afraid of the dark, and Shadow Weaver grounded you?" Catra asked, picking at the fish on her plate.

Adora shrugged. "I guess. I mean, it was a pretty shitty time."

"Did… did anyone ever, I don't know, slip you a flashlight or anything?"

Adora blinked, and a bitter little bark of a laugh escaped her mouth at the absurdity of that. "No way. You know no one would interfere with Shadow Weaver that way," she said. "Why?"

Catra exchanged troubled looks with Melog before she said, "I saw you."

"I don't understand."

"I saw you. As a kid. I talked to you. Shadow Weaver had you locked up in that supply closet. You were… I don't know, six or seven? You were so little." Catra spoke quietly and looked down at her plate. "I always remember you as being bigger than me. But when I talked to you today, you were tiny." Without looking up, Catra used the heel of her hand to wipe one eye. "She had you locked up in that supply closet. It was dark. I didn't know my eyes were so much better in the dark until Entrapta told us. I never

knew before how dark it had to be for you." She looked up, her expression haunted. "And you were so little."

Adora stared at her. "Sorry, I don't remember that happening at all."

Catra raised her head. "I figured that. I would have remembered if you told me about someone who looked like me."

"Maybe I didn't tell you?" Adora said, feeling confused.

Catra raised one eyebrow. "You mean you wouldn't have told me about meeting a grown-up who looked like me and had eyes like mine that shined in the dark?"

Put that way, it did seem unlikely.

"Melog said there was a younger me who came out of the portal," Catra said. "They couldn't tell me much more because they went looking as soon as she appeared. It was weird when they brought me back. As soon as they arrived, it seemed like something grabbed me, and then I was in Entrapta's lab with Melog. I never actually saw her." One corner of her mouth quirked up. "I asked Melog why and they said a bunch of things about equilibrium and magic that I did not understand."

Adora returned the smile briefly. "You were adorable. You hid out under Entrapta's workbench until we talked you into coming out with a tuna sandwich. Then you drew with Bow. Then you played catch-the-bot until you were tired out."

"Melog left her sleeping on a crate, they said," Catra said slowly. "Did you tell her it was a secret lab?" Her eyes were narrowed in thought.

"Yes!"

The smile Catra had was wistful. "Yeah. I kinda remember it. I remembered it the first time we had tuna. And then someone gave me applesauce."

“Wait. I remember you telling me about it. You said it was the sweetest thing you ever tasted.” Adora’s smile felt more real now. “And I said… I said if it was that sweet, you should be named after it.”

Catra giggled, the squeak at the end thawing the ice in Adora’s heart.

# Crossing the Threshold

Chapter Summary

Adora still has bad dreams.

Catra leaves to go get Angella

Chapter Notes

Thanks to my beta, Doc.

*Shadows pen her in, and red lightning arcs just beyond them. "Where did this come from?" Shadow Weaver demands, holding out the black cylinder.*

*"Sh-she gave it to me."*

*"Who?"*

*The little girl hesitates.*

"Adora?"

*"Th-the lady. She had eyes like Catra and…"*

*"You little liar!" Shadow Weaver barks. Lightning jumps toward Adora, and she throws up her hand.*

"Adora?"

*Someone calls her from beyond the lightning. Catra? It sounds like Catra. She shouldn't be here! Shadow Weaver will…*

"Adora! Wake up!"

Adora's eyes snapped open, and she looked around wildly. Where was she? What was this room?

*Stars-fucking-damnit. Fuck and bugger.*

A litany of curses echoed in her head, but she kept her mouth shut because Shadow Weaver would be furious if any of them fell from her mouth. She expected her officers to be respectful and always set a good example.

“Adora?” Catra said again loudly. “Hey!”

The room was too bright, but Adora recognized the blue and grey furnishings. Mystacor? Right. Mystacor. She was a million years away from that little girl. Shadow Weaver was dead, and Adora was…

Adora was standing on the bed again. Her shield glowed with a bright light, illuminating their room as she half-crouched, protecting her head.

Catra sat pressed against the headboard, her yellow and blue eyes wide with fear, her irises tiny slits against the bright light. She held her hands at her shoulders to show she was not trying to touch Adora this time.

The fear in Catra’s eyes felt like a punch to Adora's soul. Shadows from the dream clung to her like maggots, making her feel like her flesh was already rotting. Could someone not do the decent thing and just put her out of her misery?

She dropped to her knees with a low moan, letting She Ra go. Burying her hands in her hair, she struggled to catch her breath.

“Can I come over there?” Catra asked softly.

If anyone touched Adora right now, she would puke, so she shook her head sharply.

“Okay, I’ll just stay here then.”

An intake of breath became a sob, then another. She jumped out of bed and stood in the middle of the room, her breathing fast, wet, and loud.

She wanted to hit something, to banish the half-recollected images from her mind. She wanted to feel the little bones of her hand crunch against each other. She wanted to tear her hair out. She wanted to find a cliff to jump from and lie at the bottom of it, her spine and pelvis in pieces, only She Ra's magic holding her together. It's not like it would kill her. It's not like it would even do permanent damage. But it would hurt.

That's what she needed. If she hurt herself badly enough, She Ra's healing sleep was velvet black and dreamless. She would not have to think about Shadow Weaver, or the war, or the countless lives she destroyed.

That thought made her gorge rise, and she bolted to the bathroom, bringing up water and yellow bile. When the retching stopped, she rested her head on the cool porcelain, dimly aware that Catra and Melog had followed her.

"Same nightmare?" Catra asked softly.

Adora nodded, seeing no point in denying it.

"What can I do?"

"Don't worry about it," whispered Adora. "Go back to bed. You've got to be in the Fright Zone in the morning."

Catra exchanged looks with Melog, who chirped back at her before coming into the bathroom to sit on the counter. "Yeah, because I'm a shitty wife."

"Catra, I didn't say…." Adora began.

"Shh. Quiet. It's okay." Her voice was soft. "I'm kidding, dork."

Adora nodded faintly, feeling exhaustion etched into her very bones. She rested her forehead on the cool porcelain, her breath coming in slow, ragged sighs. Catra and Melog sat quietly until Adora picked her head up.

“Do you need any help?” Catra asked softly, not moving from her spot.

Adora started to shake her head but felt herself sway as she staggered to her feet. “Oh. Um, maybe?” she muttered, pressing the back of her hand against her damp forehead.

Catra’s arm slid around her waist instantly. “Come on. Let’s get back to bed.”

She helped Adora to the bed and then, without asking, tossed her another t-shirt and shorts from the drawer. Adora gratefully changed out of her sweat-soaked night clothes.

They still had a couple of hours until they had to be up, but Adora knew she would not close her eyes. Even with Catra purring beside her, she lay awake, watching the shadows.

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Bright and early, they took their skiff out and headed towards the Horde Territory.

Adora crossed her arms, her voice edged with frustration. “I still don’t understand why it has to be you! Wouldn’t it be better to send She Ra?”

Catra kept her gaze steady on the road as she steered the skiff, her tone calm and measured. “Melog says it would be too hard to find you. It’s even possible that they wouldn’t be able to, if you ended up in the wrong pocket dimension, or time traveling or whatever.” She paused, her eyebrows drawing together as she glanced at Adora's face. “Really. It doesn’t always have to be you.”

Adora looked away, her chest tightening. She clenched her fists, her nails digging into her palms. All right, yes, that was completely reasonable. But the thought of something terrible happening to Catra and not being there to help gnawed at her insides. What was the point of her strength, her power? She was a relic from a time of conflict, a soldier with no more battles to

fight. Every day was a struggle to find meaning in a world that no longer needed her heroism.

They didn't talk much during the rest of the trip, each lost in their own thoughts.

It was a couple of hours past dawn when they arrived. Adora had not been back to the Fright Zone since the victory, although Catra had made a few day trips in the last few weeks.

The place was barely recognizable. Leaves and flowers grew out of every patch of dirt, and vines covered every wall. Children were playing on the newly grown grass across the once-bare parade ground. The streets buzzed with activity, and no one was wearing armor.

Some people waved at Catra, and some saluted. Catra returned the gestures with gracious nods and half waves rather than saluting. "I'm trying to get folks comfortable with me being a civilian," she said when she noticed Adora's quizzical face.

Scorpia and her council were doing a great job. In the months since their victory, a lot of the destruction that Adora had seen the last time she was here was cleaned up. Work crews doing either tear-down or construction were everywhere. Most of the random rubble had been bulldozed away, and the sky was clear.

It was so beautiful that Adora felt a lump in her throat.

Catra brought their skiff to park inside the Sanctum building (or whatever anyone called it now). They headed to Entrapta's new lab. The few people they passed acknowledged Catra but not Adora. That was fine. Adora had deliberately avoided wearing her red jacket, preferring to fade into the background.

Glimmer, Bow, Castaspella, and Micah were already in Entrapta's lab. "So you would really prefer a long skiff ride to teleporting?" Glimmer asked.

"Yep," Catra said easily. "Anyway, it's not that long when the woods aren't against you."

"Catra, I cannot tell you how grateful I am for this," Micah said, extending his hand.

Catra took it awkwardly and let go quickly. Handshakes were still new in the Horde. "Don't thank me until we've finished," she replied, nervously petting Melog.

Castaspella walked over from where she was talking with Scorpia. "Catra, the attempt alone is praiseworthy." She put her hands on Catra's shoulders. "Thank you."

Aunt Casta hesitated, then leaned forward, wrapping her arms around the shorter woman. Glimmer hugged her from the side. Adora could see Catra leaning into the affection and putting her arms around both women rather than pulling away. She was so proud of how far Catra had come.

Finally, the three broke apart, and Aunt Casta cleared her throat. "So what are we supposed to do now, Entrapta?"

"Melog will be directing the Portal, but they're getting the coordinates from Glimmer, Castaspella, and Micah. That will apparently take some concentration. Their psychic bond with Catra makes it so they can find her wherever she goes, no matter what happens," Entrapta answered cheerfully.

"How does that even work?" asked Scorpia.

"Oh! I'm glad you asked!" Entrapta said excitedly. "Well…"

"Ah, why don't we save the technical explanations for afterward?" Perfuma suggested gently. "I think everyone here would really rather get started."

"Yeah," Bow chimed in. "Although, I would love it if you explained it to me over lunch."

Entrapta’s face lit up. “Really?” she squeaked. “Emily!” she called to her ever-present bot. “Can you put that on my calendar?”

“So what do we have to do?” asked Adora, her voice unnaturally high-pitched, her hand cold and sweaty in Catra’s. “Let’s just get this over with.”

Catra squeezed Adora’s hand. “It’s okay. You don’t need to do anything.” She smiled reassuringly. “Just be here when I get back?”

“What does Melog need us to do?” Glimmer asked eagerly.

"Melog says you should sit," Catra said, “They say your minds should be calm and your thoughts flexible.” She rolled her eyes good-naturedly, “Hopefully, that makes sense to you.”

The three magic users nodded.

“Where does Melog want us to sit?” Micah asked.

Melog trotted around the eight-foot blast wall. Perfuma and Scorpia grabbed some chairs and brought them over. When the three chairs were placed to Melog’s satisfaction, Catra began going over what Melog wanted them to think about.

Adora drifted away since she had nothing to do here. She leaned against the wall, listening to Scorpia and Perfuma chatting happily with Bow while Melog gave the mission briefing through Catra to the three sorcerers. How could they be so calm?

Finally, Catra looked around for her. “Hey, Adora. We’re going to get started.”

All of them retreated behind the blast wall. Micah and Glimmer handed Catra a few letters and a little box. “Those should help you convince Angella you’re for real,” said Micah. “She saw my astral body but took me for a hallucination.”

Melog settled down on their hindquarters and emitted a small chirping mew. The three mages all sat and closed their eyes. After a moment, Adora thought her eyes were playing tricks on her, but the longer she watched, the more sure she became. A thick rope of magical energy formed in front of each of their chests. Glimmer's was mostly pearly white and lavender, but there were dark purple and black threads. Micah's was purple and black. Aunt Casta's was silver and gold, but again, streaks of darkness lurked under the light.

"Okay, Entrapta!" Catra called.

The space in the center of the room under a high arch glowed white, humming and crackling so loudly that Adora covered her ears, wincing away from the noise.

"Okay!" sang Entrapta from the controls. "It's stable!"

The energy emanating from each sorcerer penetrated the blast wall, going in one side and emerging through the metal. The three ropes of light twisted around each other like they were being spun into a single strand.

Melog and Catra walked around the blast wall, and Melog settled themselves down sphinx-like, emitting a soft growl that sounded like a single low note. The portal energy shifted and flared. The long rope of magic spun out into the portal.

"All right!" crowed Entrapta. "I've got it locked! It will close behind you, and we'll re-open it when Melog gives us the go-ahead."

"Wait!" Adora yelled over the noise, following Catra. "She's going to CLOSE IT? No one said anything about that!"

Catra hugged Adora hard and then kissed her. "I'll be back before you know it," she yelled into Adora's ear. "Melog can always find me."

Catra stepped away. "I love you!" she smiled and waved at Adora, then disappeared through the glowing white archway.

# Catching up

Chapter Summary

Catra finds Angella
Adora finds things she did not want to know.

Chapter Notes

Happy (Early) Summer Solstice in the Northern Hemisphere and Winter Solstice in the Southern.

Betaed By Doc

The place was exactly like Bright Moon. It had the same graceful arches, the same Moonstone Tower rising across the plaza in the distance, and the same burbling fountains. It was an exact copy—if Bright Moon were surrounded by an endless field of white in all directions.

The stone under Catra's feet felt solid enough, but she could see the edge. There was no horizon beyond it--just endless white. Quickly, she closed her eyes and breathed through the sensation. She dropped to sit on the ground, gripping the turf with her claws, feeling the solidity of the surface underneath her.

When she opened her eyes again, she cautiously raised them to stare straight ahead, trying to get accustomed to the sensation or at least imagine a horizon that didn't give her vertigo. The sounds of the place had a strange echoing quality—she could hear a fountain running, but she could not seem to triangulate where it was coming from. The scents were… *shallow* was the only word Catra could think of.

She opened her mouth to taste the information carried on the breeze, but that did not help. The odors of flowers, leaves, and water floated past her, but only the top notes reached her nose, leaving all nuance behind—she could smell green growing things

but could not tell what kind of plants. She could smell the water but not the minerals it contained.

The light fell strangely flat through the uniform white sky. These were not clouds; they had no contour. Moreover, even though no moons hung in the sky, it was as bright as a summer day in the Waste. Everything looked brand new and even more well-kept than the real castle, yet it seemed a thin shadow of itself, insubstantial. She felt as though it might disappear from under her. Like a dream, she couldn't wake from.

At that thought, Catra's vertigo reasserted itself, worse than it had in weeks, and she clutched at the ground again. She breathed slowly until it passed.

Melog had promised to get Catra close to Angella, but everyone agreed they had to be careful. Who knew how Angella would react to Catra showing up in the first place? Her presence could be a shock or, worse, a threat in the eyes of Glimmer's mother. Catra did not relish the idea of being vaporized on the spot if that was the case, so the plan was to try to announce her presence as unthreateningly as possible.

Slowly, Catra stood, carefully turning her gaze toward the center of Bright Moon so she would not have to look over any edges. She wished she could have brought Melog with her. Reaching into her pocket, she checked to make sure the little box with the earrings was still there. In her other pocket were the handwritten letters from both Micah and Glimmer.

The breeze changed direction and brought the first proper scent she had detected. A person, the scent was almost human but also sweet and floral: lilac and lavender on the top, green leaves and water lilies underneath. It was not unlike Glimmer's scent, only without the burnt sugar notes that were uniquely Glimmer. These undertones put Catra more in mind of ozone and petrichor.

Had Angella sensed Catra's arrival? Melog said the old queen's magic shaped the place, so it was possible that this whole place

fed back into her magical senses. Angella probably sensed the magical disturbance at the very least.

Catra turned in a circle, sniffing until she identified the scent's source. Fortunately, it led to the main building. Catra could cope with being inside a building far more easily rather than remaining outside under that endless white sky.

Following her nose, Catra went through the familiar silent halls until the doors to the queen's apartments loomed before her. That made sense.

Taking a deep breath, Catra knocked.

A little yelp came from within the room, and footsteps began approaching, but then they stopped and retreated. "You foolish woman," a voice muttered softly. "You know there is no one there."

Catra knocked again, louder this time, and called, "Hello? Your Majesty?"

Another yelp. The footsteps hurried to the door and ripped it open.

Catra had never seen Angella in person, but the images throughout the palace left Catra in no doubt that the tall woman was her target. Angella's hair was uncombed, and her gown looked like many of the sleeping clothes Catra had seen around Bright Moon. Just getting up might explain the dark circles under her eyes, but she also seemed very thin. She looked a little bedraggled compared to the portraits Catra had seen of her, but Catra supposed that she was lucky the woman was actually bothering to wear clothes. Who knew how two years alone might affect someone?

Angella looked down at Catra, her mouth hanging open for an instant before she snapped it shut. Her lips turned up at the corners as she stared, her eyes crinkling. "Well, this is interesting,"

she said. Something sad colored the amusement in her tone. “I haven’t seen a magicat in ages. I must be getting bored.”

Her eyes softened as she studied Catra. “So, real,” she breathed. “I suppose I knew it would come to this.

Micah warned Catra that Angella would probably assume she was a hallucination or a magical construct that amounted to the same thing.

“I’m not a hallucination; I’m real,” Catra said, even as she shifted under the woman’s scrutiny. “I’m here to take you home.”

For a moment, the woman went very still, her eyes wide. Then she shook her head and huffed a little laugh. “Yes, of course you are,” Angella said lightly, sounding like she spoke to a child playing pretend. “Well, would you like to come in? I was just going to make myself something. The staff is nowhere to be found, but I have been experimenting with my cooking.”

She gestured to Catra to follow her, but she kept glancing back as though to make sure Catra was still there.

“You see, I’m going mad here by myself.” Angella's laugh had an edge of hysteria. “I suppose such a solid hallucination as yourself is a bid by my subconscious to slow that process.”

She glanced back at Catra, her expression a mixture of curiosity and wariness. “But why now? And why you, I wonder?”

This was why Melog and Micah suggested closing the portal. It could take a while. No one expected Angella to get on board with this plan immediately. There would undoubtedly be some negotiating around the problem of imagined portals. If Angella’s magic created a portal because of her desire to leave, she would not know where it led. It could send her anywhere, including dumping her somewhere (in Entrapta’s words) incompatible with life. This uncertainty made it far too dangerous to trust a hallucination. Grabbing and pulling her through would probably cause her to defend herself magically, possibly incinerating anyone

who tried. Avoiding incineration was definitely a plan Catra could get behind. No, she had to convince Angella to come willingly.

“I’m not a bad cook if you're bored of your own cooking,” Catra said.

“A guest? Cook for me?” Angella laughed. “Perish the thought.” She shook her head ruefully. “Ah, well. At least this is an entertaining madness.” She beckoned Catra into her room. “Come, I’ll make us tea. Do you like croissants? I have gotten very good at them.”

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“Are you all right?” Bow asked a worried edge to his voice.

Adora jumped, not having heard Bow sneak up behind her. “I’m fine,” Adora said too quickly.

Bow raised his eyebrows.

“Okay,” Adora muttered. “Maybe I’m a little worried.” She wanted to pace but did not want to call attention to herself. Glimmer, Micah, and Castaspella were chatting animatedly. She did not want her issues to mar their happiness.

“It’s okay if you’re worried,” Bow said gently.

“You know what?” Adora said suddenly, needing to get out of this conversation. “I need to find the bathroom. I’ll be back.” She hurried from the room without looking back.

The whole building was different, filled with lush, chaotic beauty. The central hallway was open to the sky, with flowering vines blooming exuberantly, clinging to the walls, seeking the light filtering into the corridor through the open ceiling. Maybe they had decided to leave this part open to the sky on purpose, letting nature in to blend with the architecture. It definitely looked like one of Perfuma’s projects.

For a few minutes, Adora wandered aimlessly, grateful that the people she passed were not paying any attention to her. The last thing she wanted to do right now was talk to a stranger. She was so worried she felt sick.

The place was so changed that she did not even realize she was near the Black Garnet Chamber. Her feet automatically took her that way, even though she did not recognize it. The chamber was also roofless, and the Black Garnet sparkled and hummed with magic that was warm on Adora's face and hands.

Shadow Weaver's personal office and sleeping quarters were at the back of the room. Had Catra taken it over? Probably. It made sense that she would. The door was locked, but Adora took a chance and typed in a few of Catra's usual passwords. The third one she tried (Sh@dowW3Averisacunt) worked.

It looked like no one had been here since Prime's invasion. Neat and tidy, as though the occupant would return shortly, but a thin patina of dust covered every surface, and it had a vaguely musty, unused odor. The room was even sparser than what Adora remembered from when she spent time here with Weaver.

A large map printed on an eraser board hung on one wall. Notes in Catra's handwriting were scribbled on the edges. Towns and villages that the Horde had claimed were circled in black, and the ones still under Alliance control were marked in yellow. There were a lot of black circles.

On the desk were two baskets with stacks of folders and papers. A few papers with Catra's scrawled signature sat in the basket marked "out." The basket marked "in" held a stack of folders about three inches high. Curious, Adora picked up the top one, automatically flipping it open to the back to see the oldest piece of information.

**Casualty Report**

**Region: Northern Territories - Sector 5**

**Field Commander: Force Captain Thadious**

**Report Prepared by: Senior Aid In Field: L. Rendon**

**Engagement Details:**

- **Location: Greenhill Pass**
- **Opposing Force: Alliance Militia - 3rd Battalion**
- **Princess Involvement: She-Ra, Queen of Bright Moon**

Adora's breath caught in her throat. Reading this would probably be a terrible idea—she had never even looked at the casualty reports Glimmer received during the war. The thought stopped her cold. Why had she not done that? It made sense when Angella was alive that Adora would not take part in anything administrative, but after Glimmer's coronation, neither Adora nor Bow had even offered to help Glimmer with that stuff.

**Casualty Summary:**

- **Horde Casualties:**
    - **Killed in Action (KIA): 54**
    - **Wounded (WIA): 62**
    - **Missing in Action (MIA): 12**
- **Rebel Casualties:**
    - **Killed in Action (KIA): Estimated 50**
    - **Wounded (WIA): Estimated 25**
    - **Captured (CAP): 3**

The names and numbers of the Horde casualties were all listed. The wounded had their injuries next to their names. Adora glanced at the first few and then looked away again when she saw notes like " *Severe: Traumatic Brain Injury"* or " *Severe: Magical burn injuries.* " Her stomach ached, and she took a deep breath. She knew she should see this. She *needed* to see this.

Adora flipped to the bottom of the report to read the commander's notes. Some paragraphs were highlighted, and there were scrawled words in the margin. It reminded her of the way Catra used to take notes in class.

**Commander's Notes:**

**The primary cause of our losses was the direct engagement with She-Ra and Queen Glimmer, which resulted in significant casualties.**

Catra's scrawl beside the highlighted paragraph read, " *Too many units lost. Unacceptable. Need to reduce."*

She wrote in another ink color, " *Gen Order #27 Do not engage princesses without an energy weapon. Dead batteries=retreat."*

**Disturbingly, reports indicate that they appeared to be toying with soldiers, causing unnecessary suffering. Additionally, multiple soldiers who were captured and subsequently released have reported that Queen Glimmer threatened them with magical torture. These actions increased the number of casualties and created a pervasive sense of fear and demoralization among the troops.**

The note next to this paragraph said, " *Torture? = desperation? Shadow Weaver? Sparkles? Is Adora on board? DT--find out."*

**I am deeply troubled by the reports of this sadistic behavior on the part of the rebel leaders. This indicates that the new leadership has introduced a level of brutality that our troops are ill-prepared to face. Given the number**

**of soldiers who were caught and released, I can speculate that the rebels are using these tactics for the sole purpose of spreading terror.**

Catra's next note read, *"Let Kyle see this. "*

That made complete sense. It would upset Kyle, who would tell Rogelio. Before Adora defected, everyone knew Rogelio was the biggest gossip in the cadet barracks. Stories about the atrocities the Princesses committed would go over well—increasing outrage at the Princesses and making people far less likely to defect.

The Commander's report went on:

**We owe it to our soldiers, many of whom were only recently cleared for field duty, to ensure their well-being. Their bravery deserves our full commitment.**

This last paragraph was both underlined and highlighted. The note read, *"Thadious wins a lot. Popular with soldiers. Check his methods."*

A note underneath that read. *Useful. Visit the infirmary 1hr/week."*

Adora sat down on the bed, feeling a heaviness settle into her bones as though someone had turned up the gravity. The little bit of sleep she got last night was not enough. She curled up on her side and buried her face in the pillow, hoping to catch the barest hint of Catra's scent.

All those names and numbers. Each one was her fault. Each life she took or destroyed. How was she supposed to live with that?

# Waiting

Chapter Summary

Micah and the rest hold a tense vigil as they wait for Catra and Angella's return.

Thanks to my lovely betas, Doc and Ktailbone

Micah paced the lab, trying to calm his mind. Since Melog had shown Micah that Angella was alive, he could hardly eat or sleep, knowing she was alone. He couldn't bear the thought of his wife living like that for a moment longer than necessary.

How long had Catra been gone? The minutes ticked by. Adora left to take a walk, but Micah couldn't imagine going anywhere. Scorpia sent lunch, but he couldn't eat, though he did pour himself a glass of wine. Glimmer was no better; she put food on her plate at Bow's entreaties but left it untouched.

They all fretted over the same question: What if something went wrong?

Micah glanced at Glimmer as she anxiously picked at her plate, seemingly caught between hope and anxiety. He stood by his decision not to mention this endeavor to her; he did not want to give her hope that might prove false.

Hope was fragile, and Micah knew better than to put faith in it. Ironically, it had been Light Spinner's teachings that kept him alive all those years on Beast Island.

In his exile, Micah had done as his once-mentor had taught him as a boy. "Hope is a trap," she said in that hypnotic voice of hers. "It torments with false promises."

Once, he had asked her what he should do without hope

Her voice dropped to a whisper, and he had to lean forward to hear her. "You must accept what is. Analyze the problem. Stay calm and plan." She had taught him to break the overwhelming into small steps. To take bold actions with careful planning. He had paid for those lessons in blood and tears, but they served him well there.

After seeing others banished to the place and watching them all give in to the Signal, he saw that Light Spinner had been correct. People would arrive on the island strong and optimistic, but every time their hope was crushed, they broke a little more. The more certain they were of escape or rescue, the faster they fell into despair.

Determined he would survive, Micah gave up on hope, gave up on tomorrow. He dedicated himself to the now and committed entirely to the process of survival. He surrendered his fear of death, embracing pain and pushing through it, but also allowing himself to see the beauty in the world. A sunset, a warm fire, dew collecting on a spider web; he treasured those experiences. When merely keeping himself alive did not take up every minute of his time, he invented new spells or meditated for hours. Sometimes, he let his spirit wander free. Sometimes, he meditated on the structure of magic and the interplay of Etherian magic with the First One's tech. The more occupied he kept his mind, the less power the Signal had over him.

That was how he lost track of so many years—tomorrow only existed in the abstract. Even now, he could feel himself pulling that cloak of acceptance around him. All the experiments, all the planning, all the effort—everything he could do, he had done. It would be enough, or it would not. He could not afford to hope. What would happen would happen. If this failed, his daughter would need him.

One anxiety he could never entirely banish, although it was far down the list—really, it should be the least of his concerns, still crept into his head and wouldn't leave him alone. What if Angella didn't want him anymore? When he was trapped on Beast Island,

he automatically shoved it aside anytime that unbearable thought crossed his mind. Rather than hope, he had firmly fixed in his mind that he needed to get through each day. The memory of her sweet face was the only thing that kept him going the whole time he survived on Beast Island.

Regret gnawed at him for all the moments he had missed. The times when Angella needed him, and he hadn't been there. In his saner moments, it seemed impossible that she would not have moved on. However, the stories everyone told him held that Angella was not interested in anyone else. She even stopped going to events that called for a partner. Micah was not sure how he felt about that. Would he have forsaken having a relationship for all that time if it had been Angella? Especially since he was presumed dead.

Adora had given Micah the bare bones of the story, and he could see how she held back. The subject was too painful for Micah to probe. Bow had told him a few more details, but the young man had confirmed there was more to it. Bow shared what Adora said: that the Queen had charged her with taking care of Glimmer.

Hearing how Angella had sacrificed herself to close the portal shattered his heart, even as it made him proud. If it had not been for how much he wanted to see his daughter, Micah would have probably not survived the war, but the thought of leaving his baby girl (even though he knew she was almost twenty) without a parent had caused him to be more cautious than otherwise.

Could he be the husband and father they needed after everything he had endured? Was he strong enough for that? Since the war ended, Glimmer had shown herself to be more than capable of running things without him. Much more capable than he.

Melog had also been pacing, but now they settled in front of the blast shield, their eyes half-closed, watching the space where the portal would appear. The urge to pester the creature, to demand to know what was happening, was strong, but Micah shoved it

down, purposely turning away to pour himself another glass of wine.

The point was moot; without Catra to translate, conversations of any complexity with Melog were impossible. The magical creature conveyed a great deal of information and communicated reasonably well by pushing ideas, feelings, and sometimes a word or two through some kind of telepathy into Micah's head, but one could not discuss the complexities of magical theory that way. It was also likely that Melog would lose track of Catra if they tried that kind of communication now.

Like Adora, Catra always seemed reticent and nervous in his presence. Still, when it became evident that she would be needed to translate, she pushed aside whatever qualms she had and threw herself wholeheartedly into the project. Speaking with Melog through her felt a little strange since she had to translate conversations full of esoterica, magical abstracts, and jargon. However, she had an endlessly curious mind and quickly went from merely translating to asking insightful questions. Not so much about the magical theories but more about the logistics and execution of the plan. Catra brought Entrapta in on the project and arranged to use Entrapta's lab. After that, the plan came together in a matter of days.

Micah felt a strange kinship with the Horde girl and mentioned it to Castaspella one night.

"Of course you do," Casta had replied, her tone a little tight. "Don't you remember? She was Shadow Weaver's pupil, too."

Belatedly, Micah recalled what Catra said about Shadow Weaver at the trial. Given the amount of new information he had been processing, it was understandable that he had forgotten that detail.

It explained much.

"Adora was the star pupil. The golden child." When Castaspella lifted her eyes from her knitting, they were narrow and angry. "Catra was the Distraction." She looked back down, and her knitting needles clicked sharply together as she continued. "You know. The Disappointment."

A soft, high-pitched sound jarred Micah from his musing, and he spun around to see that Melog had flopped over onto their side.

"Melog? Are you all right?" Bow asked, sounding alarmed.

Castaspella hurried to the creature's side, and Glimmer and Micah crowded in close. The creature still breathed, and its color did not change, but it showed no response to Casta when she shook their shoulder and lifted a paw. The sorceress pinched an ear—still nothing.

"Melog?" Hesitantly, the sorceress pulled back Melog's eyelid. The great cat's response was a little chuff, and they pulled away, half rolling over onto their back.

"What happened?" Glimmer breathed, staring wide-eyed at Catra's guardian.

"I-I don't know." Castaspella shook her head and looked at Micah, her eyes wide and worried. "They appear asleep, but I don't understand why I can't wake them."

Melog stirred again, their paws twitching in a dream. Then, they began to purr.

"A spell?" Bow asked.

"I can check." With a flick of his hand, Micah cast a cantrip to detect foreign magic—merely a quick and dirty diagnostic.

Nothing.

"Don't depend on it, though," he cautioned. "It's possibly a false negative."

Casta nodded briskly. "It's also possible that they are being affected by something that has happened to Catra."

"Where's Adora?" Glimmer looked around as though just now realizing the other girl was gone.

Bow rubbed the back of his neck, looking unhappy. "She said she was going for a walk a while ago. I thought she'd be back by now."

"I'll find her!" warbled Entrapta. "Oh, it's fine. The computer says her communicator is in Catra's quarters."

"I'll go get her!" Glimmer blinked out.

"Entrapta? When are you supposed to open the portal next?" Casta called. They had set it up so that Entrapta would open the portal right next to Catra (since Melog could find her) for ten minutes two hours after she left.

"In another half hour."

All right, they had half an hour to figure this out. If Melog was unconscious, would they be able to find Catra?

Tiny windchimes announced that Glimmer had returned.

"What happened?" burst out She Ra the minute she and Glimmer blinked in. "Oh, no," she muttered, seeing the downed big cat. She looked anxiously around at the others. "Do you think I could try healing them?"

"I don't see why not," Castaspella said encouragingly.

She Ra knelt beside Melog, and her hands glowed bright gold. Everyone held their breath. Melog glowed a bright blue, then surged up from the floor, its mane and tail dark red and jagged. They turned towards Entrapta, who sat by the controls.

Entrapta's eyes widened, and she sputtered as if choking. "Ooo-kay. Sure!" she squawked.

Whisking around toward the rest of them, Melog charged into the portal's space and vanished. A sphere of bright white magic flared and went out.

"Entrapta!" cried She Ra, following after them into the portal space, sword in hand. "Get that portal open! I'll follow Melog!"

"Um. I hate to disagree." Entrapta sounded very uncomfortable. "But, uh, I *think* Melog just told me not to. They told me to keep to the schedule."

She Ra looked as though she wanted to argue, but then something flickered behind her eyes. The next second, she had shivered away, leaving Adora looking despondent. "B-but…"

Micah exchanged a look with his sister. They had discussed this before—Adora's tendency to fling herself recklessly into dangerous situations as if She Ra were invincible.

Glimmer put her hand on the taller girl's shoulder. "No. Melog's right," she said softly. "Whatever's going on, they seem like they want to handle it themselves."

Adora did not even speak, burying her face in Glimmer's shoulder, uttering one quiet sob. Glimmer led the other girl over to sit in the chairs near Entrapta.

No one spoke. Adora stood and began to pace. Bow scooted over to Glimmer and put his arm around her shoulder. Casta sat, pulling a knitting project from her bag. Entrapta studied her computer screen.

Micah wanted to scream and punch walls. No, he wanted to tear down walls with his bare hands, to blast magic into the portal until it returned Catra, Melog, and Angella—anything to break the silence."

But he could not even bring himself to speak.

After an eternity, a small alarm pinged. "So, uh, that's the timer," Entrapta said. "Are we doing this now, or..?"

"Now, Entrapta!" Adora snapped. She bowed her head, reaching out with her hand. The air sparkled, and the sword appeared. With one blinding flash, She Ra stood where the girl had been.

"Okay!" Entrapta's delighted cackle rang out as the lights dimmed a little and then went out. It did not matter because bright white light glowed in the center of the chamber.

Micah heard the sound of the generator spinning up. The combinations of Horde tech and magic made for a much safer power source than either alone, Entrapta had said. Micah vowed he would learn more about Entrapta's particular brand of sorcery one day. For now, he just had to trust her.

Finally, the portal shimmered into existence, a bright white circle that pulsated with energy. Everyone in the lab held their breath. Micah's heart pounded as he watched, willing Angella to step through.

Two paws, Melog's head, then their body. Catra clung to them, her hands fisted in their mane, her body prone on the creature's back, her head between their shoulder blades. Melog stumbled as though exhausted. Micah could see the strain in their movements as they fought to stay on their feet.

Glimmer let out a gasp, taking a step forward. "Catra! Where's—"

But Catra's eyes were unfocused, and she swayed, leaning heavily on Melog as she struggled to push herself upright. "Sparkles," she murmured, her voice barely audible. "Hey."

Micah's heart sank. He scanned the portal's shimmering surface, desperate for any sign of Angella. The seconds felt like hours.

"Angella?" Micah whispered, his voice breaking. "Did she—"

Catra looked around, a little more alert. "She... she was right behind us... I think..." Her eyes darted back to the portal, which flickered rapidly, the edges starting to fray. Melog growled softly.

The portal's light cast eerie shadows across the lab. It flashed and flickered—it looked like it might close altogether. The generator noise reached a higher pitch, and the portal strobed, making every movement appear far too slow.

Catra slipped off Melog's back and then collapsed to her knees. She threw her hand up to protect her eyes. "I-I don't know if she..." She struggled to her feet. "Maybe I can…" Catra took a step back toward the portal.

"Noooo!" shrieked She Ra, dashing across the room and catching Catra around the waist, holding her back from the dangerously flaring conflagration. "You can't!"

Micah took a step forward. A silhouette appeared in the shimmering void. It was faint, almost ghost-like, but unmistakable.

The machinery gave a final, violent shudder, a flare of blinding magic, and then the room was plunged into darkness.

# Afternoon Tea

Chapter Summary

Catra and Angella have tea.

Chapter Notes

Thanks to my beta's Doc and Ktailbone

"Well, we are fortunate." Angella gracefully placed a tea tray on the table. "I found this in the kitchen." On the tray were soup, sandwiches, and cake.

"You found this?" Catra raised an eyebrow, puzzled by Angella's rueful smile.

"The magic often produces surprises. I suppose it's because I like them," Angella said, sitting down and serving. "Or perhaps it's not so much that I like them as I desperately need novelty." She held up the milk jug. "Do you like cream in your tea?"

Catra nodded, watching Angella pour, and carefully took the delicate cup and saucer. The tea was different from what Scorpia made, but not drastically so. The scent was shallow—menthol, tannins, maybe something spicy—but nothing substantial enough to identify. Angella smiled at her over the rim of her cup.

It was good. Warmth spread through Catra's stomach, and a slow ball of relaxation seemed to push out from her belly. It didn't take long for the whole cup to be gone.

She put down the cup, and Angella helpfully poured both of them more. Catra wondered if Sparkles knew how to make this. It was amazing; even though the scent was less complex than it should be, the taste made up for that. The second cup went down as easily as the first.

The room looked exactly like the ones in Bright Moon but eerily pristine, almost sterile, as though everything had been turned out of the factory yesterday. A little fountain burbled in the corner; otherwise, the place would be silent. There were no barely audible sounds of movement from the next room, nor any scents of people other than Catra and Angella. The solitude pressed down like a physical sensation. How had Angella managed to keep her sanity?

Trying to mask her sudden uneasiness, Catra picked up a pillow from the chair and put it on her lap. In Mystacor and Bright Moon, she often did that with the weird loose cushions strewn around the place. Almost every piece of furniture had them. Most of them had interestingly textured cloth, and she loved to wrap her arms around the softness.

Sipping on her own tea, Angella silently watched Catra. Her eyebrows slowly rose, and her frown deepened.

Catra wondered what the other woman was looking at but could not think of a way to ask without sounding hostile.

"Oh. Oh my. I did not expect that," Angella murmured, sounding like she was speaking to herself. More loudly, the woman asked, "Catra? How do you feel?"

"Mrrrp?" The inquisitive trill that tumbled from her lips surprised Catra as she dug her claws into the pillow. Bow would probably call her cute if he heard it. Would that be so bad? Catra turned the thought around in her brain. Did it matter? Bow had never been anything but kind to her, and he seemed to mean it affectionately. Maybe it didn't matter. Melog always told her that he didn't mean anything by it.

The fabric on the cushion in her lap distracted her. Much like her fur, it felt smooth when she stroked it one way and caught on her fingertips the other. What had Aunt Casta called it? Velvet. That was the word. Burying her claws in the thick cushion, she kneaded it absentmindedly.

When Angella spoke, Catra only heard mumbling, but the meaning of her words belatedly penetrated.

"I'm good," Catra said, her eyes half-closed as she enjoyed the pleasant stretch of her claws. "Wait…" It took her a second to realize what she was doing in front of Angella.

With great self-control, she put aside the ruined pillow. Her head was foggy and slow, and everything had taken on a soft focus. She blinked, trying to clear the static. "Did you… just… What was in that?" she asked, a slow realization dawning, but she could not summon much outrage. She peered at the other woman, feeling confused. Angella had drunk just as much as Catra had, but her eyes seemed just as bright and acute as when they started.

"Ah, yes. I'm sorry about this," Angella said apologetically. "Do you enjoy catnip?"

"Catnip?" Catra asked. "Sorry, I was raised by the Horde." She lifted one hand, made an O with her thumb and forefinger, and looked through it at Angella. "I've never heard of catnip before."

"I see. Well, it's intoxicating for cats and magicats. For full humans, it's merely relaxing." Angella looked a little contrite. "I thought it might help move the conversation along if you were real."

"Hmmmm," muttered Catra. The sound felt good in her throat. "Hmmmmmmmmm." Angella's answer did not make a lot of sense. The word intoxicating caught her attention. "What d'you mean?"

"On the off chance that you may not be a product of my imagination. I didn't want to spend the afternoon playing games, Catra of the Horde." The Queen's voice had gone hard, and Catra wondered if she should be afraid.

"So, I could be real?" That probably meant they were making progress, and Catra grinned at Angella. Another thought occurred

to her. "Why not just do a truth spell?" Catra waved her hand vaguely at the teacup. "Instead of this?"

Angella sighed irritably. "Because I don't trust my magic not to tell me what I want to hear. The truth spell can be tricky—you'd tell me what you believe. Therefore, I asked the magic to provide a way to verify your story, which would only work if you were real. It will wear off in a few hours. Assuming I am still not creating this in my mind. But the magic is fairly good at producing what I need if I am specific."

"Does your magic have opinions too?" The thought was funny to Catra, and she laughed.

"Only my own, generally," Angella said dryly. "Now, to business. Why are you here?"

"Because we wanted to get you back for Sparkle's and Arrow Boy's wedding. I guess that's a whole big thing?"

"Who?"

Catra laughed again, remembering that Angella would not have heard those nicknames. "Glimmer and Bow."

Angella's eyes narrowed. "You expect me to believe…?"

"Pffft. I don't, actually. You'd be stupid to." That was not what she had intended to say, but the catnip removed Catra's filter as thoroughly as a truth spell. "But since Melog can always find me, I'm the one who can do this the safest." Something in that sentence sounded wrong. "The safest? Most safely?" No, she still sounded wrong. "I won't get lost in a pocket dimension forever."

Intoxicating? It reminded Catra a little of whatever Aunt Casta had given her for pain while cleaning the wound on her neck. She had business to attend to, though. "How long will I feel like this?" She was so relaxed she could melt into a puddle.

Angella went back to looking amused. "It wears off fairly quickly."

"How quickly?" asked Catra vaguely. "Adora's going to lose her shit if I take too long."

"I wouldn't worry, my dear," the woman said soothingly. "We have nothing but time if you'd like to nap."

A nap sounded fantastic. The chair she sat on was one of those big winged ones with the squishy pillows Sparkles liked. She could curl up right here.

Sparkles. That reminded her of something. Catra reached into her pocket. "Here. I brought you some messages." She yawned as she handed them over. "And this." She pulled the box out and put it on the table. "Just give me a few minutes. Okay?" The tug of sleep was irresistible. She closed her eyes.

A few minutes (or hours later—time had become a fluid concept), Catra woke up to see Angella staring at her, pale as death, clutching one of the letters.

"What is this?" the Queen demanded, brandishing the letter. "This... this letter is from Micah? That's impossible! He's dead. How dare you bring me this forgery?"

"He's not dead," Catra mumbled, rubbing her eyes. "He was shipped to Beast Island. Adora and Bow went and rescued him and Entrapta."

"Indeed?" Angella scoffed, her eyes narrowing in suspicion.

Catra wriggled around to turn herself right side up in the chair. "Yeah. Hang on." She made it on her second attempt and shook her bangs out of her eyes. "He's been living in Mystacor."

Angella's hands trembled as she looked down at the letter again, but her tone was steel. "You were Hordak's second-in-command. You laid siege to Bright Moon and kidnapped my daughter. You threw the switch that created this place. How do I know this isn't a trick?"

"Well, really, you don't." Catra took a deep breath. "But things have changed. There's a peace treaty between Bright Moon and the Horde. I'm the Horde Ambassador to the Princess Alliance."

Angella's eyes widened in disbelief. "A peace treaty? Ambassador? How is that possible?"

Catra gestured vaguely in Angella's direction. "After you disappeared… Well, you know, things happened. Prime invaded. Occupied the place. Kidnapped Sparkles—Glimmer and me. So, like, I decided to do one good thing. I saved Glimmer. Prime…" She trailed off, suddenly unsure. "Prime took me prisoner."

What was happening? Catra's head felt fuzzy and strange. The light was white and thin, casting no shadows. The featureless sky through the open window was an endless white void. Eventually, Prime's light would consume the stars themselves.

No, no, no, no! This was real. Prime was dead, for fuck's sake.

But Catra could not feel Melog's subtle presence in her head, and everything had a patina of wrong clinging to it like scum. This had to be one of Prime's fake realities. Catra was still on his ship. She was still on his ship, and any second now, Angella would shatter into green light and his laughter. He let her make up everything, didn't he? He let her fantasize about how the peace would go. How else could she explain all the people so bafflingly kind to her? Prime was endless and eternal. How could she think…?

"Catra? Catra?" Angella was leaning over her, shaking her by the shoulders. "Can you look at me?" The Queen's voice was low and gentle. Her concerned face softened when Catra met her eyes. "Are you all right?"

Catra opened her mouth to respond, but no sound came out. Her vision blurred, and an electric blue flashing triangle appeared in the lower left-hand side of her field of vision.

"You seemed lost in thought, and then you went completely still for about a minute. Are you back now?" Angella asked, sounding

worried.

Catra's cheeks were wet. Shit. "S-sorry." She cleared her throat and wiped her eyes.

"Do you think you can continue?" The tall woman spoke gently and patted her hand. "Who is this Prime?"

"I-I..." Catra shook her head. "I'm not going to talk about Him right now," she told the woman firmly. "But let's just say he was a lot worse than Hordak. And he nearly destroyed Etheria."

Angella nodded. "Of course, dear." She sat back down in her own chair.

"So, yeah. Adora saved me. She Ra got rid of…" Catra bit her lip. "Him. We saved Etheria." Someone could fill Angella in on the details when they got back. "And then we had to find a way to move forward," Catra sighed. "Cause honestly, everyone is just super tired of fighting." The adrenaline of her little panic attack was leaving her, and Catra felt every iota of that weariness.

Angella looked back at the letter, her fingers brushing against the paper, her expression longing. "Micah says here that you're the only one who could safely find and return me. He mentions things only he and I would know. But it seems far too good to be true."

Catra nodded—that was understandable. "Yeah. Um. I keep thinking that all the time." The feeling that this was all much too good hit Catra every day.

Once again, Catra looked around the room, trying to immerse herself in the solidity of the things around her. Only this time, they did not appear nearly as solid as she needed them to be. The insubstantial light and the thin scents made everything feel fake, like the cardboard decoys Catra used to make their skeleton crews seem more threatening. Or perhaps this was a sandcastle on the beach. Some delusion she had lost herself in.

Catra's breathing sped up, and she wondered if Melog could feel it. They always seemed to be able to keep track of her, even when she could not feel them.

"Catra?" Angella said cautiously, "You are doing it again."

"Doing..?"

"You've been silent and still for a good thirty seconds. What is happening?"

"How am I supposed to know?" Catra hissed. "You're the one that fucking poisoned me!" She felt sick, her vertigo returning in full force.

"I did not poison you. Catnip should not have this effect," Angella protested. "Tell me what you feel like?"

"Nothing's real," Catra whispered. "Like if I give something a shove, my hand will go right through it." Her hands shook, so she hugged herself, closing her eyes tightly. "Everything feels like a bad simulation. Nothing looks right or feels right or even smells right."

There was a rustling noise, and then Angella's hand clasped Catra's, real and solid. "Can you look at me, my dear?"

Slowly, Catra opened one eye and then the other. Angella had dragged her chair close so she could hold Catra's hand. The woman's scent was what Catra would expect: different odors signaling shifting emotions that could be read as plainly as the worried frown on the woman's face surrounded her.

Angella held her gaze and squeezed her hand, grounding her. "I can see how upset you are," she said softly. "Let's take this one step at a time."

Catra nodded, trying to steady her breathing. The room still felt slightly off, but Angella's solid presence helped. "I... I know it sounds ridiculous. But Micah is alive."

"I want to believe you, Catra," Angella said. "I do. But…" she trailed off and looked away, biting her lip.

"I know," Catra replied softly, remembering when Adora had rescued her from Prime and her utter, unshakable conviction that the rescue was one of Prime's tricks. The war had been over for months, but Catra kept getting caught up in the feeling that everything was fake. "Look, let's assume I am real. Would even being caught by the Horde be worse than this?"

Angella's eyes narrowed as though struck by a thought. "It is possible that you would use me as leverage against my daughter."

"No. We don't want to do that." Catra could not think of anything to support her words. Although she was not as confused, her head still felt funny, and her thinking sluggish. A headache was beginning to form behind her eye. For some reason, she felt a little like crying. "I told you. Scorpia's in charge of the Horde now. I'm just an ambassador." She sniffed, feeling like everything was somehow insurmountable. Why couldn't she get her shit together? Why did everything seem so difficult right now? "Anyway," Catra snarled. "I thought this shit was supposed to tell you if I was lying or not?" She made a sharp gesture at the teacups.

Catra's vision seemed to blur—or maybe it was not blurred, but something was wrong. A bright, electric blue flashing triangle appeared in the lower left-hand side of her field of vision. She wanted to scream at Angella.

The other woman's eyebrows reached her hairline. "Catra? You don't look well."

Probably because this insta-headache with its flashing lights was driving a nail through Catra's head, she tried to speak, but her tongue felt thick and uncooperative. "I… I'm fine," she finally gasped, shoving her chair back from the other woman. She tried to speak again, but the words felt tangled and foreign. Sounds fell from her mouth, but they had no shape.

As she tried to navigate through the fog in her brain, a bright white circle appeared in the air next to Catra. With a roar, Melog leaped through the portal, their form almost as big as Angella. They showed their teeth to the old Queen, who backed away, her eyes wide.

Mane and tail pitch black with fury, Melog snarled. "Granddaughter?" The single word was enough to shove one question into Catra's mind. "*Do I let her live?*"

"Yes! It's fine!" gasped Catra, knowing Melog would understand what she meant. She staggered to her feet and threw her arms around their neck.

"This place is not healthy for you," Melog growled deep in their throat. "You will come home."

The headache abated somewhat with Melog's presence and the physical contact, but they were right. Between the weirdness of the place and Angella drugging her…

Melog's growl went down an octave as they caught the thought. They turned toward Angella again and growled. "What was it?" they asked Catra without ever taking their eyes off Angella.

"Uh. Catnip?" said Catra. "That's what she said it was."

That made Melog turn their head. Ceasing their growl, they sniffed at Catra and then walked around her to sniff the teapot. They shook their head, prowling around the room.

"What is that?" Angella whispered, her eyes following it.

"That's Melog," Catra said.

Angella whipped her head around to look at Catra. "Say that again?"

"That's Melog," Catra repeated. The words felt wrong in her mouth, as though they were somehow the wrong shape. It was as

if the muscles of her mouth could not work. Or perhaps the wires that connected her brain to her lips were loose.

Angella knelt in front of Catra, taking both of her hands. "Did you hit your head today?" the old Queen asked, alarmed.

Puzzled, Catra shook her head. Although, maybe? Her head certainly hurt enough for it, and she could hardly keep her eyes open from the light. She would have remembered hitting her head, wouldn't she?

"Why?"

That felt wrong. And it sounded wrong. The syllable from her mouth resembled a grunt more than a word. Freaked out, Catra called, "Melog?"

It seemed they understood her. "Granddaughter," they said, sounding irritable. That was better than the fury they had come with. "This plant was grown in this place?"

"She said it just appeared in the kitchen."

Their tense muscles relaxed, and their jagged black mane smoothed, although it did not reach its normal, serene blue. Nonetheless, they snarled as they said, "The Old Queen is fortunate. It is an honest mistake, and her blunder will do no permanent harm."

The white portal flared again, but no one else stepped through. Entrapta had said she was okay holding the portal open for ten minutes at a time. Catra knew this was her moment to convince Angella.

"Listen," Catra began, her voice steadier now with Melog's support. "I get it sounds crazy, but really, Micah is alive. He gave me his earring. And Glimmer gave me hers. The one that matches. Where else could I have gotten them?"

"Trophies kept by Shadow Weaver, no doubt," Angella said coldly.

"No, look," Catra growled. "She's dead, okay?" The magicat thrust both her hands into her hair, grabbing it as she stifled the urge to scream. "Blew herself up. I was there." She let go of her hair and covered her eyes with the heels of her hands, hoping the darkness would help the pain in her head. No. That did not help. She dropped her hands to look at Angella's skeptical face. "Could I make up a story like this when you just drugged me? He's waiting for you back at Entrapta's lab. He misses you more than anything." Standing up, Catra swayed. Melog was in front of her instantly, supporting her so she could scramble onto their back.

Torn between hope and disbelief, Angella reached for the little box on the table, flipping it open and staring at the earrings inside. "But… how can I trust it?" Once again, she seemed to be talking to herself. "How do I know this isn't some trick? Why should I risk it? What if it's another trap?"

Desperately, Catra said, "Because you're going to lose your mind here. None of this is real." Her voice broke on the last word, and she drew a breath that was half a sob. Melog was right. This place was not good for her.

"You said it yourself." Catra gripped Melog's solid form with her knees just to ground herself. "Fuck. Let's say I am lying. Wouldn't a Horde cell be better than this?" She waved her arm to take in the room. "Don't you deserve to know the truth? If you come with me, you can see for yourself. If I'm lying, you're still back on Etheria rather than this place. But if I'm telling the truth… you'll get your family back."

Catra could not tell whether Angella believed her or not. She could think of nothing else to say. "Please, believe me."

That sounded far too much like begging, but Catra was past caring. She needed to get home before the sheer unreality sent her off the deep end. But she could not just leave Angella—Catra would never have the guts to come back.

Angella's eyes filled with tears, her resolve wavering. "Micah… he's really alive?"

Catra nodded. "Yes, he is. Please, Angella. Just come with me. See for yourself. What do you have to lose?"

Angella looked at the portal, then back at Catra, and finally at Melog. She took a deep breath and nodded slowly. "All right. I'll go with you."

Melog nodded approvingly. "Come, Granddaughter," they said, "I will take you home."

# Searching For the Good

Chapter Summary

Felina and Derrick talk.

Questions are answered.

Chapter Notes

Thanks to Doc for Beta-ing

Felina's com badge began steadily pinging with a high-priority alert, its insistent tone echoing in the lecture hall. Her instructor glanced at her and gave a quick nod before resuming the lecture on emergency ops. Almost everyone in this seminar was someone's aide, so those alerts were routine reasons to leave class. Officially, Felina was Ambassador Catra's aide, currently on loan to Princess Scorpia and the Council. Today was Felina's first time being summoned from class because Catra needed her.

When Felina checked her compad—an officer cadet perk—she saw a message from the computer in Ambassador Catra's quarters, saying the door had been accessed. Felina knew the ambassador had been in the Capital during the day for the past three or four days, but it was a classified project. Need To Know Only.

That was fine, but if the ambassador was going to be in residence, it was odd that no one messaged Felina directly. If Catra planned to stay in The Capital for more than the afternoon, her quarters would need to be aired, and fresh sheets would need to be put on the bed. The girl knew for a fact that if Catra had not thought to send a message, Princess Scorpia surely would have.

Perhaps Catra just needed a nap? If that were the case, Felina would have expected a "do not disturb" status on the notification. The computer log showed a password, rather than biometrics, was used to open the door, accompanied by the ominous record of three failed attempts. Maybe she sent someone to box up some

things? By rights, that should be Felina's task. The girl decided it was best to check it out, probably with some security backup, just in case.

Felina punched in Derrick's access code.

"Hello, Officer Cadet Felina. What can I do for you, ma'am?" he asked cheerfully. Derrick always used her full title when they talked on the comms. Sara said it was because he wanted everyone he worked with to know his stepdaughter was an officer cadet. It never failed to give Felina a warm feeling in her chest.

"Security Section Chief Derrick," she said formally. After all, he was on duty, and this was an official request. "Someone accessed Ambassador Catra's quarters, and she didn't contact me. There were three failed password attempts before entry. I need to check it out now. Would you come with me?"

"Happy to, ma'am," Derrick said genially. "Meet you at her quarters?"

They arrived in the Black Garnet chamber at the same time. Derrick led the way through the chamber to the doors at the back. As the door slid open, Derrick called, "Ambassador?" He stuck his head in, sniffing the air with a furrowed brow. "It's definitely not her," he muttered, the tension in his voice palpable. "In fact, it smells like…." He trailed off and glanced at Felina before he called, "Adora? Ma'am? Are you here?"

"Who is it?" called Adora from behind the partition that separated the bed from the rest of the room.

"Excuse us, ma'am," Felina said. "It's Felina and Derrick. I got a ping from the computer that someone had accessed Ambassador Catra's quarters, so I came down to check. Do you need anything?"

"Oh, no, thanks!" Adora came around the corner. Her eyes were red and puffy, and she smelled like tears. A few strands of hair hung out of her ponytail.

They both snapped to attention and saluted her. Adora returned the salute, her scent thick with nerves. "As you were," she muttered, her cheeks red. "It's good to see you. You look good!"

Felina knew they both looked a lot better than the last time Adora had seen them. Felina had cut her hair short and was wearing a newly issued uniform. Derrick was likewise in a new uniform, his insignia showing that he was now a security specialist rather than a gunner. He had started to grow a bit of a beard and kept his horns freshly oiled.

"We're doing well, ma'am," Derrick said, grinning at Adora as if genuinely pleased.

Felina schooled her expression into a mask of pleasant neutrality, though her dislike for Adora made her stomach churn. "Are you comfortable, Princess? Are you and Ambassador Catra in need of… ahh!"

There was a high-pitched sound like little bits of metal striking each other, and then an explosion of sparkles made Felina jump back with a hiss in time to see Queen Glimmer appear out of the air.

"Sorry!" the woman exclaimed to the room. "Adora, there's a problem." She grabbed Adora and disappeared.

Beside her, Derrick sucked in a startled gasp. "Damn," he whispered, shaking his head. "That… that's something."

Felina clenched her fists, her claws digging painfully into her palms as she tried to steady her racing heart. "Yeah. I never got used to it." She shook herself, trying to get the fur on her neck to lie down. "But didn't she teleport you? That's how you got to Spire, wasn't it?"

The big man nodded. "Yeah, but I never saw it from the outside." He chuckled nervously. "She does that a lot?"

"All the time. Like it's nothing."

"Yeah. It was weird for me, but your mom really didn't like it, and Catra was sick by the time we got back."

"What do you think I should do now?" Felina asked him, trying to dismiss the habits of Princesses from her mind. She had become friends with Princess Frosta during the peace negotiations but could never overcome her instinctive fear and dislike of the other princesses. "Do you think I should clean the place if the Ambassador wants to sleep here tonight?"

The room was tidy enough but had an air of disuse.

"That wouldn't be a bad idea." Derrick looked around the partition at the bed. "Maybe get some clean sheets for the bunk here, too. It probably would be a good idea to requisition another couple of pillows if Adora's staying here." He turned with a little smile. "You know, I heard Scorpia say that they were official now. Maybe we should give them some extra rations."

Felina frowned. The rumor had been making the rounds, but she did not want to believe it. However, if Derrick had heard it from Scorpia, it probably was true. She took a deep breath, forcing herself to calm down. Duty first. Emotions later. She tried to look enthusiastic. "Wow, they're official? That's great."

Derrick's eyebrows knitted, and Felina knew she wasn't fooling him. "You okay there, cadet?" he asked gently.

"Not really," she snarled. The idea of Catra being with Adora just seemed to be a complete joke. "How can Catra be with her?"

"Hey, I know you don't like Adora, but…" Derrick began.

Something deep in Felina's brain seemed to short out. "Fuck her. She's a fucking traitor. How can Catra even look at her?"

Derrick took a deep breath, looking at Felina with concern. "I get it, Felina. Believe me, I do. But everything's different now and…"

"How can you say that?" Felina interrupted, her fury suddenly boiling over. "How can you defend her? How can you say that after what happened to Mom?" The last word came out as a sob, and to Felina's shame, tears started down her cheeks.

Derrick sighed and pulled out the desk chair to sit on. "Hey, come here." He held out his arms, and Felina stepped forward to put her arms around his neck like she used to do when she was little and laid her head on his shoulder, her sobs getting louder.

For a few minutes, all Felina knew was Derrick petting her back as she cried like a baby. If it had been anyone but Derrick witnessing her tears, she would have been mortified, but after her father died, Derrick had always been there for her.

"You better now?" He asked when she finally pulled away.

"I'm sorry." She looked down at her feet, embarrassed. "I just…"

"Yeah, little soldier, I know." He reached over to scratch her ear. She leaned into the contact and purred. For a minute, he was quiet, as though thinking, and then he seemed to decide about something. "What has your mom told you about that battle?"

Startled, Felina looked into Derrick's serious eyes. "Just that She Ra threw the tank, and she got trapped under the console. That you ripped the thing apart to get to her and Markus." She looked down out of respect for the dead. "He was gone already."

"Yeah, I still miss him," Derrick said quietly. "We lost a lot of good people."

Soberly, Felina nodded. Part of the reason folks were so loyal to Catra was that she took as many soldiers as she could out of fighting with Princesses, leaving that to bots and tanks. The ordinary infantry was ordered only to engage if absolutely necessary.

"So, we were ordered to hold Dryl Pass as a diversion. We had three tanks, and our orders were to engage with She Ra and any

others who showed up with her. Catra had called back the majority of our forces."

Felina nodded, wondering where her stepfather was going with this.

"So, we're there, just hanging out, and your mom was keeping watch on the scanner. She told us we had incoming, and I got up in the turret with Chuck. Markus was driving." Derrick sighed and closed his eyes.

Felina could tell it was not easy for him to talk about it, and she had never heard this part of the story at all. Chuck had been killed by a laser blast from a clone after Prime's invasion.

Derrick opened his eyes and seemed to steel himself. "It was the first time I ever saw She Ra up close. It was terrifying, not going to lie. I got the first shot off and hit her square on. She… I don't know; she just took it as if she were indestructible. The other tanks took their shots with no effect."

"None at all?" gasped Felina, who sat on the floor to hear the story.

Shaking his heavy horns, Derrick said, "None. I'm just glad I saw the other hits because otherwise, I would've thought I missed or something."

"See, that's the part I don't understand." Felina huffed. "Couldn't she see that you were a skeleton crew? I mean, didn't that make it obvious that the pass was a diversion? Why did she engage at all?"

"Felina. She had her orders, the same as we did," Derrick said. "The Queen of Brightmoon was the one running the show. I never understood their ranking system, but…"

"She Ra is the Queen's second." Felina supplied.

"Okay. Huh. That's good to know." The big man paused, seemingly still baffled by how he had personally met these people.

Felina understood. Half the time, when he or Felina's mom said Catra had done their official sanctioning, people would look it up on the computer, only to be shocked that they weren't lying. The suspicion was perfectly justified. Regular folks just did not get sanctioned by Hordak's Second. They did not get teleported back home when they had what would have been an almost month-long hike. Nor did their daughters receive officer's commissions on Catra's personal order.

"So, yeah," Derrick went on, flicking his ear like a fly had landed on it. "She had no backup. Maybe it was recon, but their intel got our position wrong. Pretty sure she had no clue we were there until she was right on top of us. Once I got that first shot off, she had no choice but to fight. Our orders were to pursue if she tried to retreat. The objective was to keep her busy on the pass for as long as possible. We did not want her joining in the push to retake Dryl."

Despite herself, Felina felt saddened at the thought of facing a battle alone, with no one at your back. "But it's She Ra!" the girl exclaimed, lashing her tail. "You can't hurt her. What difference does it make if anyone's with her?"

Derrick sighed deeply. "It's not about whether she can be hurt. We could still corner her, and we outnumbered her. Marcus called for a coordinated attack."

Felina could easily imagine a Princess transfixed between three beams, unable to escape one without running into another.

"So, I aimed high and pretty much caught her in the tiara. I could tell it gave her a hell of a headache. The other two tanks were a lot further away than ours."

He swallowed and looked somewhere off into the distance over Felina's head.

"It was… "he stopped as though he had no words, but the terror in his voice and scent told Felina all she needed to hear.

"You don't have to…" Felina said quickly, suddenly stricken with remorse about all the times she had asked him to tell her war stories. He had only ever told her "safe for kids" stories. They were a broad idea of the war without ever getting gruesome or scary. In the end, the good guys always won, and the evil Princesses were defeated once more.

As she got older, Felina began to resent the coddling like all Horde kids did. Hearing what really happened with all the dirt and blood was a right of passage, but Felina was not quite sure she was ready for that.

"I hit her square with the beam. And anytime I lost my contact, the other beams kept her disoriented. Yeah, we couldn't hurt her, not really. But we could make her hurt, if you get what I mean?"

Felina rolled that around in her head. This would not harm She Ra, but she would be crazy with pain.

As soon as he saw the look of comprehension on Felina's face, he nodded, the fear in his scent mellowing to merely anxiety. "So she dragged herself over until she was close enough to rip the turret right off the tank and throw it aside. Chuck and I were thrown clear." Derrick blew a breath out of his nose. "She Ra flipped our tank to land upside down, blocking the other tank's beams. The tank took damage from them until the beams were shut off. It was only a second, but that's what killed Markus."

Derrick paused for a moment, and Felina stayed quiet, too.

"I heard your mom screaming and then… Well, you know the rest."

Felina nodded. "But, what did She Ra do?"

"She… walked away." Derrick's voice broke, and he cleared his throat. He chuckled, but it sounded ragged, and his brown eyes

were liquid with tears. "She-she let me save Sara. She just turned her back and stomped away, like the biggest, baddest, scariest case of malicious compliance I had ever seen. I will swear on my personal sidearm that she was bitching about her superior!"

"What?!"

"It was so weird. I had one eye on her as I got something to pry off the plating. She just walked away bitching about her mission; 'I kept the stupid pass. No invading troops, just a few tanks. I told her, but does she listen? Nooo! So, I'm playing *bait* again, but no one's biting. This is so stupid! Why can't she just listen?" Derrick mimicked She Ra's voice. "The sight of her walking off was the most beautiful thing in the world right then.

Felina's eyes narrowed as she tried to reconcile Derrick's words with her anger. "But she hurt Mom. How can I just forget that?"

A smile quirked one side of his mouth. "But she let me get Sara out. Don't you see? She had been ordered to keep the pass. That's all. She threw the tank because she was defending herself, and it made a handy roadblock. It would take hours to get some machinery in to move it. By then, it probably wouldn't matter. She achieved the explicit objective and then walked away when she judged the probability of a battalion hiding under a rock practically nil. By rights, she should have at least interrogated us. And there were six other soldiers there! She could have decided we were enough of a threat that she needed to continue to engage."

"What would you have done then?" Felina gasped.

Derrick shrugged. "I would have stayed, but the others would have retreated because we were out of battery by then. I wouldn't have had help getting Sara out and keeping her alive while we waited for evac." Derrick paused. "Maybe she's not as evil as you think she is. All I'm saying is I saw a spark of the Horde girl who will not kick an opponent when they're down. I saw that she still had some good in her, you know?

"So, I'm supposed to forget what she did to Mom?"

"I'm not asking you to forget, Felina," Derrick said gently. "I'm asking you to understand. Adora was doing her job, just like we were. And it's not really any of our business, but Catra sees something in Adora, something good. Maybe we should try to see that, too."

Felina looked down, her anger slowly giving way to a mix of confusion and frustration. "I... I don't know if I can."

"It's okay," Derrick said softly, placing his broad, callused hand on her shoulder. "It'll take time. We've all got things that keep us up at night."

Before she could respond, the lights flickered and dimmed, followed by the distinct hum of power failing and restarting. Felina and Derrick exchanged alarmed glances. "That's not good," Derrick muttered. He tapped his comm. "SC 8 to C&C?"

"Go ahead, SC8."

"Are you folks having power issues? We're in Ambassador Catra's quarters, and the lights are flickering."

"Affirmative, SC8. We're getting reports that the whole Capital is experiencing power surges. We haven't traced the source yet. Do you have any ideas?"

Felina felt a knot tighten in her stomach. "Entrapta's lab," she said urgently, putting her hand on Derrick's arm. "She's been working on something big with Catra. If there's a power issue, it might be affecting them."

Derrick's eyes widened. "Your mom's down there today," he told Felina, muting the link. He tapped the comm again. "Have you messaged Entrapta?"

"Yeah, we tried, but you know how she is."

"Yeah, I know." Everyone knew that Entrapta hardly ever answered a comm when she was working. "Have you tried to message any of her assistants?"

"We tried, but we can't get anyone on that level to answer."

Derrick's scent turned to pure fear, but his posture and expression hardly changed. "Copy that. I'll go check it out."

"Got it. Thanks. Do you want us to send some help?" the man on the other end grunted.

"Affirmative, C&C. Tell them to stage in the courtyard—I'll go see what's happening first."

"Copy: Units stage in the courtyard near Entrapta's lab. We've already let Princess Scorpia know."

"Thanks." Derrick looked at Felina. "You coming?"

"Absolutely," Felina replied, her voice firm. "If there's a problem with the lab's power, it could be dangerous. We need to make sure Mom and Catra are safe."

"Let's go," Derrick said, already moving towards the door.

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Stumbling through the portal into a dark, silent void was disappointing, though Angella had honestly expected it. She hoped her demise would not take long.

A split second after this thought drifted through her mind, a wordless, terrified shriek filled the air. Then, a babble of other voices began.

The sudden noise overwhelmed Angella. What was happening? Where had the portal brought her? She took two steps back, putting her hands over her ears. It had been so long since she had heard such noise.

A cacophony of voices joined in with the shrieking, and she only caught a few phrases here and there.

"Entrapta!" snapped someone. "What happened to the lights?"

"Glimmer!"

A communicator crackled, and tinny voices added to the chaos. "Power's out in half of the Capital. This door's stuck."

"Get out of the way, fools! Entrapta? Are you all right?"

"No, look, just calm down. Someone get me a Halligan bar. I'll open it."

"If you get it open a little more, I can get through. No one's answering."

The communicator cut out.

"Sorry! Sorry! Give me a minute!" Was that Entrapta?

"Sparkles! You're okay! Ow! Quit!" That sounded like Catra. "I think Entrapta just shorted something!"

"Catra!" The shrieking stopped but was replaced by tears. "Please, I can't…"

That was Glimmer's voice. Angella shook off her confusion. Wherever she was, whatever was happening, her daughter needed her. "Glimmer?" she called. "What is this place?" She summoned a small sphere of light.

The voices all went silent, and other spheres flared to life simultaneously. Angella froze with her mouth open, unwilling to believe her eyes.

Her daughter sat on the floor, her face awash in tears but surrounded by people. Tears immediately started down Angella's cheeks as she took in the people surrounding Glimmer. Bow,

Adora, and Castaspella sat or knelt gathered around her. One of the magical spheres belonged to Castaspella and floated over her head. Catra crouched beside Glimmer with the great magical beast beside her, still looking a little ill. Angella would have to apologize for that later.

The other magical sphere floated over the head of someone obscured by Catra's guardian's bulk. The man rose from his crouch until Angella could see him clearly, and she promptly forgot how to breathe.

She knew him. She knew those shoulders, those hands. She knew that hair and that beard, although they were streaked with much more silver than the last time she had seen them. She felt his powerful magic beating against her face like morning light.

*Micah.*

Catra had told her the truth. He was here. He was alive.

The whole universe disappeared, except this time Angella was not alone.

"Angella," he whispered.

She wanted to run to him, but she could make neither her legs nor her wings obey her. She just stood there, mouth agape.

"Angie." Slowly, like a man who suspected the evidence of his senses, Micah closed the distance between them and held out his arms.

"You," Angella breathed, looking down into his face as she wrapped her arms and wings around him. Angella had no words for the emotions rioting in her heart, so she merely stared into his glistening eyes.

Heedless of the crowd in the room and that they stood under bright lights in the sight of everyone, she bent and kissed him.

# Into Darkness

Chapter Summary

Derrick and Felina get into Entrapta's lab.

Chapter Notes

As always, thanks to Doc and Kurt_Angles_Tailbone for Beta-ing this chapter.\

Felina’s heart pounded as she and Derrick hurried towards Entrapta’s lab. Derrick tried to raise Sara on the comm several times but with no luck. “That whole level is having comm problems,” Derrick said, his voice strained as he tried to sound reassuring over the chaos in the hallways. Felina couldn’t tell if he was trying to comfort her or himself.

They had just set foot in the courtyard when the power went out and didn’t come back on. “Oh, fuck me. Seriously?” Derrick growled, frustration sharp in his tone. “SC8 to C&C? Come in!” Silence. “Damn it,” he grumbled. “Now the comm system is down, too.”

This was really not good.

Felina pulled her compad from her pocket and lit the flashlight, the beam cutting through the suffocating darkness like a knife. She wasn’t carrying a weapon, so this would have to do. And really, her claws were enough weapon on most days.

“Thanks,” muttered Derrick. “I’m sure your mom is fine,” he added, though his tone betrayed his own fears. “Get those emergency lights on!” he yelled at the security lead, who was waiting for orders. “We do not need people freaking out and getting trigger-happy.”

A sense of dread hung in the air. They set up the lamps across from Entrapta’s lab in a flurry. Everyone wore the same worried

expression--during Prime's invasion, the first thing to go was the power.

To Felina's surprise, Hordak paced among the guards, identifiable by his armor and the dark stone on his collar. Genuine fear replaced his usual stern expression. She averted her eyes quickly, not wanting to draw his attention.

"Hey, come with me." Derrick strode over to the doors of Entrapta's lab. Felina followed behind, Hordak close on her heels. "Can you do anything with this?" Derrick asked Felina, gesturing to the buttons beside the door.

Felina smiled a little and nodded. She had watched her mom access backup power on malfunctioning terminals a million times. She popped the clip that held the front of the gadget on and turned the little contact to face the battery.

"What is happening here?! Where is Entrapta? Why is this...?" Hordak's voice wavered. His words were hurried and higher-pitched than usual.

"Power's out in half of the Capital," Derrick huffed, irritation seeping through his controlled facade. "This door's stuck."

"Get out of the way, fools!!" He leaned over Felina's head and hit the "talk" switch. "Entrapta, can you hear me?"

"No, look. Just calm down," Derrick snapped, frustration evident in his tense shoulders. He shoved the Horde's former leader, sending him stumbling back from Felina. Before Hordak could respond with more than sputtering, Derrick yelled, "I need a Halligan bar. I'll open it." One of the security guards already had it and handed it to Derrick. He slipped the prybar end between the doors, and Hordak grabbed the very end of it. Both of them put their backs into it, and the heavy doors parted a few centimeters until there was a space almost big enough for Felina.

"No one's answering. I can't get through." The emergency battery for the comm seemed drained dry. Felina snapped the panel shut

and stood up. “If you get it open a little more, I can squeeze in there,” she told Derrick, gesturing at the narrow opening. “I’ll just go in and see if they’re all okay?”

Derrick nodded. “Be careful. Your mom will kill me if anything happens to you.”

“You can’t seriously send this child—” Hordak began.

“You sent plenty of kids to die,” Derrick growled, cutting him off. “Back the fuck off.”

Felina smiled a little, pleased that Derrick did not argue. He treated her like he treated Trevor. She might still be inexperienced, but Derrick treated her like a fellow soldier. Someone to be trusted.

Hordak stared at her for a moment and then glanced at Derrick. “Yes… you should be… careful. Do not… cause yourself injury.” It seemed as though he were reading from a script.

The two men pried the door apart another centimeter, and Felina slipped in. She had to open the inner door, but fortunately, that one was not locked.

The room was silent and dark. Felina could see several dim outlines of people. Some of their scents were familiar: Catra, Adora, Entrapta, Queen Glimmer.

First, one light, then two others flared to life. Felina felt her heart seize with terror. In the middle of the room, a group of people huddled on the floor, staring at every Horde kid’s nightmare. Tall with long hair and wings poised for flight, the woman’s terrible eyes seemed to have some sort of magical hold on the group.

One of the people cowering at her feet stood as if mesmerized and approached the woman with halting steps. She did not move until he was close enough for her to touch. Felina’s hand flew to her mouth as the woman slowly wrapped her arms and wings around the man. Nobody was doing anything to stop her. The

sharp smell of magic lingered in the air—clearly, the woman had bewitched them.

Thinking fast, Felina took a step back. She was only here for recon—she needed to get this intel back to Derrick. He'd report to Scorpia and...

"Mom!" cried one of the people on the ground. It sounded like Queen Glimmer. Yes, it was. She appeared at the woman's side and threw her arms around both the man and the woman's waist. That seemed to be a signal because every person in the room began speaking at once.

The din sounded happy, but it was so loud Felina could not understand the words.

The machinery hummed again as the lights flickered to life. The outer room doors opened, and the security detail poured into the chamber. The inside door banged open.

"Entrapta! Are you all right?" Hordak's voice demanded, striding past Felina to the console where Entrapta sat.

"I'm fine!" Entrapta crowed. "The experiment was a complete success!" She laughed maniacally. "And I have a brand new dataset about pocket dimensions!"

"Hordak!" the tall woman exclaimed, putting her hands over her mouth and stepping back. "What is he..? Why are we..? What is going on?"

The man and Queen Glimmer exchanged looks. "It's… a long story, Angie."

Catra stumbled away from the group of people, her hand against her forehead, leaning heavily on Melog. Felina was at her side instantly.

"Ambassador?" Felina asked.

Catra squinted at her. “Felina? Hey. Would you get someone to get Scorpia? I think we should let her know it worked.”

“I’ve got it, Ambassador,” Derrick said. “Pardon me, ma’am, but you don’t look well. Are you hurt? Do you need a medic?”

“I’m… “ It seemed like Catra was about to say “fine,” but then Melog growled, and Catra stopped before beginning again. “I’m kind of tired, I guess,” she allowed.

“Why don’t you take her to her quarters?” Derrick said to Felina. “I’ll take care of letting everyone know what’s going on.”

Felina nodded, but before she could do anything, a tall woman in robes hurried over. “Catra?” she called. “Are you all right?”

“Huh?” Catra muttered. “I’m not sure. My head really hurts.”

“Can I have a look at you?” The woman looked around, and her eyes fell on Felina. “Do you think you can get her a chair, please?”

Catra caught the girl’s eye and gave her a little nod. “Yeah. Okay. I’ve never had a headache like this.”

Felina spotted a spare folding chair and dragged it over. “Ambassador? Would you like me to find a medic?” she asked when Catra practically fell into it. “I know there’s got to be one outside with security.”

“It’s okay,” Catra mumbled, squinting as if the light hurt her eyes. “I don’t need to bother the medics.”

“It’s all right, dear,” the woman said to Felina, her voice surprisingly kind. “I’m a sorceress, but I have training as a healer.”

“Is that like a medic?” Felina’s her tail bushed out. She had no idea sorcery could be used for anything other than combat.

“Yeah. She’s patched me up before,” Catra muttered.

Melog caught Felina's eye and gave her a deliberate nod followed by a little trill that Felina was pretty sure meant, "Yes."

"Where does your head hurt?" The woman seemed genuinely concerned, and Catra seemed perfectly okay with letting herself be examined by her.

Catra pointed to her blue eye and just above it. "Here."

"We need to get you to Mysticor immediately," the woman said. "Why don't I get Glimmer?"

"No," Catra groaned, reaching out a hand to grab Aunt Casta's robe, her voice weak. "I can't teleport right now. Too sick."

The woman frowned with frustration. "But you need treatment."

"What do you need? The medics probably have it," Felina said. She tapped the emergency code for the medics into her communicator.

The woman sighed. "I suppose we'll have to make do here, but it's far from ideal."

Felina glanced nervously between the woman and Catra, feeling slightly miffed by the woman's dismissal of Horde medics as "make do." On the other hand, the woman seemed to care deeply for Catra.

Adora walked away from the group in the center of the room, her concern evident. "Aunt Casta, what's wrong with Catra?"

The woman—Aunt Casta, apparently—stood up. "I don't know, I…"

"Melog says it's from bad catnip," Catra broke in, looking up at Adora. "They say I have a migraine."

The sorceress looked confused. "Bad catnip? Where did that come from? I don't understand."

Melog turned and growled at Aunt Casta, but somehow, Felina knew the sorceress was not the subject of the creature's ire.

The woman drew in a surprised breath, her eyes wide as she stared at Melog before turning to the winged woman. "I see." Her tone was tight. Could the sorceress understand Melog? It seemed they had said something the woman did not like. "Now is not the time, but rest assured, I will speak to her about it." Aunt Casta placed a comforting hand on Catra's shoulder. "Let's just get you comfortable for now."

"Catra's old quarters are nearby," Adora suggested, sounding reluctant to Felina's sharp ears. Apparently, the Princess thought the idea distasteful. "We can stay there for the night."

Felina couldn't tell if disdain or guilt caused Adora's lip to curl and her scent to spike with irritation. Did the great She-Ra think she was too good for the Horde? Or was it just the guilt of being a traitor to her people? That thought made Felina sneer inwardly, although she made sure her ears and tail did not give her away.

"Fine," Aunt Casta huffed but nodded reluctantly. "She'll probably be better with a good night's sleep." She looked at Melog. "Does that meet with your approval?" she asked the creature seriously. Felina's opinion of her rose as she realized the sorceress understood that Melog was a person and was deeply concerned about Catra.

Melog made a little yip that sounded like an affirmative.

"I can help Melog and Adora get Catra to her quarters," Felina said quickly. "I'm her aide while she's in the Capital. I can make sure she's comfortable."

The sorceress smiled at Felina. "Thank you, dear. That would be very helpful. Can you have one of your medics come speak with me before we leave? I'd like to see what preparations they want to recommend for a migraine." She glanced towards the winged woman again. "I should say hello to Angella, but I know that

Glimmer, Micah, and Angella will have much to discuss. If you need anything, please don't hesitate to call on me."

"Sounds good." Catra nodded.

Adora came up beside her. "Let's get you to bed," she said as Aunt Casta walked away.

"Do you need to say hi to Glimmer's mom or whatever?" Catra asked, indicating the group.

"I—no. I'll talk to her later. I'm worried about you." Adora sniffed and wiped her cheeks impatiently while looking back towards the others.

Felina followed her gaze to the winged being in the center. The fear notes in Adora's scent redoubled. Although everyone in the room seemed to be laughing and crying at the same time, Adora seemed the only one to be crying from true distress.

Interesting. Was Adora scared of the old queen? Felina wondered if the woman had been a harsh CO. There had always been rumors. Looking at Adora's pale face and seeing her hands shake, the girl guessed that Queen Angella might have been as harsh as Shadow Weaver.

Felina would have to think about that.

# A Quiet Dinner

Chapter Summary

Adora goes to dinner with a friend

Chapter Notes

As always, thanks to my lovely betas

Invisible, Melog carried Catra and Adora on their back while Felina walked beside them. Adora appreciated that. She didn't want to have to deal with anyone.

In the remains of the Black Garnet chamber, Felina's mom sat on the floor beside the double doors that led to Catra's quarters, cross-legged, typing on her laptop.

"Mom!" Felina called, darting forward as Melog dropped their invisibility.

Sara jumped as her daughter appeared out of nowhere in front of her, but her eyes lit up as she took in who was with her. "Hey, Sweetheart!" she greeted her daughter with a tired smile, slowly standing up to salute Catra and Adora. "Ambassador."

"Hey," Catra managed a tired wave.

"Ambassador Catra, Derrick managed to get through to me on the comms. He said you would be in residence tonight." Sare gestured to the laundry bag on the floor next to her. "I collected some clean linens from supply."

"Thanks!" Felina trilled, scooping up the bundle with one hand and pressing her thumb to the pad by the number keys. The doors slid open.

Watching Felina open those doors made a cold knot tighten in Adora's chest for some reason.

Catra must have sensed her sudden distress. She shook herself and looked over her shoulder to stare at Adora. "Are you okay?" she whispered, squinting against the light.

"Y-yeah…" Adora lied, but from the frown on Catra's face, she knew she hadn't convinced her. She tried again. "It's just… it's been so much."

"Why didn't you want to talk to Angella?" Catra asked softly, her eyebrows furrowed. "I always thought… I mean, the way Sparkles talked about it, her mom liked you."

Liked her? Adora thought of all her interactions with Angella. She had never been sure if Angella actually liked her. Angella loved She-Ra, that was true, but Adora hardly ever saw her outside the war room. Most of the time, Adora was helping Glimmer dodge Angella. The last few times they talked...

"Excuse me?"

"Huh?" While Adora had been lost in thought, Melog had carried them inside Catra's quarters.

Sara smiled at them, her presence solid and comforting. "If you give us a minute, Felina and I will change the sheets, and you can get some rest, okay?"

Catra answered, "That sounds great," her voice tired.

Adora slid off Melog's back and helped Catra down. They sat on the floor against the wall under the map since the desk chair was the only one in the room.

"Weird to be back here, huh?" Catra whispered.

Adora nodded numbly.

It took less than five minutes for Felina and Sara to return from behind the partition. "The bed's ready," she said.

Adora scooped Catra up and carried her over to the clean bunk. It was a testament to how bad Catra must have felt that she didn't protest.

Adora pulled the blanket over her, and Melog shrank down until they were small enough to curl up next to Catra's head.

Adora watched as Catra's breathing became slow and steady, her face softening in sleep. The tension that had gripped Adora since they'd arrived in the Fright Zone— *the Capital* , she reminded herself—began to unwind. A tiny bit.

Catra and Entrapta's plan had worked. Angella was back. Catra was safe. She flung the thoughts at her racing heart, at the lump in her throat, at her constricted chest. In vain, she tried to blink back the prickling behind her eyes.

This room... she remembered this room, with its cold metal walls and the ghosts of her past. It was suffocating. She had hoped that being here with Catra might make it easier, but Adora felt very alone as Catra drifted into a much-needed sleep.

The low hum of the emergency lights was the only sound aside from Melog's soft purring at the foot of the bed. Adora couldn't shake the feeling that the walls were closing in on her, shadows from old nightmares threatening to surface. The quiet wasn't comforting—it was oppressive.

The chirp of Felina's communicator reminded Adora that Sara and Felina were still on the other side of the partition.

"Affirmative, medical. I'll come and escort you," Felina said, replying to a question Adora hadn't heard. The girl raised her voice slightly. "Adora? Ma'am? I'll be right back. They're sending a medic, but he wants some help carrying supplies."

"Okay."

The doors opened and shut.

"How's Ambassador Catra?" Sara asked.

Adora walked around the partition. "She's exhausted," she replied, glancing back at Catra as she leaned against the metal wall with her arms crossed over her chest. "She fell asleep as soon as her head hit the pillow."

"Are you doing all right?" Sara asked.

"Me?" Adora chirped, trying to keep her voice light. "I'm fine."

Sara tilted her head and pursed her lips. "This place... it brings back memories, doesn't it?"

Adora stiffened at the comment, but Sara's tone was gentle, not prying.

"Yeah," Adora said after a moment, her voice quieter. "It's been a long time."

Sara nodded as if she understood more than she was letting on. "We all have our ghosts," she said softly, leaning against the wall. "But sometimes, confronting them head-on is the only way to lay them to rest."

Adora swallowed. "I don't understand what you mean."

Sara smiled and shook her head. "Don't worry about it," she said, changing the subject. "You must be starving by now. Why don't you come to the dining hall with me? Get something to eat. It'll do you good."

Adora hesitated, glancing back at Catra. "I don't want to leave her alone."

"She'll be fine," Sara assured her. "We can wait until the medics have a look at her and then go. Melog's here, and if anything happens, I'm sure they'll let you know. Besides," she added with a small smile, "I could use the company."

Just then, the double doors opened. Felina walked in with a very pale man with white hair.

"Where is she?" the medic asked, his voice calm but clinical.

Adora's heart skipped a beat at the sight of him. The sterile smell of antiseptic wafted into the room. The air became too thick to breathe. Her stomach churned, a cold sweat prickling at the back of her neck.

"Back here," Adora stuttered, her voice coming out weaker than she intended. She forced her frozen legs to move, to lead the medic around the metal partition. Each step felt heavy like the nightmare where her feet sank into the floor. "Catra? Can you wake up for a minute?" Her hand trembled as she gently petted Catra's arm.

"Mrrp?" Catra opened her eyes with a little trill. Her gaze seemed a little hazy.

"Ambassador?" the man said, his movements precise and efficient. Felina handed him exam gloves from his bag. The sound of them snapping against his wrists made Adora flinch. "I understand you have a migraine?"

Adora's breath caught in her throat. She backed into the corner, her shoulders brushing against the cold metal walls. The room seemed to shrink around her, the space closing in. She was back in Shadow Weaver's room. Trapped. Waiting. Every inch of her skin crawled with the memory of cold hands, of Shadow Weaver’s sharp voice cutting through her thoughts, of the inescapable feeling that no matter what she did, it would never be enough.

She squeezed her eyes shut, trying to focus on anything else. Even though Catra had replaced all the furniture and gotten rid of Shadow Weaver's personal effects, something of the woman's essence seemed to remain. Adora almost expected to see the old witch walk in the door.

The sharp alcohol smell became overwhelming, making her want to throw up. It was like turning over a rock and uncovering something vile. Only the disgusting thing under the rock was her. She wanted to curl up beneath it, hidden away, safe from the world's prying eyes.

Something… happened… here.

Her chest tightened further, and her fingers dug into her arms as she crossed them over her chest, as if she could physically hold herself together. As if she could protect herself from the fear clawing at her mind.

A hand rested on her shoulder, the touch warm and grounding. "Adora?"

Adora started, her eyes snapping open. She turned her head to find Sara looking at her with concern, her expression soft and understanding.

"I-I'm fine," Adora squeaked. She forced a smile, but it felt tight, unnatural, as though her face was cracking under the strain. Her heart pounded too hard. She tried to steady her breathing, to regain control, but it was like trying to inhale through a straw—no matter how hard she tried, it wasn't enough. She was drowning, and she wasn't sure how to stay afloat.

"Hey, Adora?" Catra called softly, her voice rough. Adora was at her side instantly, as if the distance between them had never existed. "The medic says I just need an injection and some sleep. I heard you talking. Are you going to get dinner with Sara?"

Adora swallowed hard, and the lump in her throat was painful. "As long as you don't need me."

"No, I'm good with Melog here. I can have them find you," Catra reassured her, her eyes soft with concern.

She knew. Of course, she knew. She always did.

"Ma'am?" said Felina from behind them. "I can stay here with her until you get back."

Catra nodded. "There. I'll be fine."

"Felina has clearance to get anything Catra needs, and the comms are fixed. She'll give us a call." Sara stepped closer, her presence steadying. "Let's get you out of here for a bit," she said gently, her eyes holding Adora's in a way that made it feel okay to leave, to escape this room and the suffocating memories that came with it.

Adora took one last shaky breath, then nodded. "Okay." She squeezed Catra's hand, then forced herself to step away to follow Sara out of the oppressive quarters.

The door slid shut behind them with a soft hiss, but the tension in Adora's chest didn't fully ease until they were halfway down the corridor.

As they walked the winding corridors of the Fright Zone— *the Capital,* she corrected herself again. They passed much-changed but still familiar corridors and landmarks. Sara was not taking Adora to the officer's dining room, where she and her squad always had their meals, Adora realized, but to one of the common dining halls. Adora had never eaten in one.

Mostly empty, except for a few folks finishing their meals at the room's far end. It looked exactly like the one Adora had grown up eating in. That felt strangely good. The lighting and the clatter of dishes being cleaned offered a strange sense of normalcy, a contrast to Adora's fucked up emotions.

Adora was suddenly struck by the smells of *soup* and freshly *baked bread* .

"Pick whatever you want," Sara said, gesturing at the tables of food as she picked up their tray. "They always have something decent."

"Real food." Adora had never seen real food offered inside the Horde. How were they getting it? Who was cooking it?

Sara picked up a tray and then turned with an understanding smile. "Scorpia and Perfuma insisted that we had to start serving real food in the dining halls." She frowned faintly, perhaps interpreting Adora's surprise as dislike. "It's okay if you prefer ration bars. A lot of folks do."

"Really?" Adora said wide-eyed. "No, it's not that. I'm just surprised. I never had real food until…" Her words petered out as she realized what she almost said. Feeling her cheeks get warm, she looked away.

Maybe to cover the awkwardness, Sara picked up another tray to hand to Adora.

"That all smells amazing!" Adora exclaimed, realizing that she was starving. She selected a bowl of stew, a slice of bread, and a small portion of fruit and returned to the table. She could not believe the variety of food the dining hall was serving.

"Looks like you found something good," Sara said as she sat.

"Yeah," Adora replied, her voice more steady now. She dipped her spoon into the stew, the broth's warmth settling her nerves as she took her first bite.

"So I hear you and Catra are official?" Sara asked.

Adora's cheeks went hot, but she grinned as she said, "Yeah."

A big smile spread across Sara's face. "That is so great to hear! A lot of folks are getting officially sanctioned. Felina's squad has been busy entering all the certificates into the computer system." The woman leaned forward to murmur, "And you would not believe the number of reproductive waivers the council has issued. Everyone who asks! Even if they're not official, if you can believe it." Sara sat back, seeming suddenly shy. "Derrick and I got one just after we got back."

"Really?!" yelped Adora.

"Shshshhhhh!" Sara's cheeks were bright red, but her eyes sparkled, and she giggled. "Not so loud."

"Sorry!" whispered Adora.

"But, yes, we did." The woman patted her leg. "As soon as Entrapta helped me with my brace. She said it would probably be safe enough." She leaned forward and whispered. "I think… I think we lit that fuse. I was down at the infirmary getting a test when the lights went out. It was positive." Sara leaned back again and pressed her hand to her solar plexus. "So now we just need our little recruit to report in."

Adora's eyes prickled with tears. Her heart suddenly felt full of light. She wanted to speak, but for a moment, her breath was utterly stopped.

"Hey, what's up?" Sara said.

"It's just… I'm so happy." This was what She Ra and the Sword of Protection were meant for. Life could be so much more than just survival; it could be more than fighting and fear. She had fought for this, for people to live without the constant shadow of war hanging over them.

"Y-your eyes…" Sara gulped hard, and her hand went to her chest. She sucked in a long breath, held it, blew it out.

Just like that, all the joy was snuffed out, replaced by a sudden wave of guilt and fear. It was like a candle blown out by a gust of wind. Adora felt She Ra's magic tingling on her skin but had not thought about where she was.

The magic snuffed out along with the joy,

"I'm sorry!" Adora whimpered, tears of distress beginning to run down her cheek. Stupid, stupid, *stupid*. Sara might be perfectly

okay with Adora, but She Ra would obviously send her into a panic attack.

Sara's hands trembled, but she laughed weakly. "I-it's okay… Just-just startled me."

"I'll just…" Adora began to stand with her tray.

Sara's hand shot out to gently grab the tray Adora carried. Adora's every instinct was to run, to flee before she could cause any more harm. But the firmness in Sara's voice, the warmth in her eyes, made her pause. Something in her chest unclenched just a little.

"No, don't go," Sara said gently, her voice steady despite the earlier tremor.

"But I…" Adora began helplessly, feeling like she was once again causing more harm than good.

Sara's hand remained firm on the tray, her gaze unwavering. "You look like you could use a friend," she continued, her tone soft but insistent. It was an invitation, a lifeline that Adora desperately wanted to grab, even though she wasn't sure she deserved it.

# A Calm Space

Chapter Summary

Adora and Sara finish their talk.
Catra is feeling better.

Thanks to Doc for beta-ing

They spent the rest of the meal talking about trivialities—Sara purposely kept the conversation light. The poor kid had been a hair's breadth away from a full-on meltdown at least twice in the past hour. Sara couldn't be sure why, but she had her suspicions—she'd seen the girl's face as she went into Catra's quarters. Of course, they used to be Shadow Weaver's. Sara remembered them well.

Tom never knew what Sara had to do to get that waiver approved. It would have upset him. It still gave her nightmares from time to time. Sometimes, when she woke up in a cold sweat, she could almost feel Shadow Weaver's measuring gaze on her. The urge to scrub her skin raw until she felt clean again was overwhelming. But it had all been worth it in the end—she would have done that and more for Felina.

There had always been rumors about Shadow Weaver and the children she took in. No one outside the officer ranks knew much, just that there was a cadre directly under Shadow Weaver's command. The kids were assigned to a special creche. They had all the best instructors and every advantage. But the idea of Shadow Weaver raising children gave Sara the screaming horrors.

"Um… Can I ask you something?" Adora's voice broke through Sara's thoughts. She bit her lip, clearly hesitant. "You don't have to answer if you don't want to."

Sara smiled softly, sensing Adora's nerves. "Sure, go ahead."

“What was Felina’s father like?” Adora bit her lip again, her uncertainty palpable. “It’s totally okay if you don’t want to talk about him,” she added. “It’s just that…”

“You’ve never known anyone bunking with a Magicat?” Sara tilted her head, feeling a wistful smile curve her lips.

“Yeah,” Adora admitted shyly. “Did he know where he was from or anything?”

Enough time had passed that it no longer hurt to talk about Tom. “He was amazing,” Sara sighed. “We used to sneak off to the roof together when we were kids. He brought me mice sometimes when rations were short.”

As she spoke, the weight of that old grief pressed down on her, but it was no longer so heavy. It grounded her—it was part of who she was. A flash of memory surfaced: seeing him in the infirmary, the fur on his face burnt away, his ears charred lumps. But after ten years, the image didn’t linger. She swallowed, and the words came easier.

“We did so much together that bunking together just seemed natural, you know?” Sara giggled softly, the sound tinged with fondness. “We found someone to show us how to cook the mice so we wouldn’t get bellyaches. When we got older, it was rabbits.”

Sara’s voice grew a bit more serious as she continued, “Tom said Magicats came from somewhere far away. That’s why there are so few. The story goes that there were some here when the Horde took over, and they couldn’t get out. Tom’s parents were killed, and he was taken by the Horde. He remembered only a little.”

“Oh,” Adora said, her voice soft with understanding.

“We grew up in the same cadre. We got officially sanctioned as soon as we could,” Sara added, a faint smile returning to her lips as she remembered. “We had some good years.” She paused for a moment, then said, “He’d be so proud of Felina.”

Adora smiled. “He would. She’s so brave.” She fidgeted and then said quietly, “I kinda feel bad… I mean…” Her cheeks flushed, and she looked away.

Sara shrugged. “She’s young. It’s an adjustment for everyone.”

The blonde girl’s shoulders began to shake, and her eyes filled with tears. “But sh-she’s right.”

“What do you mean?” Sara asked, her voice softening with concern.

It seemed Adora lost her ability to speak. She waved at Sara’s leg.

Sara’s gaze followed Adora’s to the brace on her knee. She let out a slow breath, the air suddenly thick with memories she’d rather forget. The battle. The weeks of illicit experiments, working with the medics to make Entrapta’s designs work for her, the fear that she’d never walk again.

Sara shook her head firmly. “Stop,” she said, her voice steady but with an edge of steel. The kid was going to make her crazy if she kept this up. “It happened. Lots of things happened. It was a war. It’s over. Nobody is asking you to be friends. You just need to work together.” She leaned forward and tapped her finger on the table. “Not everyone is going to like you. And there is absolutely no reason to think they will.”

Adora sniffed and said, “I’m the reason…”

“The war is the reason,” Sara growled, losing patience. “You are not special.” She stopped. Adora’s mouth had fallen open, and her face drained of color. Sara remembered just how young Adora was and softened her voice. “I mean… You *are* special, I get that--but you’re still a person. What you’re feeling isn’t unique. Everyone carries this stuff around.” She dropped her eyes. “If you don’t, you’re scary.”

A little silence fell between them until Sara reached across the table to touch Adora’s hand. “I’ve been a soldier all my life. I’ve

served on a tank crew for ten years. I don't know how many civilians I killed or maimed. I never kept count." She looked away from Adora's wide gray eyes, fighting back the tide of emotions threatening to overwhelm her. "But what else could I do? I could have deserted, but where the hell could I go? What kind of life could I have given Felina on the run?" She sniffed, feeling the tightness in her chest. This stars-damned kid was making her cry. "So, please, stop thinking you're the only one dragging around a pack full of guilt."

Something flickered in Adora's eyes, and the set of her shoulders relaxed. "Oh."

The older woman sniffed again, then squeezed Adora's hand before withdrawing. "Let's get you back. I bet you need sleep, too."

By Adora's embarrassed flush, Sara's words were correct.

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They did not speak on the walk back to Catra's quarters. Adora had a lot to think about, and Sara seemed content to let her think.

Felina sat at the double doors, reading on her compad, looking exactly like Sara, in spite of the ears and tail she inherited from her father. It was in the set of her shoulders and the tilt of her head. The way she jumped up and snapped off a salute when she saw Sara and Adora.

Sara returned it and then said, "Okay, cadet. You're relieved." Then she reached out and scratched behind one of the lighter tufts of fur near her daughter's ears.

Catra used to have those, Adora thought. She couldn't remember when they disappeared.

“Hey, little soldier, why don’t you come back to my quarters?” Sara said to Felina. “Derrick’s due to get off duty soon.” Her eyes sparkled. “I have some good news.”

“Oh yeah? What’s that?” the girl asked.

“Not here.” Sara shook her head. “I want to tell you both together,” She put her arm across Felina’s shoulder. “See you next time you come to the Capital?” Sara asked Adora.

“That would be great.”

For a second, the three stood awkwardly as if they could not quite figure out who was supposed to dismiss whom. Then Adora said, “Good night, " and waved to them.

It was not a “dismissed” and a salute, but it was near enough, and they both returned the little wave before they left.

Talking to Sara left Adora with a lot to think about, but somehow she felt more settled. She felt like she could actually get to sleep.

Without thinking about it, she pressed her thumb to the pad. It wasn’t until the door slid shut behind her that Adora realized that was strange. She had used Catra’s password this morning—she hadn’t even considered trying biometrics, assuming that hers would have been erased from the computer. Strange that it had not.

She poked her head around the partition. Catra and Melog snored softly and rhythmically in their sleep—the sound was excessively cute. Adora grinned to herself, glad that Bow wasn’t here. His head would explode while he was trying to keep his delight to a dull roar.

“Hey, I’m back,” Adora said quietly. Both Catra and Melog opened one eye to a slit and then closed them.

Adora stood quietly, watching as Catra and Melog fell back into their peaceful slumber. The rhythmic sound of their breathing was

a comforting backdrop, but the tension that had gripped her earlier in the evening still lingered just beneath the surface. She did not know what to do with herself.

It was a strange experience for her-- to not have anything to do. Even on Darla she could train or something. It was not like she could casually turn up at one of the training rooms and turn on a sim. If anybody recognized her she they would lose their minds. Even if she was not recognized, someone might ask for ID or something.

She considered trying to find Glimmer and find out what was happening with Angella but discarded it right away. It was cowardly, but she wanted to put off that confrontation as long as possible. Angella would not be cruel—it was not in her nature, but Adora could not stand to see the disappointment reflecting in the woman’s eyes.

She pulled out the desk chair and sat, leaning her elbow on the desk. Idly, she opened the drawers, finding nothing of interest. The last time she had been in this room, it had been so different. Back then, it had been Shadow Weaver's domain, a place that had always made her feel small and powerless.

In the far corner of the room, the dim light could not seem to reach, and shadows pooled on the floor. Something about that corner tugged at her memory, a vague sense of unease curling in her stomach. The shadows seemed to stretch and warp, memories flitting through her mind like dark specters.

Adora hesitated, then slowly stood to move towards the corner. She reached out toward a panel on the wall, her hand trembling. The metal was cold under her fingertips. Her hand knew what to do, even if her mind did not. She flipped up a little panel to reveal a little fingerprint pad. Adora pressed her thumb to it. The mechanism in the wall whirred, and the door to the compartment slid open with a soft hiss of escaping air, revealing a small, dark compartment hidden behind the metal paneling.

The cupboard was air tight. The objects were free of dust and looked disturbingly recent. Adora's breath caught in her throat as she stared at the contents: neatly labeled jars with dried plants and different colored powders. A small, worn book that looked like a journal and several data chips.

For a moment, Adora considered just closing it back up, pretending she had not found it. It felt like a trap. Why did her biometrics work for the door? Why did Shadow Weaver not purge it from the system? That made no sense. Perhaps it was just her quarters. Maybe she merely forgot. She had always been paranoid about allowing the technicians access to her quarters and her files.

Adora reached in and pulled out the journal, wiping it off on her shirt. The cover was worn and unmarked, but when she opened it, she recognized Shadow Weaver's precise, angular handwriting. Her heart pounded as she flipped through the pages, her eyes catching snippets of words and phrases: "Arxia," "weapon," and "Adora."

It felt like holding a venomous snake. She needed to put it down and walk away from it, but now that she had seen it, how could she without it biting her? There were answers in these pages, and she wasn't sure she was ready to face them.

*One day, she would not have to do this anymore. One day, she would lose her grip on the rope up to the roof or try a jump just a little beyond her reach. Or maybe when Shadow Weaver sent her into combat, she could duck just a little too slowly.*

The thoughts felt like a memory. A chill ran down her spine, but before she could read more, Catra's voice pulled her back to the present.

"Adora?"

The blonde snapped the book shut, determined to leave the past for another day. She put it down on the desk, shaking her head,

confused.

“You okay?” Adora asked, going around the partition.

Catra sat up on her elbows and nodded. “Yeah, a lot better. Felina brought us some food, too.”

“Oh, good.” Sitting down next to her wife, Adora pushed Catra’s bangs back. They were starting to hang in her face.

“Aunt Casta came by for a minute. I guess she went down to the infirmary and interrogated everyone.” Catra smiled a little, shaking her head. “She finally decided that it would not kill me to spend the night here. Anyway, she and the Sparkle family had dinner with Scorpia and Perfuma.”

“That’s nice.”

“Sparkles said we have to go back to Bright Moon tomorrow and have dinner with all of them. She said she’d come looking for us if we did not show up in time.”

Adora’s stomach tied itself into knots. “If you don’t feel…”

“Why are you avoiding her?” Catra asked, her eyes narrowed. “You never used to back down from anything. What’s going on?”

“It-it’s nothing.” Regret rose up in a massive black wave to suffocate Adora’s thoughts. She had tried so hard, but all she could see were the moments where she had faltered. Her mind flashed back to that first night in Bright Moon, the weight of Angella’s hand on her shoulder.

*“Do not disappoint her.”*

Now, Angella’s disappointment loomed over Adora, a shadow she couldn’t escape. The memories rose up to torment her, the moment she hesitated when Angella needed her most. The grief in Glimmer’s eyes.

“Bullshit.” Catra’s voice was firm, her eyes shining in the darkened room.“You know I can’t help if you keep shutting me out.”

“I’m not, I… “

“Please. Stop.”, Catra said wearily. She took Adora’s hand and brought it to her chest, and stroked her cheek. “It’s fine if you don’t want to talk to Angella. We can give her an excuse tomorrow, but she’s just going to wonder why. You’ll have to see her eventually.”

Adora squeezed her eyes shut. “I can’t face her. I’m the reason she was stuck there for two years! If-if I’d been better… she wouldn’t’ve been lost.” How could she explain? Every mistake came back to how she failed Angella. “G-Gl-immer w-would never have found the Heart. Prime wouldn’t’ve…”

“Shh.” Catra brought Adora’s hand to her lips and kissed it.

Adora’s eyes opened to meet Catra’s. Her pupils were huge and round, and Adora could see her reflection in them, one framed in blue and the other in gold.

“You’re tired. Come to bed.” Catra patted the spot beside her. “Come on, we might as well get comfortable.” She turned and flipped one of the switches on the panel next to the bed, putting a do not disturb flag in the log. Then she wiggled out of her clothes, stripping down to her underwear and dropping them on the floor.

Adora did as she was told, toeing off her boots and dropping her shirt and pants beside of the bed. Shoulders shaking, she crawled into Catra’s arms. The soft, rhythmic purring in her ear felt like a rope flung at her, pulling her out of a deep pit. The tightness in her chest eased.

Melog still snored softly at the end of the bed. For a moment, neither of them spoke, the silence filled only with the rhythmic sound of Catra’s purring and the soft rustle of the blanket as she pulled Adora closer. The world narrowed to just the three of them in this quiet, dim room.

“You’re okay.” She pulled Adora close and purred in her ear. “I’ll be with you. They invited me too. You don’t have to go alone, okay.” When had Catra gotten so gentle? The fierce, unyielding girl she had known had softened in ways Adora hadn’t even noticed until now.

“Promise?”

There was a little pause and then Adora felt Catra carefully pull out her pony tail, and then rake her fingers though her hair. “Of course, silly.”

Hot, uncomfortable tears slid down Adora’s face as she buried it in Catra’s shoulder. Her body trembled. Catra stroked her head, grounding her. Warmth seeped in to drive the cold from her gut. Each stroke of Catra’s hand through her hair soothed the raw edges of her emotions.

After a long time, Adora’s sobs slowed, then stopped. Catra kept petting Adora’s hair. A long time after that, she spoke.

“When we were on Prime’s ship… “ Catra cleared her throat. “Sparkles and I used to talk. A lot.”

Adora became rigid. This was the first time Catra had directly told her anything about her time on Prime’s ship. Catra did not stop stroking her hair, and gradually, Adora relaxed again.

“She was so guilty about you and Arrow Boy. She said she felt bad about what she said. And how she listened to Shadow Weaver:” The words came out slowly, underscored with that deep purr. “She wanted to tell you that she didn’t mean it.”

That was fine for the accusations that were not true—the ones Shadow Weaver had put in Glimmer’s head.

“Some of what Glimmer had said was true,” whispered Adora into the crook of Catra’s head.

The hand stroking her hair paused and then started again. “You know,” Catra said softly, “I’ve made more mistakes than I can count. All we can do is fix things as best we can.”

# Family

Chapter Summary

Back at Bright Moon. Dinner with Angella.

As always, thanks to my betas.

The road to Bright Moon was broad and well-traveled. Even though Adora and Catra left after lunch, they arrived well in time for supper with Angella.

Catra was feeling much better—the migraine medication had finally worked, and a full night's sleep had taken care of the rest. With the pounding in her head finally gone, she could think clearly—and what she saw was troubling.

Since Adora did not have a crisis to distract her from her own problems, all the things she'd been pushing down, ignoring, were starting to rise to the surface.

"Did we leave some clean clothes here?" Catra asked, mostly to break the silence. But it was also practical-- She was the Republic Ambassador, after all. The last thing she wanted was to show up to dinner looking like she'd just rolled out of bed in front of Bright Moon's (former?) queen.

Adora nodded absently. "Yeah, we did. Don't worry. Angella's not too formal about stuff when it's just a regular dinner."

Catra frowned. She could hear the hollowness in Adora's voice, how she was trying to sound casual but couldn't quite pull it off. It reminded Catra of how Adora used to sound before a big exam—like she was trying to convince herself more than anyone else.

What was that about?

This morning, Adora had actually seemed… happy for once. She'd been talking about dinner with Sara, telling Catra how good it had

felt to sit with her in the common dining hall. They hadn't talked about the war or leadership or saving the world. They'd just… talked.

As they neared Bright Moon's gates, Adora's shoulders tensed, her mouth tightened into a thin line. Catra had thought that seeing Glimmer's mom would be a happy reunion for her, but Adora looked like she was bracing herself for a fight.

Beside her, Melog let out a low growl, their mane flickering with hints of red as they sensed the tension in the air. Melog hadn't forgiven Angella for the catnip tea incident, and Catra couldn't help but feel a spark of amusement at their loyalty. But then her gaze returned to Adora, and her amusement faded. It had been the first time in a while that Adora had sounded like herself. It had been such a small thing, but it was like a weight had lifted off Adora, at least for a little while.

But tonight was different. The closer they got to Bright Moon, the quieter and more withdrawn Adora became. Catra could smell her fear, sharp and tangy, like it was leaking from her pores. She wondered if Adora even realized it was there. It was the same scent she used to carry when she was psyching herself up to face Shadow Weaver.

Did Adora feel that way about Angella now? The thought made Catra's stomach twist. She'd assumed Adora would be overjoyed to see Angella again. But maybe... maybe she was still haunted by everything that had happened while Angella was gone.

Catra had thought that the return of Sparkle's mom would make her almost as happy as the whole Sparkle family, but Adora's shoulders tensed as they neared Bright Moon's gates. Her smile was tight as if she were bracing for something.

Even with Angella slipping her a little Princess potion, Catra did not think the (former? What the plan was there?) ruler of Bright Moon inspired anywhere close to the level of fear Shadow Weaver was capable of.

A low growl emerged from Melog's throat at the thought. They had not yet forgiven Angella for her bad catnip tea, and Catra scratched their ears as they walked.

The thing was, Adora had spent so much time taking care of everyone else that she didn't even seem to realize she was crumbling. She'd been caring for Catra, Glimmer, and the whole world for so long, pretending everything was fine. And maybe it was fine now—for everyone but her.

Adora was struggling. She had been struggling for a long time. The truth was she had always struggled.

The sound of windchimes pulled her out of her thoughts. Glimmer appeared at the end of the hallway, literally glowing with happiness. Catra wondered if she was going to need to get some sunglasses if Sparkles were going to keep doing that.

"Hey, you guys!" Glimmer called, her voice bright and full of excitement. "I'm so glad you made it!"

Adora smiled, and Catra saw it—the tightness in the corners of her mouth, the way it didn't reach her eyes. She'd been seeing that smile a lot lately.

"Wouldn't miss it," Adora said, her voice as bright and sharp as a dagger. Catra could feel the tension radiating off her, even if Glimmer didn't seem to notice.

That was the thing about Adora. She was shit at acting, shit at lying, but she *was* good at pretending. Pretending to herself she was fine. She spent her whole life trying to hold everything together, and Catra was sure she did not know she was doing it anymore.

As Glimmer linked arms with them and led them down the hall, chattering about how excited Angella was to see them, Catra's mind drifted.

Maybe to Adora, maybe Angella did resemble Shadow Weaver—did she debrief Adora after battles and tell her what mistakes she made? Did she complain about Adora's training schedules not being stringent enough? She did not seem the type, but who knew?

Melog growled and shoved a picture of Angella offering tea into Catra's head. Melog was not going to forgive Angella that for a while.

"Mom is so excited to see you!" Glimmer burbled as she led them to their room. "Catra? How's your headache? Aunt Casta was really worried."

"It's better," Catra grunted as they came in the door. "Is there a dress code to this thing?" she asked as she headed to her closet.

"No, no. Whatever is comfortable is fine." Glimmer wore what she wore during the workday, so Catra opted for a simple pair of leggings and a bodysuit.

Adora had, predictably, donned a clean compression shirt and a pair of soft pants. She fixed her ponytail in the mirror like she was heading into an inspection. Bending down, she swiped her boots with a rag, giving them a little shine.

"I'll be right back," Adora said, heading into the bathroom.

Catra heard the water turn on right away. Adora did that when she wanted to give herself a pep talk without having Catra hear her.

Casually, Catra moved closer to the bathroom door. Her ears flicked forward, her heart sinking as she caught Adora's whispering. The bathroom door muffled most of it, but she heard enough—enough to feel the chill crawl down her spine. The instinct to storm in and shake Adora out of this self-inflicted torment burned under her skin, but she forced herself to stay quiet. Whatever this was, it was older and deeper than she'd realized.

“It’s going to be okay.” Adora was whispering. “It’s not like she'll bring it up in front of anyone. You know how she is; she’ll want to get you alone. She doesn’t like to criticize in front of people. It’ll be fine. Anyway, she’ll probably be too polite to bring it up at all, right?”

This dinner was only the beginning—Catra could feel it in her bones. Whatever was weighing on Adora, it wasn’t going to be solved with a few smiles and polite conversation.

Melog growled at Catra, then disappeared.

“Yeah, okay,” Catra told them absently. “We’ll see you later.”

“Oh, is Melog not coming?” Glimmer asked with raised eyebrows.

Catra shook her head with a little half smile. “They say they will ‘respectfully decline the Old Queen’s invitation.’”

No way was she going to repeat what *else* Melog had said.

“They’re still kind of mad at the whole catnip thing," Catra finished.

The young Queen looked stricken. “Oh, stars! Catra, I am so sorry! Are you sure you're all right?”

“Me? Yes, I’m okay. It was just a headache.” Catra shrugged, “Melog said it was because Angella doesn’t know much about plants. I guess the magic just approximated the plant based on what she knew?”

Glimmer nodded. “Aunt Casta said something about it last night.” the young Queen smirked, “She was kind of annoyed, but she said she'd save her lecture on magical theory for another time..” She turned her head to where the door had opened and shut. “Are *they* all right?”

“They’re fine. They said they’ll get over it.” Catra waved her hand dismissively. “Just not tonight.” She would also not mention that

Melog would be there, just out of sight.

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Angella glanced around, feeling content in the company of her family—Glimmer, Bow, Micah, Castaspella, Adora, and…

Catra?

The Queen of Bright Moon had longed for this—her family around her, safe, whole. Yet, the woman who had once nearly brought down Bright Moon was here, woven into the fabric of their lives as if she had always belonged. Angella's gaze lingered on Catra, watching the easy familiarity between her and Glimmer as the latter laughed at something Catra said.  The boundaries of her understanding shifted, reshaping themselves into something she couldn't yet define.

When Castaspella informed her yesterday that Catra would be invited to this dinner, Angella was caught off guard. "I understand she is an important diplomat," Angella said slowly, "and I am grateful to her. But I hoped we could have dinner with just the family."

"She is family," Micah and Castaspella had replied in unison. They exchanged glances and laughed at the in-joke, leaving Angella feeling like an outsider to something she had missed. She had wanted to ask them to explain, but before she could, they had been interrupted by the arrival of Scorpia and Perfuma.

There was so much she had missed.

Last night had been overwhelming—too much to take in at once. She had been relieved when, after she had been introduced to Scorpia, the current leader of the Horde, and greeted by Perfuma, Glimmer had teleported them to Micah's apartments in Mystacor, where they had talked into the early hours of the morning. Even

then, those hours of conversation had barely scratched the surface of all that had happened in her absence.

Glimmer and Micah had sketched out the arc of the war, how it had shifted from a conflict with the Horde to a battle with a creature from another world—Horde Prime. They had gone to Mystacor's highest tower to gaze at the stars, where Glimmer had recounted the final battle with Horde Prime and the peace treaty that followed.

This morning, over breakfast, Micah had patiently answered more of her questions. He had described how Bow and Adora had rescued him and Entrapta from Beast Island. How he had led the Rebellion forces against the Galactic Horde. How Glimmer had been captured by Horde Prime, only to be rescued by Catra and Adora, and how he, himself, had been controlled by Prime.

There was still so much more to uncover. So many questions, and the answers all seemed more complicated than the last. But all of that could wait. They had tomorrow… and the tomorrow after that.

For the first time in what felt like an eternity, her endless tomorrows were bright and full of hope rather than burdens to be endured.

This was far more than she had ever expected to have. Returning to Bright Moon—the real Bright Moon, not a magical copy made of memories—it still felt surreal. Sometimes, she feared it would all vanish. The only thing helping to convince her was that she could never have imagined this future.

It was not just that the war was over. She could imagine that, but not like this.  This dinner would have seemed impossible. She had longed to be surrounded by the people she loved, but Hordak's second-in-command, a cunning and ruthless opponent, sat at her dinner table between Adora and her sister-in-law.

In flights of fancy, she would imagine Micah returning to her, but she never entertained the thought that those fancies could be realized.

As the serving staff cleared away the plates from the main course, Glimmer and Bow spoke about their upcoming wedding. Well, really it was Glimmer doing the talking while Bow sat bashfully beside her, overwhelmed by the planning. But it added a welcome layer of normalcy to the otherwise unbelievable events.

"It's going to be perfect," Glimmer exclaimed, her voice alight with joy. "We've been waiting for so long. Now that you're back, we can finally plan the wedding we've always wanted."

Angella smiled softly. Seeing her daughter so happy planning her future filled her heart with warmth. Micah and Castaspella were adding their thoughts on magical touches for the ceremony while Bow listened, beaming.

But then Micah turned his gaze toward Adora and Catra. "Of course, you two are already ahead," he said with a playful grin. "I understand you've already tied the knot?"

Angella blinked, taken aback. Adora and Catra? Her mind spun for a moment, trying to reconcile the names.

"You're… married?" Angella asked, her surprise clear in her voice. "I thought the treaty was only recently signed?"

Adora shifted in her seat, her cheeks reddening as she looked down at her hands. "Uh, yeah… it was recent." Her mouth turned up at the corners, and she reached over to take Catra's hand.

"About three months ago," Catra added with a shy smile that revealed one fang, her tail flicking lazily behind her.

"Glimmer and I officiated," Castaspella said proudly.

Angella's brow furrowed. "And no one thought to mention it to me?" She was beginning to feel quite lost.

“I’m sorry,” Micah said with a smile, covering her hand with his. “I’m afraid we had so much other ground to cover that I forgot. I only just heard about it myself.”

Both Catra and Adora seemed discomfited. Adora’s cheeks flared bright red, and Catra’s tail lashed.

“I don’t understand. How could you not know?”

“The ceremony was private,” Bow supplied.

Angella knew Adora to be intensely private, but this... The woman who had once nearly brought down Bright Moon was married to the woman who had saved Etheria. The last time Angella had heard Adora speak Catra’s name, it had been spoken with a kind of angry obsession.

Angella raised an eyebrow, still genuinely taken aback. “Private?” she repeated. “But… you’re both public figures.” She trailed off, not wanting to make them uncomfortable, but her voice still showed surprise. “I would have thought there would be more… celebration. Something for the people of Etheria to share in.”

For a brief moment, she considered asking if the marriage had been arranged—perhaps to seal the treaty, to symbolize unity. It wouldn’t have been unheard of in situations like this. Their ranks would be roughly equivalent, and the timing seemed to indicate that.

But then she looked at them again— *really* looked—and saw how they leaned toward each other. How Catra shifted closer when Adora fidgeted, a small gesture that spoke volumes about their connection.

Adora’s face flushed even deeper, and she mumbled, “We didn’t want to make a big deal out of it.”

Catra shrugged, though there was a protective edge to her casual tone. “It’s not like we need to show everyone. It was about us. That’s all.” Her voice remained light, but Angella couldn’t help but

notice the slight tension in Catra's hands, the way her claws flexed almost imperceptibly.

Castaspella placed a gentle hand on Catra's and cleared her throat. Interesting-- Castaspella was normally not demonstrative with casual friends, and the touch seemed intended to be reassuring. "In Horde culture, weddings are traditionally small. Close friends and family only." She raised an eyebrow at Angella, sounding a little prim. "Adora and Catra wanted a ceremony that meant something to them, not a public spectacle."

Angella tilted her head slightly, intrigued. Of course, The Horde would have traditions like this—ceremonies with their own customs and meanings. Angella had just never really considered it. Even after Angella had gotten to know Adora a little, she never spoke of their customs. And to her chagrin, Angella realized she never asked about what Adora had left behind. The Horde had always seemed monolithic, a vast empire bent on conquest. It felt strange now to imagine the lives of the people within it, the rituals and relationships that had nothing to do with war.

"I beg your pardon. I didn't mean to be rude," Angella murmured, though her surprise hadn't quite dissipated. She didn't want Adora or Catra to think she was criticizing them. "Still, your marriage means so much to all of us. And to the people of Etheria." She paused, measuring her next words. "I know you didn't want a large ceremony, but… would your customs allow a reception? A way for everyone to celebrate your union? Many would see your marriage as symbolic of the peace process."

Adora looked up, eyes wide, clearly caught off guard by the suggestion. "A reception?"

"Yeah. Remember?" Catra nudged Adora, glancing at Castaspella and Glimmer. "We've been talking about it. Aunt Casta said it was like a morale thing. It would be another way to remind people that the peace is real."

"Oh, right," Adora said vaguely, sounding as though she had no idea what they were talking about but going with it anyway.

"Yes," Angella continued, smiling gently. "A ball. Something for your friends, your allies, and the people of Etheria to honor what you've done and celebrate your marriage. It wouldn't have to be formal—just a way to acknowledge what you two mean to the world. You've both given so much of yourselves. I think it's something worth sharing."

Catra's ears twitched, and she looked at Adora, whose face had gone redder than before. Adora squirmed slightly, clearly uncomfortable with the idea.

"Um… we're not really the 'ballroom' type," Adora said hesitantly.

Catra's tail flicked back and forth. "Yeah, but displays like this are important."

"We should probably have a celebration for Angella's return as well," Castaspella said unexpectedly. "I think we should plan that first. The story must be all over Etheria by now, so you must make a formal announcement."

"Yes," Glimmer said, suddenly businesslike. "You're absolutely right. We should announce this at Court tomorrow. Perhaps the celebration of Mom's return should be next week. That gives us time to plan." She turned to Adora and Catra, a smirk tugging at her lips. "It'd be a practice run."

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Adora smiled as best she could, her hands fidgeting beneath the table until Catra's warm, dry hand squeezed her cold, sweaty one. The small gesture of reassurance could not stop the rising tide of panic.

When the subject of their wedding came up, her chest tightened, squeezing the air from her lungs. Angella's gaze sharpened, and Adora's mind filled with one clear, damning message: They'd done

something wrong. They'd forgotten something important, something everyone else expected of them.

The whole reception thing was important to people. Catra was right; that was a big part of being She-Ra. To Adora, the idea of a reception felt alien, suffocating—another performance she'd have to put on for a world that expected answers from her.

When Aunt Casta mentioned Angella's return celebration, the relief almost made her dizzy. But the tension never left her shoulders. What they celebrated didn't matter—it would always come back to her. What more could she give? What more did they want?

Her heartbeat pounded louder in her ears, drowning out the conversation around her. The Queen's silence terrified her. It was quiet, heavy, filled with disappointment. Adora could feel it, even when Angella wasn't looking at her directly.

Angella had trusted her with everything. With Glimmer. With Etheria. And Adora had failed. She could still hear Angella's last words to her, quiet but firm: *'Take care of my daughter.'* But she hadn't. She'd let Glimmer fall into Horde Prime's hands. She'd broken the Sword. She'd wasted Angella's sacrifice.

After Adora broke the Sword, Shadow Weaver took every opportunity to explain to Adora what a disastrous decision that had been and how it had squandered their most potent advantage. How she wasted Angella's sacrifice. Micah had heard it once as he came into the tent.

"What did you just say?" he'd growled at Shadow Weaver.

Adora had fled, but not before she overheard him asking Shadow Weaver if she was trying to destroy morale. It made sense—Micah never showed weakness. Adora understood that he wouldn't allow Adora or Shadow Weaver to make the Rebellion look weak or disorganized. People counted on them.

But he never negated the truth of Shadow Weaver's claim. He knew it was true, as did Adora. The best she could do was look convinced when he told others he trusted her.

"You okay?" whispered Catra.

No, Adora was not okay. Her heartbeat hammered in her chest, drowning out the words around her. The walls felt too close, the air too thick. Adora tried to focus on Catra's hand, warm and steady over hers, but it was like grasping smoke; the comfort slipped away as soon as she reached for it. Her palms were damp. She tried to focus on her breathing, but each inhale felt tight and shallow, as though her chest were wrapped in iron bands. She felt sick, and she needed to get out of this crowded room. The main dish was gone. It would not be terribly impolite to get out of here now.

"Um. Your Majesty. Majesties. Uh. Excuse me." Adora's voice cracked, the words tumbling out clumsily. "I… I need to…" She pushed her chair back, the sound loud in the quiet room, and stumbled to her feet. Without waiting for a response, she turned and hurried toward the door, each step quickening until she was running. She didn't even glance back. She needed air, space, anything to escape the weight pressing down on her.

She didn't stop until she reached the skiff. Only then did she let herself breathe.

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Catra had known Adora was overwhelmed, but she hadn't expected her to jump up and run away like that. It was like watching a dam give way, the pressure building before it shattered. And then, without warning, Adora was on her feet, her chair scraping harshly against the floor as she fled.

"Give her a minute," Bow whispered as Glimmer began to stand. He caught her arm, giving her a slight shake of his head.

Catra frowned. Micah, Aunt Casta, and Bow exchanged sad glances but did not move to follow her. Did Adora do this during the war? She used to do it when they were cadets, usually after an especially bad reprimand, barely holding it together until they were dismissed, and then she'd bolt. She always seemed to need a moment alone when that kind of panic hit her. Pushing her too soon would only make it worse.

"What... what just happened?" Angella asked, looking confounded by Adora's sudden flight.

Bow let out a long sigh. "Panic attack," he explained, glancing at Micah as if to confirm his words.

Micah nodded grimly. "I've seen it. She's been hiding it pretty well, but… it's been rough."

Angella's eyes darted between Catra and Bow, her expression shifting from confusion to something closer to fear. "Panic attacks?" she murmured, almost to herself. "Adora always seemed… so capable." The word sounded hollow even to her own ears. "How… how long has she been dealing with this?"

"Since always."

"Since Shadow Weaver..."

"Since we lost…"

Catra, Micah, and Bow began speaking at the same time, their words tumbling over each other before they stopped, each of them looking at the others. For a moment, an uncomfortable silence stretched between them, thick with unspoken memories and half-formed regrets.

Micah finally broke the quiet, turning to Catra with a solemn expression. "Has she always had them?" he asked, his voice

barely above a whisper.

Catra's ears flicked, her throat tightening as she forced herself to stay calm. She should've seen this coming. She *had* seen it coming. "Yes." Her voice was quieter than she intended. She had seen Adora struggling but hadn't realized how often it happened. She should've known Bow would notice, too. "How do you know when she's having one?"

Bow's lips pressed into a tight line. "She gets real quiet, and her knee starts bouncing. She completely checks out, and nothing we say is penetrating. Then, she just… runs.  During the war, she used the excuse that she needed urgent 'training' or something."

Catra swallowed. That sounded exactly like what she'd seen. The realization made her stomach twist uncomfortably.

"Shouldn't we go after her?" Angella asked, her voice uncertain.

Micah shook his head gently. "No. Let her have a moment. She'll come back when she's ready."

Catra's gut twisted, but she knew he was right. Still, knowing didn't make it easier. She clenched her jaw, fighting the urge to chase after Adora.

Knowing she wouldn't like the answer, Catra asked anyway. "What does Shadow Weaver have to do with it?"

Bow hesitated before speaking softly. "After Adora broke the Sword, Shadow Weaver kept… well, she blamed her for everything that went wrong." His normally affable face turned cold. "And I do mean *everything."*

His jaw clenched. Catra had never seen him so pissed off, not even when she dropped him off a cliff.

"Every village that got invaded, every inch of territory we lost—it was all on her. Because she…" He made air quotes with his fingers, "'was too stupid to figure out how keep all that power."'

Bow’s voice grew harder. “I overheard her dragging Adora over the coals about it more than once."

"I heard it too," Micah added, his voice filled with quiet anger. "I stopped it as best I could, but… it left a mark."

Shadow Weaver’s poison still clung to Adora, wrapping around her thoughts, squeezing the life out of her. Catra dug her claws into the arms of the chair again. How many times had that woman torn Adora down under the guise of ‘helping her’? How many times had she convinced Adora that her worth was tied to her ability to lead, to be perfect? Catra clenched her fists. Shadow Weaver was gone, but her shadow still lingered, and Catra was powerless to banish it.

Bow hesitated again, glancing at Glimmer with a silent question in his eyes. She gave him a small, resigned nod, and he continued, his voice more cautious this time. "But… I'm pretty sure this was building, even before that… after you were lost, Your Majesty," he said, addressing Angella, "Adora… she and Glimmer… well… they had some misunderstandings."

"Stop, Bow, it’s okay," Glimmer said quietly, placing a hand on his arm. She lifted her chin though her voice wavered. "What he is trying to tactfully say is that I treated them both—Adora and Bow—like dirt after I became Queen." She took a shaky breath, fighting to keep her composure. "I was… angry and hurt. It-it’s a lot. But, I guess Adora blamed herself for what happened to you and…"

Catra couldn’t hold it in. " *What?!* How the fuck does that work?" Her claws flexed, and she quickly grasped the arms of her chair to avoid tearing into the table. " *Hordak* and Entrapta designed the portal machine. Adora…" She blew out a breath, trying to control her rising frustration. "Adora warned Entrapta. That’s why…" Catra’s voice faltered, then steadied again. "That’s why Entrapta ended up on Beast Island. And *I’m* the one who… pulled the switch." She pressed her palms together, forcing herself to stay

calm. “Melog and I searched for you,” she told Angella. “They said they could sense you were alive somewhere.”

Her words hung in the air, heavy with the weight of unspoken guilt. She dared a glance at Glimmer, who stared back with wide, tear-glossed eyes.

“I wanted… to fix something.” Tearing her eyes away from Glimmer’s, she caught Angella’s gaze. “I didn’t hear what happened to you until me and Glimmer were on Prime’s ship.” Briefly, she closed her eyes and was surprised when Aunt Casta’s arm went around her shoulders. The magicat leaned into the unexpected support. Her body felt heavy, weighed down by the sheer helplessness of watching Adora fall apart, not knowing how to help.

“But right now, I’m worried about Adora.” She ran her hand through her hair. “She sometimes freaked out like that when she was a kid,” Catra added quietly, her voice thick with emotion. “I don’t think she ever stopped doing it. I think she just got better at hiding it.”

“Your Majesty,” Bow bit his lip, seeming to think over his words. “She told me the last thing you told her was to look after Glimmer,” he said to Angella. “And I know she has always…”

Angella’s face went pale. “That’s not what I said.” The words slipped out as if to herself. She stared at the tabletop. “Oh,” she breathed, her voice shaking. “Oh, Adora.” She pressed a hand to her mouth, her eyes brimming with a sudden, terrible regret. "I never meant to give Adora such a burden to carry. I think I will have to speak with her,” Angella finished softly, looking away.

Catra sucked in a breath, her throat tightening as she fought back the rising panic in her chest. She’d seen Adora struggle for as long as she’d known her, but this—this was deeper. It was like Adora was fighting shadows no one else could see. And it seemed all they could do was sit here, helpless and angry, while Adora drifted further away.

“You should all know.” She hoped this was not a mistake.  “She’s hiding something from me,” she admitted, the words slipping out more quietly than she intended. “And I don’t know what it is.”

A silence fell over the room, heavy and uncertain. Everyone looked at each other, but no one had the answers.

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*“They’ve seen you for what you are.”* Shadow Weaver’s cold voice, sharp and unrelenting, echoed in Adora’s mind. “ *When did you become so weak?”*

Her breath hitched. She quickened her pace down the corridor, trying to outrun the voices. Her fists clenched, nails digging into her palms as she pushed herself faster.

Light Hope’s voice sliced through the fog in her mind, cold and clinical. “ *You are She-Ra. That is your purpose. You do not get to choose.”*

The voices grew louder, overlapping.

*“If you truly cared about Catra, you’d focus on protecting her,”* Shadow Weaver hissed, cutting like a blade in the dark.

Adora’s stomach twisted, nausea rising. Her feet carried her faster, but the voices kept coming—intertwining, suffocating. She couldn’t tell where one ended and the other began.

*“Flawed.”* Light Hope’s precise, dispassionate tone dissected her like data.

*“Weak.”* Shadow Weaver’s accusatory words echoed in her mind.

Adora’s breath caught, her pace quickening again.

But then Angella's voice struck deepest, quieter but heavier than the rest. " *Disappointing."*

Adora's heart clenched painfully. She had tried—tried so hard to protect Glimmer, to protect everyone—but she had failed.

*"Take care of Glimmer. Take care of Etheria."*

But she hadn't, had she? She had failed at both.

*"If your best was good enough, my mother would still be here,"* Glimmer had once said. The accusation had hit so hard because she wasn't wrong. Even if Angella had returned, it was still Adora's fault that she had been lost in the first place.

Adora's footsteps echoed down the empty corridor as she moved, barely aware of where she was going. The palace walls seemed to close in on her, the air thick and stifling.

Ahead, she saw a glimmer of moonlight filtering through an open doorway, and without thinking, she sprinted toward it, spilling into the courtyard where the skiff was parked. The cool night air hit her like a shock. After a moment, she threw herself behind the controls and just stood there, closing her eyes and letting the breeze brush against her face.

She wanted to go... somewhere. She felt lost, untethered. Melog appeared beside her with a reproachful chirp, their mane bristling in red spikes of irritation.

Adora winced. Of course, Catra would be angry with the way she'd bolted. She gripped the skiff's controls tightly, her knuckles white. What was she even trying to do? Where could she go? Nowhere felt safe anymore. For a fleeting moment, she thought of Sara, of their dinner together. Sara hadn't expected anything from her.  She'd spoken to her as an equal—soldier-to-soldier. Maybe even friend-to-friend.

That was all Adora wanted. She didn't want people looking up to her. They always expected more than she had to give, and their

disappointment crushed her.

Sara hadn’t been disappointed. Her sharp rebuke—" *You are not special!"* —had felt like a release. A burden lifted—permission to just *be.*

Shadow Weaver, Light Hope, Angella—they’d always told Adora how special she was. But being special hadn’t helped her. It hadn’t made anything easier. If the war hadn’t depended on her, Adora might have been okay with She-Ra disappearing forever after the Sword broke.

"Don’t tell them where I am," Adora begged, her voice cracking under the weight of her panic. "I just… I can’t do this. I want to go home."

Melog blinked at her slowly, their glowing eyes softening. Their mane shimmered, the red spikes smoothing and lightening to a normal light blue as they stepped closer. Their head tilted questioningly.

A broken laugh escaped her, harsh and hollow. She brushed away the tears stinging her eyes. "Yeah, I don’t even know what I mean by that," she muttered, her voice thick. The word "home" felt meaningless now. There was no home anymore.

Her heart slowed, the storm inside her ebbing, leaving her cold and drained. Melog didn’t speak (not that she was likely to understand them unless she transformed), but their presence was a quiet comfort, like a blanket draped over her frayed nerves.

Melog chirped softly, their eyes narrowing in a way that felt both gentle and stern. They nudged Adora’s arm with their head, a soft reminder.

Adora blinked, her heart sinking. "What? You… want me to go back?"

Of course.

Melog huffed and turned their head back toward the palace. No words were needed; Adora understood. They were right. An apology was required.

And Catra had to be livid. Adora had begged her to come to Bright Moon. Insisted on it. Adora wondered what excuses Catra had made for her this time. She always covered for her. *She deserves to be angry.*

"Can you…?" Adora gestured vaguely between herself and Melog. She could not bear the thought of having to speak to some random castle resident.

Magic shimmered over them both, and Adora knew they were invisible now. Meekly, she followed the magical creature.

To her surprise, instead of taking the turn leading to the royal dining room, they turned back toward the rooms she shared with Catra.

"What are we doing?" Adora asked. A thought drifted into her mind: an image of her and Catra's bed, the feel of the sheets, the scent of the pillows.

Melog didn't want her to go back and continue the conversation. They wanted her to go to bed.

Adora couldn't remember the last time she'd had a full night's sleep, uninterrupted by nightmares or waking up soaked in sweat. She hadn't told Catra how often she woke up in the middle of the night, heart racing, her body instinctively ready to transform into She-Ra in self-defense.

She was beginning to fear she might actually take a swing at Catra while she was asleep. Sleeping in a different room would be a good idea, but Adora could not bring herself to mention it. Having Catra sleep next to her was the best part of her day, no matter what else happened.

She was so *selfish.*

Quietly, she crept back to the room, following Melog. No lights were on, and for a moment, Adora wondered if Catra had already left—maybe asked Glimmer to teleport her back to Mystacor. After tonight, she wouldn't blame her.

But then, from the shadows, Catra's soft voice broke the quiet. "Hey, Adora." Her tone was calm—so calm it threw Adora off guard. "You okay?"

A light sparked in the tea nook. Startled, Adora jumped, her nerves raw. Catra struck a match and lit one of the scented candles scattered around the place.

"What are you doing sitting in the dark?" Adora growled defensively, trying to mask her embarrassment, though the sharp edge in her voice betrayed her. "I might've hurt you." She braced herself, waiting for the explosion, the sarcasm, the sharp words.

A soft scoff as Catra put the candle down on the little table. "I doubt it." Catra stayed where she sat on the little loveseat in the tea nook, her silhouette barely visible in the shadows, her eyes faintly glowing in the dim light.

Bewildered, Adora blinked. Catra was not angry?

Catra held out her hand. "Come sit with me?"

Melog nudged Adora gently, urging her forward.

The only light in the room came from the moons and stars outside the window and the tiny candle burning on the table. Catra was warm against her side.

"I'm worried about you," Catra said quietly, her voice so soft it almost didn't sound like her. She scooted over so their sides touched, and Catra gently placed her hand on Adora's knee.

Adora frowned. "What? What do you mean? I'm fine."

"You’re not," Catra said, firmer this time. "And everyone in that room is worried about you."

“They don’t have to worry about me.” Why couldn’t they see she just needed to be left alone? Why couldn’t they stop pressuring her? “I’m *fine!* ” Adora shouted, her voice cracking under the weight of the words.

“Okay, okay, you’re fine,” Catra said hurriedly, clearly not believing it. She nervously ran her hand through her hair. "Look, We don’t have to talk about anything tonight." She drew a long breath in, her hand resting gently on Adora’s leg. “Just stay. Please? That’s all I want.”

Adora’s chest tightened, but she nodded, confused by Catra’s strange agreeableness. She hadn’t expected this softness. She almost didn’t know how to handle it. Tentatively, Adora rested her head on Catra’s shoulder and was rewarded when the magicat's hand came up to pet her hair.

The candle on the table flickered, casting long shadows on the walls. The flame’s dance reflected the unease in Adora’s chest, the last of her defenses slowly crumbling, flickering like the dying light.

“Are you cold? You’re shaking.”

Was she? Adora couldn’t tell. *All she knew was that she was falling apart inside—she didn’t deserve this kindness.*

“I love you, all right?” Catra whispered, her voice soft but firm.

Adora choked back a sob, her throat tightening painfully. “I love you, too,” she whispered, but it tasted of guilt. Everything tasted of guilt.

Her gaze drifted to Catra’s eyes, her pupils huge in the candlelight. Sometimes, Adora thought the reflections in Catra’s eyes were what her soul must look like. The two sides of herself, the blue and the gold—so different, so conflicting.

In the gold, she saw warmth and connection—She-Ra's love, She-Ra's fire. But it was a fire that could burn her to the ground. When she leaned too far into her emotions, it felt like the flames consumed her until she was drowning in feelings she couldn't control.

But in the blue, there was peace. The blue was cool, soothing, like the surface of a calm lake at dawn, untouched by the wind. It promised focus, a way to shut everything out and just act. No second-guessing. No guilt. Just perfect clarity.

"No one was mad, Adora. We're *worried* ."

Adora thought of the cold blue flow of magic, the peace of a calm forest pool. "I told you, I'm…"

"Don't say it," Catra hissed softly, her hand tightening slightly on Adora's knee. She screwed her eyes shut for a moment, then opened them again, her voice a thin whisper. "Do you think we can't see? I can't… *I can't help you* if you keep hiding everything."

On the last word, Catra's voice cracked, and a tremor of fear crept into it. She looked away, her control slipping just for a moment, trying to hold herself together.

Adora opened her mouth to speak, but the words got stuck in her throat. How could she explain it? She couldn't even explain it to herself.

The candle flame flickered again, casting the room into near darkness.

"I thought we agreed… no more secrets," Catra murmured, her eyes locking onto Adora's. Her voice was soft, but the edge in it was unmistakable—a plea, a demand, all in one.

Adora nodded numbly. "Yes."

" *Then let me in.* "

# Homesick

Chapter Summary

Adora is homesick

As always, thanks to my betas, especially Doc and the Notebook Wizard

The next morning dawned too early, spilling pale rose light across the room in soft streaks. Adora lay still, feeling Catra's warmth as she purred softly. The blonde had barely slept, her mind caught in an endless loop despite the bone-deep exhaustion weighing down her limbs.

When Catra had finally fallen asleep, Melog padded over and settled quietly beside her. Their mane pulsed faintly, a calm, rhythmic glow that felt as steady and reassuring as a heartbeat. Adora closed her eyes, letting the hum of their energy soothe her.

"Thank you," Adora told them softly. With Melog, she didn't have to be anything. She didn't have to be a hero, or a leader, or even "fine." They didn't prod her with questions or wait expectantly for answers she couldn't give. When Melog padded up beside her, she felt a quiet acceptance, a sense that she could exist without judgment. She didn't know if she should feel guilty for leaning on them so much.

A low growl from her stomach broke through her thoughts—a gnawing emptiness she'd tried to ignore since last night's dinner. Once, she could push past hunger or pain. Skipping a few meals would not even have registered.

But now… now everything seemed overwhelming, and the slightest thing felt like the end of the world.

A run would help. Adora quickly pulled on last night's leggings and a clean shirt, lacing her boots with quiet precision.

Catra stirred, turning over and opening one eye. She lifted her head just slightly, her voice a sleepy mumble. "Where are you going?"

"For a run." Adora forced a smile, hoping to reassure her. She finished lacing her boot and stood up. "We'll get breakfast when I get back?"

"Okay." Catra flopped back onto the pillow, one arm pulling the blanket closer. "Take Melog?" she muttered into the pillow. "Please?"

Adora sighed, glancing over at Melog, who was already watching her with calm, unreadable eyes. If she'd been making Catra worry this much, she supposed it was only fair. She hadn't meant to become someone who needed watching, but here she was.

Stepping into the hallway, she hurried away, her footsteps soft against the polished floor as if quiet could make her invisible. If she thought Catra wouldn't ask questions, she would have thrown a rope over the balcony. It wasn't just that she didn't want to talk to random people—it was that she didn't even want to be seen. She always felt the weight of eyes on her. Every gaze felt like a spotlight, a reminder that she was supposed to be special.

From the moment she'd sworn her allegiance to the Rebellion in Angella's throne room, she knew they weren't really interested in Adora. They only cared about She-Ra. When she'd revealed her past as a Horde soldier, Angella had downplayed it as if it didn't matter. No one ever talked about it. It felt like a dirty secret, something to hide and dismiss, a part of herself that didn't belong in the image they'd painted of her.

A familiar shimmer of magic rolled over her, cloaking her like a second skin. 'Thank you,' she muttered, grateful for Melog's quiet understanding.

Unseen, she slipped out of the castle gate and down through the valley, her feet pounding against the soft earth. The steady rhythm of her steps helped—a beat that brought her back to the present moment. The wind in her hair, the burn in her lungs, the feel of solid ground beneath her—all of it brought her back into her body, easing the edges of her thoughts.

It didn't work as well as it used to. Running had been enough during the war to shake off the intrusive thoughts, scattering them behind her like dust. But now, they clung to her like burrs, softening only slightly with each step.

She slowed, the ache in her chest only growing, the gnawing emptiness refusing to fade.

*I want to go home.*

The words had slipped out last night, unbidden, when she spoke to Melog.

Homesickness—that was what Bow had called it on Darla. He said it was a longing for the small, familiar things: his dads, his brothers, and the comfort of a place where he belonged.

She had watched Bow long for his family, brothers, and dads. She'd tried to understand, but there was always a gap between them—something Bow could feel and she couldn't. She'd wanted to comfort him, to tell him *she* understood, but she couldn't. The word "home" felt too distant, too empty, like something she'd never had and never would.

And yet…

From her first day at Bright Moon, a dull ache settled into her chest, and it never went away. Always overshadowed by so many other fears and anxieties that Adora never had a chance to think about it. Since talking to Sara the other night, the vague, unformed feeling had begun to crystalize.

There were things about the Horde she *missed* . There always had been. Not the brutality, not the endless fighting, and certainly not Shadow Weaver. But, in the Horde, everything had its place, its purpose. Even the mess hall was orderly—each cadet lining up in formation, eating the same bland food, everyone knowing what to expect.

When the cadets got back to the bunkroom before lights out, they would bind each other's injuries, listen to the latest gossip, joke about their bruises, and compare times or scores. They were a squad- they belonged to each other.

Hanging out with Sara felt like that. She didn't ask loaded questions, didn't look at her with that flicker of pity that always made Adora's stomach clench. It always made her feel like she was broken and needed fixing. But Sara? She didn't need Adora to be anything other than what she was.

Most people in the Horde weren't monsters-just people. People who wanted to go home at the end of the day, who laughed with each other during training exercises and shared the little comforts they could find.

Bright Moon had been so different, so outside of her experience. She loved it here, but she also hated some things. When she first came here, Bow and Glimmer slept in her bedroom until she 'got comfortable. What they did not realize was that Adora had *never* gotten comfortable. The many choices that had to be made daily and the copious unstructured time made her feel unmoored. It was like she was swimming in open water, searching for something to hold onto.

Especially now.

She slowed her pace, feeling the burn in her lungs and the steady pounding of her heart. These early morning runs usually cleared her mind and helped her leave her tangled thoughts somewhere along the path. But today, the memories clung to her, stubborn and relentless.

The morning sun crept higher, casting a warm glow over the valley as she pushed herself up the winding hill. She ran harder as if she could outrun the questions and doubts clawing at her. By the time she reached the crest, she was gasping, her breath coming in harsh, uneven bursts.

Melog trotted up beside her, their mane shifting to a calming blue-green, a quiet reassurance.

"Am I doing this right?" she asked Melog softly, not really expecting a response. But the creature gave a soft chirp, their head tilting in what Adora imagined was sympathy. She didn't have to explain herself to Melog; they seemed to understand her in ways that even Catra struggled with. Melog didn't question her doubts, didn't demand answers she couldn't give.

She straightened, brushing a hand over her forehead to clear the sweat. Maybe it was time to head back. She'd been out here long enough, lost in her own thoughts. Catra would be awake by now, maybe even waiting for her.

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The persistent knocking dragged Catra out of a restless doze. "Who's there?" she yelled, rubbing sleep from her eyes. After last night, she was exhausted, her senses on high alert from waking up every time Adora shifted in her sleep. The last few nights of broken sleep were starting to wear on her.

"Excuse me, Catra?" Glimmer's voice sounded unusually formal, and, for once, she knocked instead of popping in. Hopefully, she was not coming with news of some new crisis.

Catra sighed, staggering upright, lurching to the door, and yanking it open.

And there was Sparkles—along with Sparkles Senior.

“Oh, I beg your pardon,” Angella said, taking a slight step back, clearly surprised. “We can come back in a moment if you... need privacy.”

“Huh? What for?” Catra replied. “Come in.” She waved them inside and headed to her dresser, rooting around for clean clothes. She pulled off the shirt she’d slept in and reached for a bra. “I’m listening. Go ahead.”

Angella looked thrown off, her brows knitting together. Angella’s gaze flicked to Glimmer as if seeking some sort of translation. Glimmer shot her mother a look—probably the closest thing Bright Moon had to a “just roll with it” expression. “Um… in Horde culture, body modesty isn’t really a *thing* ,” she explained, glancing at her mother with an awkward smile.

Catra forced down the urge to snarl. Instead, she rolled her eyes and scoffed, pulling her clean shirt over her head without a second thought. “I grew up in a bunk room. Privacy’s not exactly something we had a lot of.”

Angella’s mouth opened, then closed, her expression shifting to a faint mix of shock and awkward acceptance. Glimmer shot her mother an apologetic look, then turned back to Catra.

“Sorry, Catra,” Glimmer said, clearly trying to smooth over the moment. “We just… well, we wanted to talk to you while Adora was out.”

Catra paused mid-button, her eyes narrowing as she took them in more carefully. “All right,” she said slowly, finishing dressing and crossing her arms. “What’s this about? If you’re here about Adora, just spit it out. Melog says she's on her way back.”

They had not talked much after Adora had fled last night. Given everyone's general exhaustion, they all agreed to table the discussion.

Angella’s expression softened, though there was something uneasy in her gaze. “Yes,” she said simply. “We’re worried about

her."

Catra raised an eyebrow, masking the flicker of anxiety that shot through her at the mention of Adora. "Yeah, well. So am I. Get in line."

Glimmer took a small step closer, her voice gentle but insistent. "We're worried, Catra. And… Maybe you see things we don't."

"You mean you're finally realizing it might be your fault she's like this?" Catra grated, her jaw clenched, her anger flaring in spite of herself. She took a steadying breath, forcing herself to swallow the bitterness rising in her throat.

"Look," she said, her tone harsher than intended. "She's pretty convinced the only reason you guys kept her around was because of She-Ra."

These conversations were a lot easier when Melog could help her keep her temper.

Angella's mouth turned down, her eyes pinched. "I feared that. I'd hoped once the war ended, she might let herself… lean on others more. When I told her to 'take care of each other," I meant for her to share it with Glimmer, but I fear she took it as a mandate to protect everyone around her… at her own expense."

A flash of surprise ran through Catra, but she tried to hide it, tilting her head in feigned indifference. "So, what? You're here to tell me Adora has a hero complex? Wow, big revelation," she muttered sarcastically.

Catra's tail lashed as she crossed her arms, forcing herself to stay still. Every well-meaning question made her want to scream and tear something up, but Melog had grudgingly assured her that Angella was trustworthy—even if she didn't know a thing about magical plants.

Angella hesitated a flicker of something raw passing over her face. "I wanted to ask about Shadow Weaver," she murmured. Her gaze

turned distant, and for a moment, she looked not at Catra but through her.

"Shadow Weaver?" Catra asked.

"I did not realize that Adora had been Shadow Weaver's ward for most of her childhood until she had been here for months. Had I known, I would have dealt with her differently."

Catra blinked, unsure what Angella was getting at. "What do you mean?"

Angella nodded, a shadow crossing her expression. "When I met Micah, he was a prodigy—a young sorcerer with a bright future. But he was… ." Her voice softened as if speaking to herself. "Shadow Weaver was his teacher when she was still Light Spinner. He trusted her completely. But she… twisted him. Used his gifts to further her own power."

Catra's eyes narrowed. That tracked. Adora's loyalty to the old bitch had been unquestioning. "Aunt Casta might have said something about that," she allowed slowly.

Angella went on, "I didn't want Adora or Glimmer anywhere near her after she was imprisoned here." She glanced at Glimmer, her voice pained. "I thought… if I kept you both away, she couldn't reach you. Couldn't manipulate you like she did Micah."

Glimmer's cheeks flushed. "After you were gone," she said quietly to Angella. "I… started taking advice from Shadow Weaver."

Angella paled and sucked in a ragged gasp. "Oh. No."

The young Queen's cheeks were wet with tears. "I let her teach me magic, and then I started taking her advice. She seemed…" she trailed off with a helpless gesture, as if unable to find the words.

"Like she cared about you?" Catra supplied, looking down at the floor.

“Yes,” admitted Glimmer in a rough voice. “I thought… She made me feel special. And like I was good at something. Like I wasn’t a complete failure as a queen.”

“Yeah. She did that,” Catra said with a harsh little laugh. “She was really good at making you think you were important to her. Until she didn’t need you anymore.” Reaching out her hand, she gave Glimmer a little punch on the arm. “You’re not the first person to believe her bullshit.” When Glimmer looked up, Catra finished. “She was that good at it.”

Angella nodded. “Adora’s been under Shadow Weaver’s influence since she was a child. She was trained to believe that her worth is tied to what she can do for others—how much she can sacrifice and how much pain she can bear. And now, without Shadow Weaver’s voice in her ear, I think she’s filled that void with her own guilt.”

“I think I was not as… empathetic as I should have been to her difficulties.” The Old Queen gestured to the room. “I thought she was comfortable here. It did not occur to me that… She was struggling so.“

“Things have been really hard since the war ended,” Glimmer told her mother. “Everything’s different. And then… “ Glimmer looked apologetically at Catra before she went on. “Catra was sick for a bit, and it was pretty serious. I know that Adora was worried to death about her, but at least she’d talk about that. I feel like there’s a lot she’s not telling us.

“She’s not sleeping,” Catra added, the admission slipping out before she could stop herself. “And when she does, it’s… not good.” She grimaced, feeling like she was betraying Adora’s trust but unable to hold it back. “She’s had nightmares so bad, she transformed in her sleep.”

“That’s…” Glimmer’s face went pale, her eyes wide with worry. “That’s not okay.”

Catra scoffed, her frustration bubbling over. “Yeah, I know it’s not okay, Princess, but what am I supposed to do?”

Before anyone could answer, the door creaked open, and Catra’s heart skipped a beat. Adora stood in the doorway, one hand on the doorknob, her eyes darting between the three of them. She looked like a cornered animal, tense and wary, and Catra couldn’t help but feel a twinge of guilt. She knew Adora hated being talked about and hated being seen as anything less than invincible.

Catra forced a grin, trying to look casual. “Hey, there you are. We were just, uh… waiting for you to get back.”

Adora’s eyes narrowed slightly, and her mouth thinned to a line. “Oh?”

Before Catra could think of something reassuring to say, Angella jumped in smoothly. “Yes, dear. We were wondering if you would like to have breakfast with us?”

Catra watched Adora’s face; the tight smile and crease between her eyebrows said she was unhappy, but she nodded.

Glimmer smiled broadly. “We wanted to start planning the reception for next week! We already sent for breakfast to be brought here. Is that okay? We can still…”

“It’s fine,” grunted Adora. Her shoulders dropped as she decided she would stay.

The four of them moved to sit down. They all seemed to be trying to figure out what to say. No one was convinced by Glimmer’s assurance that this was a planning meeting. The awkward silence was cut short by the arrival of the food.

Once the staff put the food on the table, Angella quietly dismissed them, and they served themselves. Catra kept one eye on Adora without looking obvious.

“Tea, Catra?” Angella said blandly.

At the question, Catra's head shot up, and she turned to stare at Angella. The woman's lips were quirked up at the corners.

Melog faded into sight right beside Angella, sniffing at the teapot and giving her a little growl. The startled woman made a sharp movement, nearly dropping the hot teapot, but Melog's magic caught it mid-air, and it floated back to the table near Catra.

Angella blinked at Melog, who was now sitting calmly beside her. A flicker of shock passed across her face before she smoothed it into a polite smile.

"Thank you." She glanced at Glimmer and Catra and cleared her throat. "It seems we have an extra guest for breakfast." She inclined her head toward Melog as though acknowledging an ambassador from another kingdom. "Melog, would you care for tea as well?" She asked seriously.

"I do not care for tea, But you may tell the Old Queen I do enjoy milk," Melog replied with great dignity, settling onto their haunches.

Catra snickered, reaching out to scratch Melog behind the ears. "They don't like tea," she said with a grin. "But they would like a bowl of milk." She glanced over at Adora, hoping the brief bit of humor might ease the tension she could still feel radiating from her.

Adora's lips twitched, almost forming a smile, but then her eyes dropped to the table again. She picked up her teacup, staring down into it as if the steam might hold the answers to unspoken questions. Catra felt a pang of frustration and helplessness. She wanted so badly to fix things for Adora, to make her see she didn't have to bear this weight alone. But every time she tried, it felt like hitting a wall.

Catra took a huge breath and said, "Adora? We wanted to talk to you about…" she trailed off, unsure how to phrase it.

"So… I was right. You were talking about me behind my back?"

Keeping her voice as steady as she could, Catra said, “Adora… they’re just worried. We’re all worried.”

Adora’s eyes flickered to Glimmer, and Catra saw the way she flinched, the tension in her jaw. Resentment flashed through her eyes too—resentment and something worse. Guilt. As if she believed every whispered word was proof that she’d failed them all over again.

“We’re just trying to understand, Adora. None of us think less of you for needing—” Although Glimmer’s voice was gentle, Adora’s face tightened as if the softness were an accusation.

Adora’s face twisted. “I know what you think,” she spat. ”You made that pretty clear. That if I’d been stronger… Angella wouldn’t have lost two years.”

“We don’t…” Angella shook her head. “Adora, we don’t blame you.”

Adora’s eyes shimmered, and she let out a bitter laugh. “Maybe you don’t. But *other* people made sure I knew.” Her eyes went to Glimmer.

“Adora… “ Glimmer whispered. “I never…

“You know what? Never mind.” Adora spun on her heel and yanked the door open. She stopped without looking at any of them and said, “Catra? I’ll meet you in Mystacor. Tonight.”

Then she slammed the door behind her.

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This was stupid. It was dramatic and ridiculous. That was twice now she had fled from a meal with Angella and Glimmer. Shit, this

was twice now she had skipped a meal. Okay, she *had* eaten last night, but she'd been so nervous she could hardly swallow.

Facing Angella felt terrifying, even now, although Adora could not give a reason exactly why. She just knew when she was in the same room her breath clogged her chest and her thoughts skittered away like bugs scattering under a light. She could not think of anything to do other than run.

Why was she *like* this?

For a second, she contemplated finding Bow, but she feared he would just encourage her to go talk to Angella.

This time, when she got to the skiff, she started it.

A familiar shape caught her eye—a shadow that hadn't been there a moment ago, materializing from the soft blue-gray light like an echo of her own uncertainty. Melog padded up beside her, their mane pulsing with a faint, calming glow. They didn't make a sound, only brushed against her leg and looked up at her with those steady, unreadable eyes.

"I'm okay," she told them. "I just can't right now."

"Are you sure you're okay?" Catra faded into sight on her other side.

Startled, Adora yelped and stumbled backward; Catra's hand shot out to steady her. At the touch, for some reason, Adora began to shake. "Was that ambush your idea?" she gritted.

"Huh?" Catra seemed honestly surprised Adora would accuse her of that. "Do you seriously think I'd want to sit around talking about everybody's feeeeelings," she drew the last word out contemptuously, "first thing in the morning?" She glanced at Adora's face and scoffed. "No. Really. They dragged me out of bed."

"To talk about me?"

Catra sighed."Yeah." She reached into the bag on her shoulder. "Here. I brought you some food." She indicated the bag on her shoulder. "If you need to go get your head on straight or whatever, that's fine." Scowling, she looked away as she handed it over. "Just don't be an idiot. I want you in one piece."

"Catra… " Adora's eyes began to fill up with tears.

"But, look," Catra said quickly, "I'm not… Don't think I don't want to be with you. I just… I want to give you your space or whatever if you need it. You don't need to lie about where you are. Okay?" She paused for a second and blinked. A tell that Melog was giving her words somehow. "I-I'm really freaked out that you feel like you can't tell me… but whatever it is… " Catra turned her head towards Melog who chittered at her and then turned back. "Whatever it is… you can… um… tell me when you're ready."

Tears spilled over as Adora ducked her head. She couldn't hide anymore, but the truth felt too heavy to let out. Yet, Catra was there, offering to help her with "whatever," no questions, sight unseen, without even being asked.

Adora hesitated, the words catching in her throat. She wanted to keep it all buried, to hold her fears close and pretend they weren't there. But its weight was crushing, and Catra's hand on her arm was the only anchor she had left. "I'm scared," she finally whispered, the words tumbling out in a broken breath.

For once, Catra didn't have a sharp retort or an exasperated sigh. She stepped closer, her hand still warm and familiar. That one spot of warmth felt like the center of Adora's being for this moment.

"What are you scared of?" Catra asked quietly.

Adora squeezed her eyes shut, the tears hot against her cheeks. She wanted to brush them away, to pull herself together, but the longer she stood there, the more everything she'd been holding back seemed to press forward, demanding to be let out. The weight of it was suffocating.

“I don’t even know anymore,” she admitted, her voice barely more than a whisper. “It’s like… I don’t know who I’m supposed to be. During the war, I had to save everyone, to fix everything. But now… no one needs She-Ra anymore. And if I’m not her, then…” Her fists clenched, nails digging into her palms. “What good am I?”

Much to Adora’s surprise, Catra nodded, a flicker of understanding in her eyes. “Yeah. Okay. I get that. I mean, I really get that.” She glanced toward the archway leading to the castle. “I told Sparkle Senior you’d probably need some time. She said you could call her when you feel up to it.”

Hot shame burned in Adora’s stomach. She put her hands over her face. “She must think I’m so pathetic…”

“Honestly, I don’t give a fuck what she thinks,” Catra said sharply, her hands moving to rest on Adora’s shoulders. “You don’t need to prove anything to anyone. She’s worried about you, that’s all. So are Sparkles and the rest. I promise, no one’s mad.”

Adora peeked out at Catra’s worried face, and for the first time, she felt a flicker of relief.

“And if you need time alone,” Catra said, her gaze steady, “I get it.” Her eyes met Adora’s, wide and unblinking.

Catra was the only person who always saw *Adora* , not just She-Ra. When Catra teased Adora about her love of routine, it was with the understanding of someone who had needed that structure, too. She didn’t see Adora as an oddity—she understood. Unlike anyone else, Catra knew the things that had shaped her: the love of routine, the discipline, the comfort of knowing her place. In the Horde, rules and roles were everything, and structure was survival.

Bright Moon was nothing like that; it was a place built on whim and comfort, where people followed their hearts more than

orders. It should have been paradise… but it felt like quicksand. If she lost her footing, she might sink, and no one would notice.

"I just… I don't know how to fit here anymore," she murmured, glancing down. "During the war, I had a purpose. A job. Now I'm just…" She crossed her arms, her voice bitter. "Window dressing."

Catra regarded her for a long moment, no trace of mockery in her eyes.

"You know, if you're looking for something concrete to do… Kyle's been asking for someone to do a survey out at that refugee camp. They're working with Entrapta's people. Working on medical tech for some injured folks." She hesitated, then added, "This wouldn't need She-Ra at all. Entrapta's going to be there with Sara and a few others."

"What do they need?" Adora asked, cautious but intrigued.

"We don't know. That's why you're going. Part of the peace treaty has the Alliance sending reps to do periodic surveys to assess needs."

That sounded… doable.

"All you have to do is take notes when Entrapta tells you what they need out there." Catra's mouth quirked into a small smile. "It's just the sort of thing you like—putting things in straight lines and checking boxes."

Adora's lips curled into a faint smile, one that felt natural for the first time in days. Catra was right; that kind of task was perfect. Surveys and inventory were easy duty.

"Report back to the Joint Council with the needs analysis." Catra's tone softened. "And it's okay if it takes a day or two." She reached out, gently stroking Adora's cheek. "Just check in, okay? You know I worry about you."

The acceptance where she expected pushback made Adora dizzy with relief and gratitude. A huge burden lifted from her shoulders and she let out a breath she did not know she was holding. Catra understood her. She always had. She knew Adora would be better off with a distraction rather than the heavy and intense talks that Glimmer and the rest seemed to want.

Putting her hand over Catra's, Adora nodded. "I love you so much," she whispered.

# Camp

Chapter Summary

Adora visits with Kyle and Rogelio

Chapter Notes

As always thanks to my betas

They shared breakfast on the skiff before Adora left. Catra sent the mission details to Adora's compad, and they watched the morning sun climb higher. By the time they'd finished eating, Adora had felt steadier, bolstered by Catra's support. Just as she was leaving, Catra caught her hand, pulling her in close. "I love you. Okay?" she murmured, her eyes holding Adora's. "And Sparkles is just worried."

The mention of Glimmer had made her heart sink, but Catra seemed to read her mind, squeezing her shoulder in reassurance.

"Hey, hey." She cupped Adora's cheeks and met her eyes. "It's okay. She knows it's been a lot.  And with everything going on… with me…" Catra hesitated, her voice soft. "I know it's gotta feel overwhelming."

"I'm sor…"

"Shh." Catra stopped her. "Don't." she said. "You don't have anything to apologize for, got it?"  Glancing at Melog, who lounged nearby, she went on. "This is pretty much Melog's idea." She jerked her head at them. "They thought maybe you'd like this project, and it might take your mind off things. When you're ready, I'll meet you back in Mystacor? All right?"

"Okay." Adora nodded, relief flooding through her. "Thank you," she said sincerely to Melog. The thought of leaving Bright Moon behind felt like a weight lifting, even just for a few days.

“Don’t thank them yet,” Catra smirked. “I’m glad you think it's a good idea, but you’re going to have to work with Kyle. You’ll probably need to make sure he and Entrapta don’t blow the place up somehow.”

Adora laughed a little at that, and she felt a flicker of lightness for the first time in days.

It took her the rest of the morning to reach the camp, but she didn’t mind. The drive had cleared her head, and as she approached the place, she felt… ready.

The refugee camp lay nestled at the edge of the Whispering Woods, about twenty-five clicks south of Spire. Adora took in the rows of makeshift shelters clustered around a few permanent buildings—old Horde supply depots with rusted walls and patched roofs. The air here was cool, tinged with the earthy smell of damp leaves and wood smoke. Tucked under a sheltering cliffside, it was an extremely defensible spot, probably why so many were gathered here.

There were *so many* children.

The sight of them—wide-eyed, wary, clinging to each other—made her heart clench. According to the data Catra had sent to her compad, most of the people here were Horde: former soldiers, and support staff who’d fled Prime’s invasion. Many of them were chipped at some point.

Guilt burned in her chest, acid and familiar. But there was something else, too—something like nostalgia. These were her people, the ones she’d grown up with. She recognized the games the kids played and the way the cadets talked. It felt like a piece of her past, one she thought she’d left behind but could never truly escape.

When Catra had suggested this mission, a part of her—a part she hadn’t realized was so desperate for direction—had leaped at the idea. Something practical. Something she could do without

needing to be She-Ra. It was exactly what she needed: a purpose that didn't come with the crushing weight of saving the world. For the first time in weeks, the overwhelming dread inside her felt like it was loosening its hold.

Parking the skiff, Adora let her gaze wander, taking in the quiet hum of activity around the camp: the muffled laughter of children playing nearby, the distant clink of metal as someone worked to repair a broken shelter pole.

She barely had time to check in at the central building before she spotted Kyle hurrying toward her, a broad smile lighting up his face. "It's great to see you!"

She opened her arms, letting him pull her into a hug. Kyle had grown—as when she'd seen him a couple of months ago, he seemed so much taller and more robust. Or that may just have been the new confidence he carried himself with. "Kyle! Catra said you're working here?"

Kyle's face flushed, looking for a moment like the awkward boy she remembered. "Uh, yeah! Actually, this is kinda *our* project."

"Ours?" Adora asked, raising an eyebrow.

"Yeah… um, it's me, Rogelio, and Lonnie. "

"How did all these kids get here?" They were a good three-day hike from the Capital.

"When the invasion happened, some people stole transports and loaded as many kids as they could." Kyle explained, "They knew this was here. These cliffs make it hard to spot, so it was pretty safe." He gestured at the overhanging rock. "The three of us heard some refugees were gathering here and came to see if we could help."

"Wow," Adora said, genuinely impressed. "You set all this up?"

"Yeah, although not all the kids are Horde. Some come from the border villages that Prime decided to make an example of." He turned grim. "Probably the worst fighting Lonnie, Rogelio, and I saw. It was at the very end." He shuddered. "Prime purposely kept going after civilian targets." He paused and sighed. "I guess we know where Hordak learned that one. "

Adora's stomach tightened. She remembered Thaymore and dozens of other villages where infirmaries and schools had been hit.

"You know, when we were still fighting the Rebels, I was super glad when Catra told us we weren't using those tactics anymore." He suddenly seemed to realize who he was talking to. His cheeks turned pink, and he hurried to change the subject.

"But, anyway… " Kyle shrugged, his shy smile reemerging. "We've been keeping it going since the war ended. It seemed like people needed a place to catch their breath before heading home."

She looked around at the bustling camp, understanding now the scope of what they'd taken on. "Why are so many kids still here?"

Kyle's face grew serious. "Most of them are orphans. They don't have anywhere to go or anyone but each other."

The unspoken words hung in the air—"like us." Adora understood. The five of them had grown up without parents, clinging to each other like these children. The Horde had given her purpose, but it had never given her a home.

Here, Kyle, Rogelio, and Lonnie were creating something amazing: a place where these children might finally feel safe and learn to be something other than soldiers.

"We're trying to reunite them with family or, if that's not possible…" Kyle swallowed and cleared his throat. "We want to find placements. We're coordinating with Agatha and Scorpia to get the kids back into school, but we need some instructors. And… "

His expression tightened, and his voice dropped. "A lot of these kids have injuries—complicated ones. That's why Entrapta's people are here. They're working on prosthetics, treatments for nerve damage… things like that. And we're always running low on supplies."

"Oh." Adora bit her lip, feeling a renewed sense of purpose.

"Anyway, that's why we need the survey done," Kyle explained. "We need a lot of stuff."

"Okay, but… why me? Couldn't Entrapta handle that on her own?" Adora asked, still a little uncertain.

Kyle chuckled. "She's amazing at building stuff, but explaining it all in a report? Not so much. Plus, we needed someone from the Alliance if we wanted to apply for funds from the Joint Committee." He grinned, shaking his head a little. "I thought they'd send some prissy Princess who didn't know her ass from a hole in the ground, you know? When Catra called to say you were coming, I was thrilled."

His earnest praise gave Adora a small surge of pride—and maybe a touch of relief. This was something she could handle, something concrete and achievable. *Thank you, Melog,* she thought.

With a nod, she turned to Kyle. "Okay. Let's get started."

For the next hour, Kyle showed her around the whole camp. His excitement was contagious; Adora found it hard to remember she was only here for a survey.

As they walked, he explained how they were handling the logistics of a camp of mostly children. They needed some adult volunteers. The oldest cadets- the ones almost old enough for field duty- had been pressed into helping run the camp, and though they really were doing a great job, they needed support.

It was fun to watch Kyle, so obviously proud of their work, as he chatted with various people around camp. It was clear that he

was well-liked and respected. This man was very different from the failure of a cadet Adora grew up with, the one they used to protect from bullying in the showers.

Kyle was a terrible soldier because he never should have been one. Here? Here, he was in his element. He answered questions, gave orders, and listened to complaints with the same cheerful air. It seemed they could not go ten steps without someone needing to speak with him.

The list of what they needed was extensive, not even counting what they needed for Entrapta's project. They needed children's clothing. Bedding. Medical supplies. Water purifying equipment. Educational materials. Adora dutifully entered Kyle's wish list into the compad.

Eventually, they made their way to the large medical tent set up beside one of the smaller buildings. Rather than going into the tent, Kyle grabbed Adora's hand and dragged her into the building.

The front room looked like a standard medic waiting room; chairs lined up in several neat rows, and at the front, a desk stacked with paperwork. No one was waiting, but Rogelio sat with a dark-skinned young man at the desk, reviewing some forms.

Before Adora could take in more than that, Kyle called, "Hey! Rogelio! Look who the Alliance sent for the survey!"

Rogelio exclaimed something warmly in his native Lizardspeak, then jumped up and bounded over to wrap Adora in a hug and lifted her off the ground.

"Hi!" Adora giggled, returning the hug. "It's great to see you too!"

The lizard man set her on her feet and beamed down at her, baring his sharp teeth.

The man who had been working with Rogelio came over.

"This is Sara's assistant, Trevor," Kyle said politely.

"Oh! We've met, too!" Adora told Kyle,  grinning at the younger man.

He saluted. "It's great to see you again, ma'am!"

"What are you doing here?" Adora asked, pleased at another friendly face. "So they made you Sara's assistant?"

"Yep. Sara asked for me specifically," he said proudly. "I'm training with the medics."

"Really?" Adora was surprised. Medics in the Horde did not have the same status as healers in the rest of Etheria. Perhaps now that could change.

"Yes, ma'am!" He grinned, "And after we get a team of medics in here, I'm going to be assigned here for the long haul."

"Oh, that sounds great!"

"She's doing the survey for the Joint Committee, so we should show her what Sara's doing!" Kyle said enthusiastically. "Come on," he told Adora unnecessarily. "It's really cool."

"I can finish this, sir," Trevor told Rogelio deferentially, waving at the forms on the table. "If you want to visit with our VIP."

The lizard man growled in approval and handed his clipboard to Trevor.

"Where's Lonnie?" Adora asked Kyle.

"Oh, she's got some kids classes she's teaching. We'll see her after dinner. Catra said you might stay for a couple of days?"

"I don't know, I mean…" Adora said hesitantly.

The two men glanced at each other, and then Kyle said, "I kind of wish you would, honestly. We want to expand the project… All

these kids are depending on us, and we don't want to let them down, but… Well, with all the competing priorities… I'm kind of afraid these kids will get lost. You know?"

Rogelio grunted and growled, gesturing at Adora with his claw. *"To you, they'll listen."*

Kyle nodded in agreement. "Yeah, he's right. They'll listen to you. I think any report you give will probably get a lot more attention from the Alliance. Scorpia's being pretty generous, but… "

"I'll do my best for you guys. I promise."

The hope in Kyle's and Rogelio's eyes made her realize how much this place and the people here meant to them.

Kyle led them down the hall, talking animatedly about the project.

"Come on. A few of Entrapta's people are here working with some of the kids. I want you to see what they're doing! It's really cool!" He grinned. "I guess you know Sara? She said her daughter was Catra's aid."

Adora returned the smile. "Oh, yeah, I know Sara! I knew she was working with Entrapta." Today was shaping up to be a much better day than it started.

"Yeah. Scorpia put her in charge of this project. She got here yesterday. The rest of the medics are due tomorrow."

Kyle opened a door to a room with a one-way mirror and beckoned her in. He closed the door before he went on. "She requested this assignment. Said it was important to her." He glanced at Adora. "She's helping these kids with… well, with a lot. Stuff that's hard to even talk about."

Without another word, Adora focused her gaze on the room beyond the mirror, letting herself get lost in the gentle, hopeful scene unfolding before her.

The room beyond the mirror was set up like a playroom. Books and games on the shelves, toys in the toy box. A couch and a few battered but comfy chairs completed the impression.

Sara crouched down to eye level with the child, her voice gentle and reassuring. "Hey there," she said.

"My name's Sara. What's your name?"

The lizard-type child looked up with wide eyes and whispered something Adora couldn't quite catch from behind the one-way mirror.

Sara smiled softly, undeterred by the child's shyness. She shifted to sit cross-legged on the floor, setting the small case she carried on the floor beside them, and kept her voice low and kind. "Do you remember all those measurements the medics took last week? Did they tell you why we needed them?"

The child nodded hesitantly, eyes still fixed on the toy soldiers she had been using one hand to play with.

" *They said… you were making me a new arm thing.* " The little girl wiped her nose with her shoulder. Adora's Lizardspeak was a little rusty, but she still followed easily enough as the little girl answered Sara.

"That's right," Sara said, her tone gentle but steady. "I'm building it just for you."

Behind the mirror, Adora glanced at Kyle, who stood beside her, his usual cheerful expression replaced with something more somber.

"What happened to her?" Adora asked.

"She was caught in a bombardment," Kyle explained, his voice quiet. "Prime's forces razed her village. Lonnie and I found her in the rubble of what used to be her home. We got her to one of our

medics in time. Saved her life… but the infection set in. The arm didn't make it."

Adora winced, her stomach twisting. She had been part of so much destruction, but at least this child's injuries were not on her head.

Through the glass, Sara continued, opening the case with a small, encouraging smile. "Do you want to see it?"

The child hesitated for a moment before nodding slowly.

Sara lifted the sleek mechanical arm from the case, its smooth metal gleaming in the soft light of the lab. "Your new arm is going to be just like this one," she said, her voice warm and patient. "This one is a loaner for you to learn on. While you're learning, I'm going to make one that's designed just for you. It'll take some getting used to, but I'll be here to help you every step of the way."

Adora felt a lump form in her throat as she watched the child's expression shift—first fear, then wonder, and finally, a flicker of hope.

Sara held the arm out gently, letting the girl examine it at her own pace. "You're going to be able to do everything you did before once you learn to use it."

The child reached out with her remaining hand, tentatively touching the new arm as if testing its reality. " *It's not the same,* " she whisper-growled, her voice shaking.

Sara's smile softened, her tone serious but still kind. "No, it's not. You'll have to learn to use it. And it will feel different. The sensors in it will give it a sense of touch, but I'll have to calibrate it for you as you grow."

*"Is it… magic?"* the child breathed.

"Nope." Sara lightly tapped the metal arm with her fingers as if to reassure herself and the child. "Everything here is just metal and

wires, put together in a way that lets your brain talk to it. No spells, no magic."

The child looked at her, her scaly brow furrowed. " *Really? Just… metal?"*

"Just metal and tech," Sara confirmed, her tone calm and patient. "I work with Entrapta. I help her design these. When we make your custom one, we can give it a softer skin that matches your scales if you want, or maybe put designs on it."

The girl stared at the arm, chewing on the claw of her remaining thumb, seeming to consider it. Slowly, the child nodded, her hand inching closer to the arm. She still looked hesitant, but some of the fear in her eyes began to fade, replaced by a flicker of tentative curiosity.

"You don't have to use it if you don't want to, but I think you should give it a try."

The girl stared at it for a long time.

"Does the arm that's gone still hurt sometimes?" Sara asked.

The girl nodded.

"That's because your brain still thinks it should be there and can't understand why it isn't following orders. So it keeps sending signals, but then the circuit gets overloaded, and they turn into pain."

Adora watched, feeling the tightness in her chest grow. The words echoed painfully inside her. Could pain linger even when the cause was long gone?

She thought of the people she'd wounded—those caught in her path as She-Ra. What pain had she left that couldn't be healed?

"Entrapta and the medics worked out a way to make it feel better. Want to try it?"

The little girl nodded.

“Okay.” Sara stood, walking to the little child-sized table in the corner of the room and taking the case with her. She sat on the full-sized chair, putting the case and the arm on the table. “Come on over here and have a seat.”

When the girl sat down, Sara directed her to put both feet on the floor and her remaining hand palm down on the table. “Close your eyes for a second,” The child complied, and the specialist set the mirror facing the child's remaining arm, propping it up where the missing one should rest.

“Now look.”

Adora leaned forward, trying to make sense of what Sara was doing. “What’s she doing?” she asked quietly. The table they sat at gave Adora a profile view of both of them. The mirror's optical illusion made it look like the other hand was intact.

Kyle glanced at her and shook his head. “I’m not sure. It’s the first time I’ve seen her work.”

The child looked down at her two hands—one real, one reflected.

“Now, make a fist with both hands,” Sara instructed.

“ *But…* ” the girl started, her voice unsure. She made a fist, and it looked like she made one with both hands.

“We’re trying to trick your brain into thinking the arm is still there and doing what it tells it to. It’s strange, but it really helps.”

The girl’s brow furrowed in confusion. She looked down at her hands. *“But… it doesn’t feel the same.”*

Sara’s smile didn’t falter. “That’s okay. Remember, it’s just pretend. Now, put your real hand flat on the table again and imagine both hands doing the same thing. Think about what the table feels like. Is it hard or soft? Hot or cold? Smooth or rough?”

The girl nodded, narrowing her eyes in concentration. Then, her eyes snapped open in surprise. " *Oooh!* " she exclaimed, almost roaring in her excitement, her face lighting up. " *I can feel that* !"

Sara grinned, her warmth contagious. "That's going to help with the phantom pain. And we're also going to use the mirror to map your nerves. It'll help me calibrate the arm I'm building. It won't hurt, I promise."

The girl nodded again, this time with a little more confidence.

"When we finish mapping, we'll use that to position the contacts in your arm. That way, it'll understand what your brain wants it to do more easily, and you'll even be able to feel what you touch," Sara explained.

The girl looked skeptical as if it sounded too good to be true.

"Can I show you something?" Sara asked, her tone a little softer.

The girl nodded, somberly curious.

Sara pushed her chair back, rolled up her pant leg, and removed the brace from her knee, unclipping the magnetic fasteners, revealing her lower leg—nothing but scar tissue stretched tight over bone.

Rogelio growled low in his throat, and his tail flicked in agitation. Kyle's fists tightened at his sides, his jaw clenching as he looked away from Sara's leg. Adora could feel the tension radiating from them; they barely contained their anger at the sight.

"My tank was flipped in a battle," Sara told the girl calmly, her voice steady. "I got trapped underneath and burned on the metal. All the muscles in this part of my leg were burned to the bone."

Adora clenched her fists, too. Sara spoke about the battle as though it was a natural disaster. No names, no blame. She'd said, "My tank *was flipped* ." Not, " *She Ra* flipped my tank." And Adora could have wept with gratitude.

Neither of her former squadmates gave any sign that they knew how Sara got injured, and Adora sincerely hoped they never found out. She did not think she could bear how they would look at her.

"I was afraid I'd never walk again," Sara finished. She clipped her brace back on and slid her pant leg down again.

The child blinked up at her, wide-eyed. "But… my arm's completely gone," the girl said, her voice small.

Sara gave her a gentle smile. "Let me show you something else."

She turned, pulling her T-shirt up slightly to reveal a small silver disk glowing softly in the small of her back. Silvery lines radiated outward from the glow.

"I had *a lot* of problems," Sara explained, looking over her shoulder. "But then Entrapta started working on Hordak's armor. I used her designs to make this." She met the child's gaze again, her voice full of quiet confidence. "If you give me a chance to help you, I think you'll be happy you did."

The little girl stared at the mechanical arm, doubt clouding her face. "What if… what if it doesn't work right?" she whispered, her voice trembling.

Sara nodded confidently. "Then we'll make it work," she said firmly. "I want you to be able to live your life the way you want to. I believe you'll be able to do that." She stood up. "Watch what I can do now."

Making sure the child was watching, Sara stood on her bad leg, balancing with her other foot tucked up against her thigh. She wobbled and held her hands straight out from her shoulder for a second. She shifted her foot until she stabilized, slowly raising her hands to the ceiling, then pressed her palms together over her head.

Perfuma frequently did this during her yoga sessions, and the image of Perfuma giving yoga lessons to the Horde seemed

ludicrous. But Sara stood in her tree pose, grinning down at the child.

"See. My leg works just fine." She wobbled some more and put her foot down. "It took a while, and it isn't exactly like my old leg, but it's good enough that I could do field duty again."

As Sara lowered her foot and grinned, Adora found herself in awe. Here was someone who had every reason to be angry, to be bitter—but instead she was here, offering hope to others.

Sara gracefully dropped back to her chair. "Your arm is going to be like that. It won't be perfect at first, but that's okay. We'll make a lot of mistakes. We'll just keep working. Entrapta says that 'imperfection is beautiful.' "

The lizard girl bared her teeth in what most would mistake for a snarl, but Adora, who'd grown up with Rogelio, recognized the timid flicker of a smile.

The weight of her guilt pressed down on Adora with every breath. Sara could forgive. But Adora wasn't sure she could ever forgive herself.

"But you have to work with us, okay? This will be hard. I'm not going to lie. But I'll help you all I can."

The child drew herself up tall where she sat, raising her chin. "I'll be brave."

"I know you will," Sara replied, her smile bittersweet. "And it's okay if you feel scared sometimes. Being brave means facing what scares you, and you will always have to face this. People like us have to be brave. We have no choice. "

Watching the child's resolve harden, Adora felt something shift inside her. If this little girl could find her courage again, piece by piece, maybe there was a way forward for her, too.

“You want some supper?” Kyle asked as Sara continued the session. “Sara will be a while. She can join us later and brief you on what she needs. “

“I could eat.” Adora smiled.

They went to the mess tent, where the warm smell of freshly baked bread mingled with the sharper scent of pickled vegetables. Adora was once again surprised by the variety of food available—more ration bars than she'd like, but they also had fruit and fresh bread, soft and golden from the ovens.

Outside, children's laughter echoed from somewhere nearby, mixed with the distant hum of a generator. She felt an unexpected warmth settle in her chest; what Kyle, Lonnie, and Rogelio had built here was amazing.

They collected their meal and sat down. “So, how’ve you been?” asked Kyle, his eyes serious, but the warmth in his voice made it clear he genuinely wanted to know.

“Not- not great,” she replied honestly.

Instead of questioning her, he nodded soberly. “Yeah. A lot of people are having a tough time. I mean… everything is different now.”

For some reason, that acknowledgment helped. It seemed like everyone around Bright Moon was adjusting to the peace effortlessly.

“I just feel like… “ She glanced up from her plate into Kyle’s face. “I don’t know what to do with myself, I guess. You guys are making such a difference here.” She gestured to take in the surrounding camp. “I feel like nothing I do has any meaning anymore.” She dropped her hand back onto the table.

“I told you we desperately need help here.” Kyle smiled. “Do you think you want to sign up?”

The familiar weight of responsibility pressed down on her shoulders. She was supposed to be here for a survey, not to get involved.

Except… what else was she doing? Nobody needed She Ra these days except for the diplomatic meet and greets, the social bullshit that she hated. And Catra was a lot better-- she did not need Adora lurking in the background and tagging along behind her everywhere, waiting for something to go wrong.

She looked into Kyle's hopeful eyes. She realized how much this place and these people mattered to him. It would be work she didn't need to be She Ra for. Since becoming She Ra, she had almost forgotten who *Adora* was.

She nodded, her heart lighter at the idea. "Yeah. I think I am."

# Hot Spring

Chapter Summary

Adora and Catra reunite after a few days apart

Chapter Notes

CW: A tiny dollop of gentle smut.
As always, thanks to my betas

Catra sat on the railing of the main steps, watching for signs of a familiar blonde ponytail. She would not have believed she could miss Adora so much after merely a few days apart. But it was the longest they had been separated since the war ended, and she'd been restless the entire time.

The trip seemed good for Adora. Melog had been absolutely right when they suggested it. Every night, she called to share updates about her work and the gossip she'd heard at the refugee camp, sounding more like herself than she had in ages.

Catra spotted her—a flash of blonde moving through the courtyard. "Hey! Adora!" Catra yelled, jumping to her feet.

Adora's face lit up. Without missing a beat, she bounded up the steps two at a time, grinning like an overeager puppy. Catra smirked but couldn't resist meeting her halfway, bounding down the steps on all fours. When she was close enough, she sprang up and threw herself into Adora's arms, wrapping her arms and legs around her wife without a trace of shame.

"Hi!" Adora squealed, laughing as she caught her. "Miss me?"

"Naw." Catra nuzzled against Adora's neck, breathing in her scent and rubbing her cheek along Adora's shoulder, marking her with her own. She pressed a gentle kiss against Adora's neck, letting her warmth settle all the nervous energy in her chest. "Not really," she murmured.

Adora giggled, and the sound was music to Catra's ears. "Brat." The fondness in her voice made Catra's heart quiver. Adora didn't let her go, carrying her up the last few steps, ignoring the amused glances from passersby.

When they reached the landing, Adora finally set her down, her gray eyes shining. "Did I miss anything here?"

Catra reached for her hand, lacing their fingers together as they walked. "Sparkles and I put the final plans for the reception together. We thought it'd be good optics to invite a lot of guests from the Horde—Hordak and Entrapta already said they're coming. Scorpia and her Council, too." She shrugged, trying to seem casual. "Figured we'd invite Kyle, Lonnie, and Rogelio."

"Oh, that sounds great." Adora smiled, raising Catra's hand to her mouth and kissing her knuckles, making Catra's cheeks flush. "What about Sara and Derrick? He's head of Capital security now, and Sara's running the refugee medical project."

Catra nodded, pretending to consider it even though she'd already planned to send them invitations. "Sure, I'll add them. Trevor and Felina, too." She smirked. "Happy?"

"Very." Adora grinned, and Catra's heart fluttered. This was it. She took a steadying breath, feeling her pulse quicken. She'd planned this out carefully, but now it was time to say it, and her stomach was tying itself into knots.

"So, um…" she started, struggling to sound casual. "Did you still want to do one of the mineral baths?"

"Now?" Adora's face lit up. "That sounds amazing. I'm so stiff from the ride."

For some reason, Catra felt her cheeks heat, and an unbearable shyness came over her. "I… um… booked one of the private mineral pools for us this afternoon and evening," she muttered. "And ordered lunch sent up." Aunt Casta had helped her with all the arrangements, but it felt too embarrassing to admit out loud.

Adora's eyes widened, her grin growing even brighter. "You did that? For us?"

Catra rolled her eyes, trying to play it cool even as her cheeks flushed. "Yeah, yeah. Don't make a big deal about it." She squeezed Adora's hand a little tighter. "We can head straight up there if you want."

"Absolutely!" Adora said, bouncing on the balls of her feet with excitement. "I can't believe you did all that."

"I cleared my whole afternoon," Catra added, her tail twitching nervously behind her. "So we've got plenty of time."

In the middle of the hallway, Adora stopped and turned to face her, her gaze warm and tender, making Catra's stomach flip. She reached out, gently brushing a stray strand of hair behind Catra's ear. "That's so sweet. Thank you."

For a moment, Catra was drowning in Adora's eyes—the color of storm clouds over the ocean, deep and soft and so full of warmth. She wanted to say something smart or flippant, but her voice wouldn't work. Instead, Adora leaned in and kissed her, leaving them both breathless.

When they pulled back, Catra's heart was pounding. She cleared her throat, hoping to sound normal, but her voice came out breathy. "Come on," she said, glancing around, half-expecting someone to give them a scolding about public displays of affection. "I don't need everyone in the place to see us making out."

Adora giggled again, and Catra decided that was probably one of her favorite sounds in the world.

They reached the level of the mineral pools, and Catra led them to a door she'd unlocked earlier. She fished a small key from her pocket, glancing up at Adora with a quick, shy smile before turning the lock and pushing the door open.

The room beyond was softly lit, the warm glow reflecting off the steaming mineral pool where rose petals floated thick on the surface. A sweet floral scent filled the air, mingling with the mineral warmth. A small fireplace crackled cheerfully in the corner, casting a cozy glow over a settee against the far wall. Two plush, white robes hung on hooks by the door, and a tray with covered dishes waited nearby, promising an indulgent lunch.

Catra glanced back. She'd put this together, but now that they were here, her nerves frayed when she couldn't read Adora's expression.

"I, uh, thought you'd like the flowers," she mumbled, her voice barely above a whisper. "Aunt Casta helped me make the arrangements. She said it's, um… traditional. Like, when people get married, they take time off work and go on a trip together. And a lot of people come here for that, so…" She trailed off, realizing she was babbling, and grabbed her twitching tail to keep it still. "Anyway. So… what do you think?"

Adora's face softened, her eyes filling with something warm and deep. "Catra, this is… perfect. Thank you."

The way Adora looked at her right then made Catra's fur puff out involuntarily, and she felt a flush spread across her face. She cleared her throat, rolling her eyes to cover her embarrassment.

Catra threw the latch on the door. "So… do you want to eat first or…?

A thin wisp of desire threaded itself through Adora's scent, and she smiled wickedly. "Not really hungry for food yet," she teased with a playful glint in her eye.

Catra hesitated for a moment, her stomach clenching. *Nope. You do not get to ruin this,* she thought at the ghosts in her head. "Who are you, and what have you done with my wife?" Catra quipped though the teasing edge faltered as a flicker of unease tightened her chest.

That warm chuckle broke the moment, the wicked smile softening into something playful, light, and easy. The shadows at the edges of her mind began to lift.

“I actually had a sandwich half an hour ago,” Adora admitted.

No green light. No shattering of reality. The relief made Catra giddy. She shucked off her shirt. “All right then, I can wait ten minutes.”

“Catra?” Adora said softly, coming up behind her and wrapping her arm around Catra’s bare midriff. “This is beautiful.”

Catra turned around in her arms. “Yeah? You like it?”

“I do like it.” Adora bent to kiss her, then fiddled with the drawstring of Catra’s loose pants. “Can I help you with these?”

“Yeah. That would be great.” She had not bothered to wear a bra today, so she was already naked from the waist up. “But only if I can help you with this.” She fingered the hem of Adora’s shirt.

An odd shiver passed across Adora’s face, and a hint of fear spiked in her scent.  A flicker of something distant, something dark, passed through her eyes before she shook her head quickly, “Um. Okay.”

“Adora?” Catra asked, pulling her hand back. “You okay?”

“No.” Adora’s hands hovered at the hem of her shirt, her fingers curling slightly. "I mean, yes.” She laughed softly, too bright and not quite meeting Catra’s eyes. “I mean…" She trailed off, her chest rising and falling in slow, deliberate breaths. Her breath hitched, and her gaze darted away. “I’m fine,” she said, but the tightness in her voice betrayed her.

A surge of protectiveness rose in Catra, and she gave Adora’s arm a gentle squeeze. “Hey, it’s okay,” she whispered, letting her hands drift slowly up and down Adora’s arms, grounding her. “It’s just me. We can take our time, you know?.”

As Catra let her fingers trace down Adora's arm, she thought about how Adora had always been the one who led. The magicat had let her have it while her body was still healing from everything she had been through. It felt good to be cared for. Adora breathed praise into her ears while her hands explored her worshipfully. Anything Catra had ever done with her own hand paled compared to what she felt as Adora's calloused hands ghosted over her thighs. She reveled in the sweetness of Adora's soft mouth and skin.

However, it was never in Catra's nature to be passive. As the days passed and she felt better physically, their makeout sessions began to resemble the wrestling they engaged in as kids, both trying to pin the other and giggling like mad the whole time.

As much fun as that was, Catra wanted something different today. She had been longing for her wife all week, and now she wanted to take care of her. "I want you. Is that okay?"

"Of course!" Adora spoke too loudly and the set of her mouth looked almost scared.

Catra kept slowly petting Adora's arms. "Adora. This won't work if you don't tell me what you want. I need to know what's okay."

"I… " For a moment, the odor of fear overwhelmed that of desire. Catra did not know what that was about, but an alarm rang in the back of her head.

Later. She would think about it later.

Right now, she wanted to get her wife through whatever was causing her this much anxiety.

Catra cupped Adora's cheek and leaned in. For a moment, they stood forehead to forehead, Catra's hands resting on Adora's hips, feeling her breath's slow rise and fall.

"Tell you what," Catra said, moving to talk quietly in Adora's ear. "How about we get in the water and see how things go? If you

don’t like it, we can do something else.” She backed up to see Adora’s face. “We can even spar later if that’s more your speed.” She smirked and was relieved to see the worried line between Adora’s eyebrows smooth out.

Slowly, Adora reached for the hem of her shirt, her movements tentative. Catra stayed close, letting her set the pace, and when Adora hesitated halfway, Catra reached out, resting a gentle hand on hers.

“Here, let me,” she said softly, watching for any sign of discomfort. When Adora gave a slight nod, Catra lifted the shirt the rest of the way, her fingers brushing lightly along Adora’s arms as she did.

“See, it’s all okay,” Catra whispered, her voice barely audible. She let her fingers trace a soothing path over Adora’s shoulders, grounding them both in the warmth and quiet of the room. “Just you and me.”

Adora’s shoulders relaxed at the words, and she leaned into Catra, resting her head against her shoulder. They held each other, skin against soft fur, letting the silence stretch, feeling the steady beat of each other’s hearts.

Adora’s voice came out barely above a whisper. “I know I’m acting weird. I just…” She took a deep breath as if steadying herself. “I just get… nervous sometimes. About… being seen.”

Being seen? Catra frowned, puzzling over the admission, while she brought up a hand to stroke Adora’s hair. Sure, Bright Moon folks were weird about being naked, but this was not what she meant. Although Adora seemed to thrive in the spotlight, Catra always suspected it was mere bravado—armor to cover the cracks underneath, so she never showed weakness or need.

But this? This was the Adora no one ever saw. *Her* Adora, raw and uncertain and heartbreakingly open. It hit Catra, all at once, how much she loved her—not the fantasy, not the idea, but *her.* The

thought made Catra's chest ache, and she wanted nothing more than to wrap this fragile part of Adora in her arms and never let go.

When the tension had seeped out of Adora's muscles, Catra backed up again. "Come on, then, dork. The water's going to get cold."

A spark of humor kindled in Adora's eyes. "It's fed by a hot spring. It doesn't get cold."

"So they say," Catra grumbled, pleased to see her wife start to relax again. She doffed her pants and underwear, grabbing her shirt off the floor to hang her clothes on the provided hooks. "I don't trust it."

Sitting on the side of the pool, Catra dipped her feet in. The heat was soothing against her skin, but her chest tightened, She had done this with Melog before she had even thought of this as a welcome home date for Adora. The first time she tried the pool—with Melog, Glimmer, and Aunt Casta—she'd had a panic attack. But by the end of the afternoon, she'd discovered she liked it. It was just the act of getting in that was hard.

Aunt Casta had shown Catra how to set the lights so they glowed white, blue, or gold, in case someone left it set to green. The scent of the floating petals and minerals helped a lot too. Prime's pool had smelled of ozone and terror.

Adora sat down beside her. She had taken her trousers and underwear off before she sat, and now she looked no more self-conscious about it than she would have in the locker room after a shower. Perhaps Adora had the same problems with getting naked as Catra did with the water. Perhaps Adora was shy about getting undressed with someone watching her.

"You okay?" the blonde asked, breaking into Catra's thoughts, tilting her head with concern. "Your hackles are up."

It wasn't only Catra's hackles; it was all the hair on her spine, and she could feel it. "I'm fine," she said quickly, instinctively it seemed. Then she blew out of breath and shook her head. Melog had been trying to get her comfortable with talking about her vulnerabilities. This was Adora. She would not laugh, Catra was certain.

It was still hard to say, "I get nervous at this part." She took a quick glance at Adora, whose face went through several microexpressions, apparently not understanding what Catra meant. The familiar irritation rose in her chest. Melog said it was defensive anger--her fight or flight circuit was set more toward *fight,* so she often felt fear, or even vulnerability as anger.

She took another deep breath. The warm steam curled around them, carrying the faint, sweet scent of rose petals. Catra's claws flexed against the tile as she stared into the water's steady blue glow,

"It's just…" Even with Adora beside her, Catra's heart pounded in her ears. Her throat felt tight, like the ghost of a breathing tube crammed into it, keeping her alive when she would much rather drown.

*Fuck.*

She gave Adora a tense smile and tried again. "It… I told you… about Prime's pool."

Adora nodded, her mouth tight, probably remembering the night Catra had swiped at her in a fit of panic and rage when they had gone to look at one of the weird anomalieswhich had sprung up in the wake of letting the magic in the Heart loose.

"Well, glowing water sort of freaks me out, is all." Catra's claws flexed against the edge of the pool as she stared at the water, the floral-scented steam curling softly into the air. Her tail twitched, betraying the tension she thought she'd hidden.

Adora reached out, her hand hovering hesitantly before resting on Catra's fur. "We don't have to do this," she said quietly, her voice steady but gentle. "Not if it's too much."

Catra put her hand over Adora's, grateful for the touch. "No. No, I'm not saying that. I did this with Aunt Casta and Sparkles while you were gone. Once I get in, it's great, but getting in is… intimidating."

"What can I do?" Adora asked, gently petting the fur on her spine back down.

"Hold my hand? Sit next to me?" Catra felt like someone had thrown a truth spell on her.

Immediately, Adora twined her fingers around Catra's and scooted beside her so their bare sides touched. "You want to go in together?"

Catra smiled. "Yeah."

Adora tugged on her hand as she slid off the edge. "Oooooh." She let out a long sigh of contentment as she settled on the bench in the water. "Oh, yes. This is perfect."

Catra slipped into the water more slowly, her muscles stiff and uncooperative. The warmth wrapped around her like a blanket, but her breath still came too fast. She clung to the pool's edge, her claws digging grooves into the tile.

"You okay?" Adora asked, staying close but not crowding her.

"Fine," Catra rasped, though her voice betrayed her. She sucked in a sharp breath, forcing herself to loosen her grip on the edge. "Just… give me a minute."

For a moment, she felt stupid and frustrated. She'd done this before, just last week. But Melog wasn't here now, and that was the whole point, wasn't it? She needed to do things for herself.

Slowly, she let herself sink until the water reached her shoulders. Her tail twitched below the surface, but her breathing slowed as Adora reached out, brushing her hand over Catra's fur. "You're okay,"

When Catra looked up, she saw something shine in Adora's eyes—relief, maybe, or pride. But there was something else, too, something softer and harder to name. She felt it in the way Adora's hand lingered, holding her steady.

Catra let out a shaky breath, her claws finally retracting as her grip on the edge softened. "Yeah," she said, more to herself than Adora. "Yeah," she said again, more strongly, throwing Adora a smile. She reached out, her fingers grazing Adora's wrist. "Thanks."

Fragrant petal floated in the warm, clear water, swirling with their movement. Now, Catra's body accepted that her face was in no danger of slipping under, and the fear locking her muscles uncoiled. The relief was so strong she wanted to laugh out loud. It was as Melog kept telling her, she did not need to stay trapped in the past; she could choose her present. And she was choosing this, choosing Adora, choosing to heal—even if it was hard.

A flat space like a little table was built into the pool's side, near the back wall. Waiting for them was an open bottle in a tub of ice and two tall, thin glasses. Aunt Casta was so excited when Catra mentioned this idea she had arranged all the "newlywed" accouterments. She showed Catra how to reserve the pool and then helped her order "a proper wedding lunch." There was even a special wine newlyweds drank.

When Catra objected they had been married for months, Aunt Casta had laughed and said they were newlyweds until their first anniversary. Even longer if they wanted.

"Do you want a glass of wine?" Catra asked. They were both stupid bundles of nerves, and it might help.

Adora thought so, too because she nodded enthusiastically.

Catra poured and brought the two glasses over, handing one to Adora. "Aunt Casta ordered this. It's got bubbles. She said it's traditional."

They both sipped their wine silently for a few minutes. Catra swirled her in the glass, watching the tiny bubbles race to the surface. The words she needed to say sat heavy in her chest, tangling with her breath. She'd rehearsed this conversation a dozen times in her head, but now that Adora was here, real and warm and looking at her like she hung the stars, the shame threatened to choke her.

"Hey, before we get too far into this bottle," Catra said quietly. "I need you to promise me something."

Adora's eyebrows crept up her forehead, puzzled by the sudden seriousness of Catra's voice. "Of course," she said as if there was never a question. "Anything. Anything you need.

While she appreciated her wife's easy agreement, Catra *needed* Adora to understand this. She glanced away, gripping her glass more tightly. "Fake Adora… she was perfect. She never said no, never hesitated—She was always everything I wanted her to be. But the things I did with her…" Catra whispered, her face burning. "A lot of them were out of Prime's head." Her skin crawled as images came to her mind unbidden. "But sometimes, he would pick things out of my imagination."

Now, they hit the crux of Catra's fear. "I'm worried about…" she cleared her throat. "The things I like?  I don't even know if they're… you know, normal things that people do."

She held her breath. It had been hard enough to admit this to Melog in the privacy of their psychic bond, let alone articulate it out loud. What if the things she wanted weren't things she was supposed to want? What if they made her bad, or broken, or worse—what if they made Adora leave? Prime's voice echoed in

the back of her mind, cold and mocking, telling her she'd never be enough, never be anything but the monster he'd made her.

Adora's brows furrowed, and her hand twitched like she wanted to reach for Catra but didn't know if it would help. "I don't… I don't think there's a normal, really." Adora's lips pressed together as she searched for the right words.

Adora glanced down at her own glass, her fingers curling around the stem. "I've… thought about that, too, sometimes. Like, what if the things I want are wrong? Or weird?" Her voice dropped, and she met Catra's eyes again. "But I think… as long as we're honest with each other…" Her voice trailed off as her cheeks darkened.

"I… read some books. Glimmer got them for me when I first got here." She hesitated and then reached out, gently cupping Catra's cheek. "They were a lot more helpful than health class." She smiled wryly. "I know that I trust you. And if something didn't feel right, I'll tell you. I promise."

Catra blinked, caught off guard by the raw honesty. "You… you've thought about that too?" she whispered, her voice shaky. At Adora's nod, she felt the fear unwinding again. She hadn't realized how much she needed to hear that.

She could feel her emotions trying to snatch her voice away as she looked up into Adora's worried eyes. "It just… it matters to me that if something feels wrong, you'll tell me. I'm so scared that I'll screw it up and… hurt you. A-and I'm worried that you'll let me, just because you don't want to upset me. And I can't bear it if you do that. So, do you promise?"

That was different, as Catra knew it would be. Adora could do things for Catra (and other people) that she would never do for herself. "Oh. Oh, yes. Of course." Adora said in a much more believable voice. "I promise."

Relief bloomed in her chest, and for a moment, she let herself rest in it, her breathing steadier now. "Can I…" Her cheeks flushed as

she set her glass aside. “Can I get in your lap?”

Adora nodded, her gray eyes glowing blue in the dim light. She set her glass on the side and opened her arms.  “Come here.”

Catra straddled her naked lap, and Adora gently rested her hands on Catra’s hips. “This okay?”

Adora smiled. That soft smile made Catr’s heart stutter, but she did not move until she got Adora’s nod.

She leaned forward, at first, their lips barely touching. Adora’s mouth opened, and her hands wrapped around her back, letting Catra lick into her mouth.

When they parted, both were breathing heavily. Deliberately, watching Adora’s expression as she did so, Catra rubbed Adora’s shoulders and then moved her hands lower, ghosting over her breasts. As Adora sighed and let her head drop back, Catra unsheathed the merest hint of her claws, dragging them down from her shoulders and grazing her nipples.

“Oh!” Adora exclaimed, jumping as though startled and opening her eyes wide.

Her chest tightened as her hands jerked back; Catra retracted her claws. Fake Adora had always pushed for more, her touch hungry, demanding. But this was different. Catra’s throat thickened, and she pulled her hands to her chest. Of course, her first instinct was wrong… there was no way Adora would want…

Adora blinked up at her, reaching for Catra’s hand. She pressed a kiss to her palm, her lips soft, her voice even softer. “That was… Do that again?” she said, and there was no trace of demand or expectation—just warmth, just her. “Please.”

The tension in Catra’s chest dissolved as Adora’s quiet gasp filled the space between them. She grinned, her claws grazing lower with only enough pressure to draw another soft, needy sound from Adora. “Good?” she asked, her voice light, playful. Adora’s

flushed cheeks and breathless nod were all the answers she needed, and Catra leaned in, her confidence sparking brighter with every touch.

For a moment, Adora stared up at Catra, her gray-blue eyes wide and shining, her lips parted like she couldn’t quite catch her breath. And then, as though something inside her finally unlocked, she reached up, her hands steady now as they framed Catra’s face and pulled her down into a kiss. It wasn’t tentative or hesitant—it was fierce, hungry, and open, a kiss that stole the breath from both of them.

# Unfinished Work

Chapter Summary

> Adora and Catra talk about the casualty report. A decision is made.

Adora was glad Catra had wanted to come back to Mystacor. The energy of the place was slower and quieter than Bright Moon's bustle and she liked that. Staying here made it easy to avoid running into either of Angella or Glimmer. She knew she was being stupid, but the thought of seeing them made her chest tighten painfully. Mystacor felt far away from it all, a safe haven where she could pretend, just for a little while, that everything was fine.

This afternoon had been wonderful. Catra said she'd planned it because it was Adora's favorite thing to do here. That quiet confession brought tears to her eyes when she thought about how far out of her comfort zone Catra had gone for her.

They'd spent hours in the hot springs, only leaving for the late supper Catra had ordered to their rooms. It had been filled with Adora's favorite dishes—things she hadn't even realized Catra had memorized. Afterward, they'd gone to bed early.

As a child, her favorite part of the day was the time between getting into bed and falling asleep. It was the only time she'd felt safe. After lights out, Catra would climb onto her bunk, settling herself at the foot of Adora's bed like a protective shadow. Catra's sharp ears would catch every creak and distant noise, and her eyes pierced the darkness. Her low, rumbling purr vibrated through the mattress, melting the tension from Adora's muscles. Sleep had come easily then, as long as Catra was near.

During the years she thought Catra lost to her, lying in that huge, lonely bedroom, the time was excruciating.

Now, though? Those minutes before sleep were her favorite time again. She and Catra would cuddle and talk, catching up on each other's day or planning for the next. It grounded her in a way little else could.

Adora shifted against the soft mattress now, her fingers toying absently with the edge of the blanket. Even though they'd talked all afternoon, neither of them had wanted to break the contented silence with heavier subjects. But now, lying together in the quiet, it was unavoidable. Catra wanted to hear every detail of Adora's trip—and Adora was excited to talk about the work.

"I sent off the report to the Joint Committee, so hopefully, they should get the shipments next week," Adora said, her voice soft, sounding pleased. "It was great seeing what they're doing, you know?"

Catra's eyes were half-lidded as she raked her hand lazily through Adora's hair. "Sounds like you had a good time."

"Yeah." Adora's lips curved slightly, her gaze softening as she thought about the camp. "I told Kyle it'd probably take me a week or so to get my shit together, but I figured I could head back out there for a few weeks, at least."

Catra's hand stilled in her hair. Adora felt her purr falter and stop entirely. "A few weeks?" Catra repeated slowly, her voice cooling.

Adora blinked, startled. "I told you, they desperately need volunteers."

"Yes, you said they needed volunteers," Catra said as she sat up, pushing herself against the headboard. Her arms crossed tightly over her chest. "You didn't say you were planning to go."

Adora's stomach dropped. Had she really not told her? She replayed their conversations in her mind, searching for any mention of it. Her shoulders sagged. Of course, she hadn't. She'd been so caught up in the excitement of the work that she'd assumed Catra already knew. "Oh. Gosh… I guess I didn't."

Catra cocked an eyebrow and tapped Adora lightly on the forehead with her claw. “So, you want to let the people outside of your head know what you were planning?”

“I was thinking I could help organize their supply lines and maybe work with the kids.” Adora hesitated, pulling her knees up to her chest. Her fingers twisted in the hem of her nightshirt, unable to stay still. “Lonnie set up a school. They need instructors for everything.”

“The camp you were just at?” Catra said, her tone bland as though merely double-checking the information. “The one twenty-five clicks south of Spire? The resettlement camp for Republic citizens?”

“Uh-huh.” Adora nodded quickly, but her heart was starting to pound now.

Catra stared at her, frowning. “So… Let me get this straight. You want to work in a refugee camp,” she said, disbelief dripping from her voice, “full of ex-Horde soldiers?”

“Um… yeah. It’s mostly kids,” Adora said, trying (and failing) to sound casual. She shrugged, her fingers twisting more desperately. “Why not?”

At the confirmation, Catra groaned, running a hand down her face before jumping up to pace. “Why not?” she echoed, her voice rising. “Adora, they won’t welcome She-Ra waltzing into their camp.”

“I know,” she said quietly, her jaw clenching. “I don’t care.” Of course, they wouldn’t. They’d be stupid *not* to carry a grudge. But that didn’t matter. It couldn’t matter. “I want to do something that doesn’t need me to be She-Ra.”

The brittle silence that followed made Adora’s throat tighten. Catra stopped pacing and turned to stare at her, moonlight catching her fur's copper and bronze edges, making it shine. Her

tail flicked sharply behind her. “That’s what this is about?” she asked, her voice quieter now but no less sharp.

Adora looked down at her hands, fidgeting in her lap. “With the war over, no one needs She Ra.”

Catra frowned and walked back over. Kneeling, she reached out, cupping Adora’s cheek. Those glowing, mismatched eyes held her captive,

“That’s why you want to go work there?” Her ears twitched, and she grimaced as if she were fighting with herself. “Adora, I get it.” Her tail flicked once. “But come on, there are safer places. I know at least three refugee camps in Alliance territory.”

“Oh yeah, because that would go so well.” Adora’s laugh was bitter, and it felt like chewing nettles. “They’d find a way to turn it into a spectacle.” She looked away, clenching her jaw. She used to love seeing how much people adored She-Ra—the way children’s faces lit up, the stories they told about her heroics. But now? Now, it felt suffocating. Even Catra had a civilian title—she was *Ambassador* Catra. Not a soldier. No one would expect her to fight if she did not want to. “They don’t want me,” she muttered. “They want her.””

Clearly, the only thing Adora was good at was punching things.

“Okay, yes, but…” Catra began, sounding like she was going to be way too reasonable.

“‘But, She Ra is symbolic.’ ” Making air quotes with her fingers, Adora mockingly imitated what some town official from Thaymore said to her at the last celebration, disappointed because Adora had not transformed for the party.

Pushing back her loose hair, she tried to smile as though she was joking, but her mouth twisted. Remembering that night and the thousands of other conversations she had in the same vein made her angry and hurt all over again. It was stupid to feel jealous of

what was essentially herself, but heat filled her chest, and the words boiled out before she could stop them.

"I don't want to be a symbol." Her voice was harsh, and she gulped a shaky breath. "At least at the refugee camp, I can do something real. Something that matters." She looked down at her shaking hands. "When I'm there, I'm not special.  I'm just another ex-soldier trying to help."

Very carefully, Catra wiped a tear away with her thumb. Searching Adora's face, Catra let out a long breath. "Okay. You're a dork, and you forgot to tell me," she said, her voice low and her teasing tone taking any sting from the words. "Got it."

The magicat stood up, crossing her arms tightly over her chest, and walked to the window, her eyes narrowed. It was her favorite thinking spot. Melog, lying quietly in the corner, padded over and pressed against Catra's side, their soft purr breaking the silence.

In general, Adora knew that Catra was more cautious than she, and if Catra said "absolutely not," she was not sure what would happen. Her heart pounded as she watched Catra think it through. Desperation clawed at her, and she pushed her advantage. "I bet we could get the Truth and Reconciliation Committee to say it's part of the Alliance reparations."

Catra's ears flicked. "That… might help." Her voice was reluctant but thoughtful. "She Ra working at the camps as part of the reparations program would go over better than She Ra swooping in like a savior."

Adora clung to that thread of hope. "It makes sense politically, right? It would help the peace process. And maybe… maybe it'll help me feel like I'm actually doing some good instead of standing around pretending everything's fine."

For a moment, Catra didn't respond. She stood there, silhouetted by the window, her arms crossed tightly over her chest and Melog pressing against her leg.

“I don’t like it,” she said finally, her voice quiet.

“I know,” Adora said softly.

“But…” Catra glanced over her shoulder, her expression resigned. “If you need this, I won’t stop you.” She turned fully, her sharp gaze locking onto Adora. “When are *we* leaving?”

Adora blinked. “We…?”

Catra rolled her eyes. “You didn’t think I’d let you go alone, did you?”

Adora’s heart swelled, warmth spreading through her chest. “You would do that?” she whispered.

Catra’s gaze softened. “Of course, I would.” Her tail lashed once before curling loosely behind her. “I’m not letting you run off to a camp full of ex-Horde soldiers without me.”

“But… can you? I mean, what about your job?” Adora was unsure why she was so surprised, but she never expected it.

“I’ll make it work,” Catra said. “Spire’s close enough that I can deal with most of my duties remotely. I can hop over to Bright Moon or the Capital if something big comes up. But for now…” She trailed off, her sharp gaze softening. “I’d rather be with you.”

“You would?” The look Catra gave her- warm and soft, her eyes shining with something like pride, made Adora melt inside. She cleared her throat, searching for something to distract herself.

Catra gave her that distraction. “Have you talked about the idea with Sparkles yet?”

Adora’s cheeks heated. She should have known Catra would ask. Frowning, she crossed her arms over her chest. “No.”

Catra opened her mouth, but Adora cut her off. “I don’t need to ask her for permission." Her voice sharpened, dripping with

resentment. "It's not like she needs me."

"Adora—" Catra started, but Adora didn't let her finish.

"You tell her." Adora's voice sounded flat even to herself. "I… I don't want to talk to her."

Catra blinked at her. "What the fuck, Adora? What's the issue with Sparkles?"

Adora didn't answer. Instead, she looked away, her jaw tightening. Too many feelings gripped her, clogging her chest and making it too hard to speak.

"I knew you were avoiding Angella," Catra pressed, her voice softer now. "But why Glimmer?"

Adora's lips trembled. She sucked in a shaky breath and shook her head, unable to speak without breaking.

"Adora?" Catra pleaded, stepping closer. "What's going on? You're freaking me out."

Adora stood up, crossing to her desk. She didn't want to do this. Didn't want to see it. She wanted to pretend she never found it, but she had promised to try to be honest.

Catra's worried gaze followed her, and she could not avoid it any longer.

With a sharp intake of breath, she yanked the drawer open and pulled out the paper. It crinkled in her hands as she hesitated, her chest tight. Finally, she turned and held it out to Catra, unable to meet her eyes.

How could Adora tell Catra that, even when she *knew* Glimmer was getting advice from Shadow Weaver, Adora had trusted her? And the report left no room for doubt. Glimmer had… threatened soldiers. Tortured them.

And Adora had not stopped her.

At the time, it had not seemed severe. They had too many other things to think about. They were losing. They were desperate. She'd told herself they needed the information, but now, every excuse felt pathetic.

She could still see the magic sparking in Glimmer's hands, the terror in that soldier's eyes.

*She* knew a proper truth spell would not hurt anyone, but she thought of Catra at her trial. How horrible it had been to watch her brace herself for pain. Every Horde citizen in the room had assumed that sorcerers were into torture. Because if Shadow Weaver were the only sorceress you ever knew, *of course,* you would think that.

The Force Captain who wrote this report cared about his troops. The last two paragraphs weren't about tactics or strategy. They were about his soldiers.  He wanted to win, not because he wanted power, but because he wanted his people safe. He had no choice about where to send them, but he protected them as much as possible.

Phrases like " *unnecessary suffering* " were scratched indelibly on Adora's soul. He had characterized their tactics as sadistic. The last paragraph talked about how young and inexperienced those troops were.

How could Catra even look at her?

And Glimmer… Her stomach churned, and she pressed her palms to her eyes. Glimmer was her friend, and even when Adora was pissed at her, she did not see what she was doing. Angella had charged her with taking care of Glimmer.

Catra frowned, unfolding the sheet. Her ears twitched as her sharp eyes scanned the heading.

**Casualty Report**
**Region: Northern Territories - Sector 5.**

Adora knew precisely what the report said. The names of the wounded and the dead were burned into Adora's brain. The words of the narrative an indelible mark on her soul.

She thought about Glimmer—her best friend. Glimmer, who had stood beside her in so many battles, fought with her, fought *for her*.

And yet… Glimmer had *sent her* into those battles. And Angella—from the moment She Ra pledged her allegiance to Bright Moon, she had seen She Ra as the answer to everything. But what else were they supposed to do? Before She Ra came, the Horde had been chipping away at all their borders. Angella had been too risk-averse to do more than provide other Princesses with humanitarian aid. They would have lost Plumaria to Hordak's chemical blight three years ago. Mermista had nearly lost the Sea Gate.

If Angella had been left in charge, they would have lost everything.

When Glimmer tried to activate the Heart… Had Adora ever told her what breaking the Sword was like? How did it feel when she thought she had lost She Ra for good? Maybe on Darla? Probably not.

She hadn't explained how much it had cost her. The agony of Etheria's magic flooding her—an unstoppable force she'd barely managed to contain. The impossible strength it had taken to prevent a literal world-ending disaster. Destroying Light Hope had almost destroyed her, too.

And it hadn't been Prime who did that to her. It had been Glimmer.

Glimmer, who Adora had risked everything to rescue. Glimmer, for whom Catra had suffered under Prime's torture.

It hadn’t been intentional. Adora knew that. Looking for the Heart on Shadow Weaver’s advice had been a mistake—an honest one. They’d been desperate. Anyone in Glimmer’s position might have done the same.

The war… Horde Prime finding Etheria… That wasn’t Glimmer’s fault. Adora told herself that again and again.

And yet.

The weight of the thought felt crushing. It didn’t matter that Glimmer hadn’t meant for it to happen—she had trusted the one person she shouldn’t have. Even after all the warnings, all the times Adora had begged her not to listen to Shadow Weaver, Glimmer had trusted her anyway.

The person who had destroyed Adora’s childhood. The person who had hurt Catra and so many others. The person Adora had spent years trying to escape.

Adora’s breath hitched. Glimmer had apologized to her. She knew that. And she had accepted it, hadn’t she? Of course, she’d had no choice. They were trying to save the world. But even now, that apology lingered like a half-finished sentence. Thin. Not insincere, exactly, but somehow hollow. And she did not know why.

*“I’m sorry for everything.”* Glimmer had sobbed. And then she had broken down, falling to pieces, knowing Adora would gather them up. “*You were right,”* she’d howled.

And Adora *had* picked up the pieces, just like she was supposed to. Comforting and consoling Glimmer. “*We’re here now. And nothing is going to tear us apart again.”*

Had Glimmer thanked Adora?

Adora’s chest tightened as she recalled Glimmer’s apology to Bow. “Maybe you’ll be mad at me for a really long time,” Glimmer had said, tears streaming down her face. “I deserve it. And maybe we’ll never be friends like we used to be, but I’m not going to

stop trying to make it better. You get to be mad. For as long as you need to be. But I'm not going anywhere."

Glimmer never said anything like that to her. And if she did, would she mean it? Would she really stay, even if Adora stayed angry, stayed hurt? A part of her whispered, bitter and dark, that Glimmer only stayed when it was convenient—when she needed Adora to fight, to smile, to play the hero.

But wasn't that what everyone did?

Adora stared down at her clenched fists. People didn't give her that kind of grace. No one waited for her to fall apart. When the war raged, Etheria had not paused to give her time to process, or heal or even *breathe*. There had been no room for hesitation, for pain. She'd had to forgive. She'd had to move on.

She Ra couldn't hesitate. She Ra couldn't hold grudges. She Ra couldn't break.

Therefore, Adora couldn't break.

She squeezed her eyes shut, trying to push the thoughts away. She wanted to tell Glimmer how much it still hurt—how much it all still hurt—but the idea twisted in her stomach, sharp and ugly. What would be the point? It wasn't like Glimmer would understand.

Adora flinched at the thought. No. That wasn't fair. It wasn't right. Glimmer was always there for her. Wasn't she?

She didn't want to feel this way.

She wanted to be happy Angella had returned. She wanted to be relieved that the war was over. But instead, her heart pounded, her chest constricted, and the memories wouldn't let her go.

Clenching her fists tighter, Adora dug her nails into her palms, willing herself not to cry. What was wrong with her?

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**Field Commander: Force Captain Thadious**

**Report Prepared by: Senior Aid In Field: L. Rendon**

**Engagement Details:**

- **Location: Greenhill Pass**
- **Opposing Force: Alliance Militia - 3rd Battalion**
- **Princess Involvement: She-Ra, Queen of Bright Moon**

Catra's ears flattened against her head as her eyes scanned the report. Fifty-four dead. Sixty-two wounded. Twelve missing. Her tail lashed behind her, sharp and erratic, as she gripped the paper tighter.

*Fuck.*

How did Adora get this? The notes in the margins—the ones scrawled in her own jagged handwriting—seemed to leap off the page.

*"Too many units lost. Unacceptable. Need to reduce."*

Another line, written in a different color: *"Gen Order #27: Do not engage princesses without an energy weapon. Dead batteries = retreat."*

Her throat tightened as she flipped through the pages, scanning for more of her own words. And there they were, scattered across the report, reminders of her time as Hordak's second:

- *"Thadious wins a lot. Popular with soldiers. Check his methods.*
- *Visit Infirmary once per week.*

She ran a hand through her hair, trying to push back the memories that surged forward. The report wasn't just numbers and strategies—it was hers. She'd read this and made the notes on it.

Greenhill Pass. That was a nasty one. Neither side decisively won the battle, and both sides suffered heavy casualties.

"Damn it, Adora," she muttered under her breath as her stomach churned. She couldn't stop staring at the words. They felt like a punch to the gut. Why would Adora bring this up now?

"Why do you have this?" she asked, her voice low and cautious.

Adora swallowed hard. "I found it in your quarters?"

"Found?" Catra knew exactly where and when Adora must have "found" it. Adora had been sitting on this for over a week. Is this why she decided she needed to get away so badly?

"I just… I was curious, I guess."

"Curious? Seriously?"  Where did Adora get the idea she could go through Catra's shit? What did she find that upset her so much? What the fuck did Adora think she was doing?

She ground her teeth, reigning in her mouth. If Adora wanted to cancel their sanction, would she have come home? And she would not have spent the afternoon with Catra like nothing was wrong. It would be sensible to let Adora finish before deciding how she felt. They had promised to be honest with each other. If Adora was upset about this, Catra should try talking with her. Snapping back or shutting down never got them anywhere.

The calm and reasonable thoughts that washed over her weren't hers. Like rain on dry grass, they prevented her temper from igniting a wildfire that would burn herself and anyone nearby. Her magical guardian lay in the moonlight, their luminous eyes fixed on her, radiating pride and reassurance. Enough to anchor her against falling into that terrible spiral.

"What did you want to know?"

“Huh?” Adora’s eyebrows scrunched together as though she did not understand.

“You’re... upset about it.” Catra held on to her patience with all four sets of claws, her tail flicking once before she stilled it. She glanced away toward Melog, who met her gaze with a slow, encouraging nod. The tension in her chest eased just enough to keep her moving forward. “But… I don’t know why.” The last word slipped out almost plaintively as her eyes flicked back to Adora.

Adora stood frozen by the desk, her arms wrapped tightly around herself, her shoulders trembling. She looked so small, so broken, and it made something deep in Catra’s chest twist painfully.

“Do you know I never saw a casualty report.?” Adora whispered.

Catra blinked, confused by the change in direction. ” Huh?”

Taking a shuddering breath, her fists clenching at her sides, Adora shook her head. “Never. They didn’t show them to me.” Her voice broke, and she looked away, blinking back tears. “They didn’t want me to know.”

Catra stared at her, confusion flickering in her expression. “Know what?”

Adora’s voice rose, trembling with barely-contained emotion. “How many people I murdered!” She pressed her fist to her chest. “How many lives She-Ra destroyed!”

Catra flinched. “Adora…” she began, but Adora didn’t let her finish.

“They used me, Catra!” The words spilled out in a rush, her voice cracking under their weight. “I wasn’t a person to them—I was a *weapon!* And I let them! I told myself I was doing the right thing, and I—” Her voice broke, and she buried her face in her hands, sobbing. “I didn’t even want to know. I didn’t want to think about it.”

For a moment, there was only the sound of her ragged sobs. Then Catra crossed the distance between them in two quick strides. She gently pulled her hands away from her face. “Stop,” she said fiercely, her voice low and steady. “You weren’t murdering anyone, Adora. You were fighting a war—a war you didn’t start.”

Catra took her wife's hands and led her back to the bed. Slowly, Adora followed, her movements dazed and heavy, like after one of those dreams she’d been having.

The air was cool, and she felt the goosebumps prickling along Adora’s arms as she tucked her under the covers. Catra slid in beside her, pulling the blanket over their legs so they sat with their backs against the headboard.

Pale-faced,  Adora reeked of a complex mixture of emotions—anger, anxiety, and, most powerfully, shame.

Catra lifted her hand and petted through Adora’s hair, pulling her head onto her shoulder. “You’re okay,” she whispered. “We’re okay.”

Adora's reddened eyes filled with tears, and she shook her head violently, the fresh tears spilling down her cheeks. “All those people, Catra. All of them are dead. Because of me!”

Catra flinched, her tail lashing behind her. She kept petting, her claws barely grazing Adora’s skin, her voice dropping to a low, fierce whisper. “No. They’re dead because of the war. Because of Hordak. Because of Shadow Weaver.” She stopped and swallowed, her ears pinned to her head. “Because of me. Okay? But not because of you.”

Adora’s voice cracked. “It’s right there, Catra!” She leaned over and grabbed the paper that Catra put on the bed. “*Look* !” She held it up and jabbed her finger at the words, “ ‘*The primary cause of losses was engagement with She-Ra.’* It’s all there! And then Glimmer—Glimmer was running around torturing people!”

Catra took the report again, her sharp eyes narrowing as she skimmed her own notes. She had talked to him. She could still hear Thadious in her head, insisting on the infirmary visits, discussing the importance of morale. His troops fought harder and longer for him and for each other.

" *Magical torture. Unnecessary suffering,'* " snarled Adora. " See? Right there."

"Oh." Catra's voice dropped an octave. As she began to understand, she felt sick. "Okay. Yeah. I see."

It would be insulting to try to refute the reports of her own Force Captains and spies. While she never witnessed exactly what Glimmer had done, she had gotten *a lot* of reports. Double Trouble had been gleeful about reporting the Queen's and She Ra's rift. How Sparkles had gotten reckless and started risking her stupid neck on the battlefield.

Given how shitty teleportation made *her* feel, Catra would agree that it did amount to a torture session. And then Glimmer did that thing of teleporting people into a fall. From what she remembered from DT's reports, a big chunk of their rift came from that.

Catra always knew Sparkles had it in her. The Young Queen (as Melog called her) had a mean streak almost as wide as Catra's

But Adora… did not. Shoulders hunched, twisting the tissue Catra had given her, her eyes wide; not merely upset—unraveling. It was not about survival or even about her own decisions. It was about the aftermath. About reckoning with what they'd done to survive.

The sobs turned ragged as Adora tried to catch her breath. "And… and Angella and Glimmer look at me." Adora's voice cracked as she spoke. "Like none of it mattered. Like none of those people mattered."

Catra sighed, her tail flicking behind her. "The war broke everyone. That's what war does." She hugged herself. These

were things she had begun to talk about with Melog but no one else. They never judged her- they always said they were so old that nothing surprised them.

However, that did not mean that no one judged her. Without the protection of Castaspella and Glimmer, Catra would have a difficult time moving around Alliance territory freely. Sometimes, when they went out, Catra would feel hostile eyes on her. Melog always liked to go with her if she left the confines of either Bright Moon castle or Mystacor proper. Unlike Adora, Catra had a harder time going incognito.

"I used to go down to the infirmary once a week," Catra muttered, not sure why she was saying this. For some reason, she felt like she needed to explain some of the notes. "Thadious said it would make the soldiers trust me. I thought it was bullshit."

Adora finally looked at her, a small, sad smile ghosting over her mouth. "I just spent the last week with everyone telling me stories about how much you cared about the troops."

"Did you check that story with Lonnie?" Catra sneered, bitterness overtaking her. Back then, Catra hadn't let herself care about the soldiers. Names and faces were a liability—a weakness. Efficiency, she told herself, was all that mattered. But now, their faces haunted her. Every name on the report felt like a wound she'd inflicted herself.

Soberly, Adora nodded. "She said you treated her, Kyle, Rogelio, and Scorpia like shit."

"See?" Catra's voice rose, frustration clawing at her throat. "So don't pretend that you are the only—" she broke off mid-sentence, biting the inside of her cheek.

"Granddaughter," Melog interrupted, their deep, resonant tone cutting through the tension. "Look at your mate."

Catra blinked at them, her tail flicking once in irritation before she turned back to Adora.

Adora had pulled one of the pillows into her lap, clutching it tightly. Her knuckles were white, her head bowed, and her teeth sunk into her bottom lip.

The sight stopped Catra cold.

It was a posture Catra knew all too well—the same way she used to hold onto herself when she was too scared to ask for comfort.

The frustration drained from Catra's body, replaced by a sharp ache in her chest. She took a deep breath, trying to loosen the tightness in her throat.

"Sorry," she said softly, her voice losing its edge. She crossed the space between them and knelt in front of Adora. "I—" Catra hesitated, her ears twitching, then blew out a breath. "I'm sorry."

Adora looked so lost- like a cadet on her first night in the bunk room.

Catra shook her head, trying to push away the memories that threatened to rise—the times she had braced herself for rejection, for cruelty. She wasn't going to make Adora feel like that. Not now.

She slid closer, reaching out to gently take one of Adora's hands in both of hers. "Adora…" she began, her voice low, her mismatched eyes softening as they searched Adora's face. Melog purred faintly in the background, their quiet presence grounding her. Catra's ears flicked back as her resolve hardened. "I sent people after you," she admitted. "I gave those orders. And from what I understand… you didn't."

Adora's voice was barely above a whisper. "But I could have…" Her lips trembled. "I could have stopped her…"

"What? And gotten yourself locked up even sooner?" Catra's eyebrows rose, and her tone turned dry, though she kept her voice steady. "Sparkles told me about that, you know."

Adora blinked, startled. “She told you…?”

Catra nodded sharply, her ears flicking back again. “Yeah. About how Scorpia came asking for help finding Entrapta, and Sparkles confined you and Arrow Boy to the castle.” She frowned, her voice turning bitter. “She said she’d been taking lessons from Shadow Weaver for a while by that point.”

Adora’s eyes widened, her confusion giving way to something softer—shock, maybe, or understanding. “She told you that?”

“We… had a lot of time to talk.” She looked away, embarrassed. “I did tell her what a terrible idea that was,” she muttered, but her voice carried a note of something darker—anger? Disgust? Yes, definitely disgust. They claimed to be her best friends, but they seemed to have no clue how bad off Adora was.

“Listen to me,” she said firmly, locking onto Adora’s gray eyes. “You didn’t get a choice. But now you do. So if this is what you need, we’ll figure it out.”

Adora shook her head. “I was so angry at Glimmer! She wouldn’t listen to me! And when she didn’t listen… it felt like I didn’t matter. And then Light Hope tried to use me! That’s why I had to break the sword. And then… and then she was gone.

“Bow said Shadow Weaver was a real bitch to you after you broke the sword.”

“She was until Micah talked to her. He made her quit.” Adora hung her head and played with the end of her ponytail. “She wasn’t wrong, though.”

“What?!” Catra demanded.

Adora flinched at Catra’s outburst, pulling the elastic from her ponytail and running her fingers through her hair in nervous, jerky movements. “She wasn’t wrong,” she repeated quietly, her voice barely audible. “I wasn’t She-Ra anymore. I wasn’t… anything. Just another ordinary fighter. I didn’t really matter.”

Catra's tail flicked sharply, and she leaned forward, her hands gripping Adora's knees. "Don't you dare say that," she hissed, her voice low but intense. " Shadow Weaver knew exactly how to twist the knife, Adora. That's her whole thing."

Adora shook her head, her eyes distant. "But… It wasn't only her, Catra. Angella only took me in because She-Ra was supposed to save the world. And then we lost her. I thought maybe… maybe it was my fault. Maybe I failed her." Adora's voice broke, and she buried her face in her hands. "And now… I don't matter at all." Adora finished, her voice small.

Catra's ears flicked back, her tail twitching as she began to pet Adora's hair. "Yeah," she said after a moment, her voice low but firm. "They did use you." At the bald affirmation, Adora peeked at Catra, who met her eyes. "It wasn't fair." She hesitated, then added, "Now you've gotta stop doing it to yourself."

Adora blinked at her, startled. "What… what do you mean?"

"I mean this," Catra gestured at the tissue still clutched in Adora's hands, her shoulders hunched. "You keep carrying all of this like it's only your weight to bear. Like you've gotta fix everything, atone for everything, all by yourself." Those gold and blue eyes softened, and her voice dipped lower. "But you don't."

The words hung heavy in the air, and Adora didn't know how to respond. She remembered her relief when Sara told her, "You're not special." This brought it back. The simple premise that Adora did not have to do anything extraordinary. That she could merely exist like anyone else.

"We have to be here for the reception, you know." Catra brought the trash can over, swept the tissues into it, and sat beside her.

Adora's heart sank. "Do we have to?"

The idea of putting on a gown and pretending everything was fine felt unbearable. But Catra was right—they had to show up, at least briefly. Adora didn't know how long she could keep up the

charade. She felt on the knife edge of a rage or a panic attack thinking about it.

"Come here." Catra pulled Adora into bed and molded herself to Adora's back. "It's okay. The reception is tomorrow night, but Sparkles will be busy all day. We'll need to go for a little bit, at least."

Adora hesitated. "What if they want to talk to me?"

"You want me to get Aunt Casta to tell them to back off?" Catra asked seriously.

"Would she do that for me?"

Catra smiled a little maliciously. "Yes. I guess she's still annoyed at Angella because of the catnip tea incident."

"As am I," Melog growled.

Choosing not to share what Melog had said (their protectiveness made Catra feel odd. Good. But odd.), Catra's smile turned serious. "She wants to help. She already told Sparkles and Sparkles Sr. that you may still need some time."

"Okay," Adora whispered, sinking into the mattress and the comfort of her wife's arms.

"If seeing them is too much, we'll give them a sob story about how overwhelmed Kyle, Lonnie, and Rogelio are. We can scoot out of there first thing."

"Oh. Shoot. I need something to wear. To the reception, I mean."

"All taken care of," whispered Catra, putting her arm around her wife's waist. She kissed the back of Adora's neck, her voice low. Catra could feel Adora relax in stages, slowly giving in to sleep. 'I've got you, and I'm not letting go," she assured her, "I love you."

“Love you too,” Adora whispered. “Thank you.”

Catra wiggled a little to get more comfortable. “Get some sleep, dummy.”

# Reception

Chapter Summary

Angella's reception happens

“Wow,” whispered Trevor as they ascended the staircase. “So, were you guys really here for the battle?”

“Yeah,” Derrick rumbled back, his big hand engulfing Sara’s and squeezing tight. They had lost friends in that battle. As they walked across the plaza, the glow of the Moonstone sent a shiver down Sara’s spine, and for a moment, Derrick’s good-natured face twisted into an unwonted snarl as his eyes locked on the Moonstone.

Sara knew what he saw. The floodwaters tearing through their ranks. The screams of the wounded. The bloated faces of the drowned.

It was beautiful now, standing serene and untouched. She leaned her head on Derrick’s shoulder. “You okay?” she asked him.

He shuddered and looked down at her. “Just memories.”

Their crew had been fortunate. They’d gone up against the Flower Princess. The tank had flipped—it could have ended very badly. But Perfuma’s vines tore it apart, metal screeching as they opened it like a box of rations, ripping the chassis off.

The vines coiled around Sara’s torso, pinning her arms. She had given herself up for dead.

Instead of slamming her to the ground, they lifted her with a care she hadn’t expected. No crushing force, no jagged edges. Just a steady, deliberate strength that cradled her like something precious. The vines carried her to the edge of the Whispering Woods, set her gently on her feet, and patted her on the head before withdrawing.

Most soldiers agreed that Perfuma was the kindest of the Princesses. Her plants dismantled tanks with surgical precision, yet they rarely harmed soldiers. It made sense she'd find Scorpia—two people who chose kindness, even in war.

The same could not be said for those swept up by the Water Princess's flood or frozen by the Ice Princess.

But something else had happened that day. Something Sara had never told anyone. They'd have dragged her to get her brain scanned.

The forest had been unnervingly quiet, untouched by the cold that gripped the rest of the Woods—the same cold that enabled Bright Moon's siege. Whatever Entrapta had done to the Runestones hadn't reached this hollow. The air here was thick, warm, and still, shimmering in the dappled light, like the world had paused to catch its breath. The rumble of artillery and crack of magic echoed faintly, muffled—as though coming from far, far away.

Sara's boots sank into the soft earth, the green vegetation springy and gentle beneath her. She was used to fighting in dead zones—mud, ash, the acrid sting of chemical fire. But here, it was alive. Vibrant. It didn't feel real.

That's when the woman appeared, trotting out of the trees as though she'd taken a wrong turn on her way to market. She carried a broom in one hand and a basket in the other, her glasses perched precariously on the tip of her nose. She stopped a few paces away, peering at Sara with sharp, curious eyes.

"You're not Adora," the woman said after a moment, tilting her head to the side. "Your hair's too dark. And you're too short to be Mara."

Sara blinked. "…What?" She glanced around, disoriented. Where did the vines drop her?

"Ah! I know!" The woman's face lit up as if recognizing an old friend. "Sara! Oh, it's you! How are you, dearie? It's been so

long!”

Her voice was almost familiar. Sara smiled faintly in return. “I think you’ve mistaken me for someone else,” she said. The distant sounds of the battle seemed to grow louder, like a radio tuning back into the right frequency. She glanced over her shoulder, hoping the woman was far enough away from the fighting to stay safe.

But then the broom came down gently on her head—*bop*—snapping her attention back. “No, not someone. *Somewhen.*” The woman’s voice softened, almost wistful. “What are you doing here, Sara? Did you want to come to my place for pie?”

Sara frowned, the question catching her off guard. “I… I lost my crew.”

"Lost them? Do you want to find them?"

Sara stiffened, a chill creeping up her spine despite the warm air. “What? Yes, of course.” Her voice faltered, frustration bubbling in her chest. “They need me.”

Razz tilted her head, leaning on her broom. Her gaze drifted toward the distant battlefield, where smoke still curled into the clear sky. “Oh, yes. Of course, they do. But that’s not what I asked.” Her voice softened. “What do *you* want, dearie?”

The question struck like a blow to the chest. Sara froze, her mouth opening slightly, but no words came. Something in Razz’s tone sent a shiver through her. This wasn’t a question to answer lightly. Something deep inside her warned her to tread carefully.

Her heart settled into a steely resolve. Her voice, when it came, was quiet but steadier. “What do I want? I want to get back to my crew. I want to make sure they’re okay. I want to get home to my daughter.” She straightened, clenching her fists at her sides. “I’m not leaving anyone behind. *We’re all going home today.*”

Razz's smile softened further, crinkling the corners of her sharp, curious eyes. She stepped closer and cupped Sara's cheek with her weathered hand, a warmth in her touch that sent a jolt of comfort through Sara's aching bones.

"All right," Razz said softly, as though granting permission.

The air shifted. Alive. Vibrant. As if the forest itself exhaled.

Razz turned back toward the trees, her voice carrying over her shoulder as she disappeared into the shadows. "Well, you'd better get moving, dearie. You've got work to do before you come to see me for pie."

Sara watched her vanish, muttering, "What the hell is pie?"

The sounds of the battle sharpened. The world tilted back into focus—smoke, gunfire, shouting. Sara inhaled sharply, bracing herself. Her body still hurt, but she didn't stop moving.

When she found her crew again, the retreat had been called. The survivors limped back through the woods.

Their crew had been lucky. They *had* all made it home that day.

"It was a long time ago," Sara said. They stood silently. The memories hung heavily in the air. Then Sara shook her head, forcing herself to focus on the present. 'If you'd told me then that we'd be coming here for a… Felina, what did the invitations call it?"

"A reception."

Sara laughed faintly, overwhelmed. "One of those. I'd have sent you to the medics for detox."

Derrick snorted in agreement.

At the door, they handed their invitations to the guards. Sara almost expected them to say, *Nice try,* and turn her away. But the

guard who checked them in smiled and said, "Welcome to Bright Moon. Please enjoy the Queen's hospitality."

The grand staircase inside felt like the entrance to another world, one Sara wasn't sure she belonged in. Derrick's hand tightened around hers, steadying her. He didn't say a word, nor did she, but the quiet squeeze of his fingers told her he'd noticed. He always noticed.

They descended into a vast hall with round tables scattered across the floor. Most of the crowd wore shimmering gowns, suits, or polished armor. It helped when Sara spotted Horde uniforms mingling in the mix.

"So, uh. What now?" Trevor asked, shifting awkwardly. Sara could understand his discomfort.

"Looks like there's food over there," Derrick said, inclining his head. A small group of youngsters gathered at one end, filling their plates from the large platters. "Why don't you kids head down there? We'll meet up later."

Felina and Trevor grinned. "See you later." Felina's tail flicked with excitement as she dragged Trevor toward the buffet.

Sara watched them go, shaking her head with a faint smile. "They're going to eat half the spread," she muttered.

"Good," Derrick chuckled. "Let them. We've earned it."

"Yeah," she murmured, brushing her hand against the hem of her jacket. The fabric was crisp and new, but it felt heavy. Too formal. Too clean. "Can you imagine what Tom and Meg would've said?"

"Ha. Yeah." Derrick smiled nostalgically, glancing down at the officer's insignia on his uniform. "They'd laugh like hell—and then fuss we were impersonating officers," he said with a lopsided grin.

Sara wrapped both arms around Derrick's bicep. "I wish they could've seen this."

They both stood silently for a moment, staring down at the glittering main floor, thinking of lost loves and absent friends. Across the expanse of the hall, a group of people played music, and some danced.

It looked like the fairytales they used to whisper in the dark. Days where you could eat yourself stupid on sugar and fat, and places where music and dancing weren't crimes.

"We'll have to enjoy it for them," Sara said softly.

"Sounds like a plan," Derrick replied hoarsely. He cleared his throat. "Come on. Or the kids will eat everything," he rumbled thickly.

When they reached the buffet, Sara paused, her gaze sweeping over the plates piled high with tiny, intricately arranged food. "Did they put Entrapta in charge of this?" she muttered, eyeing the trays of bite-sized dishes. "What is this?"

Derrick smirked. "Not sure what that is, but there's some shrimp here. We had shrimp when we took Salineas, remember?"

"I guess, but I could tell what it was," she replied, grabbing a plate and cautiously selecting anything that looked remotely familiar.

Derrick added another piece of food to her plate without asking. "Medic's orders," he teased lightly, but his eyes were steady and watchful. The way he'd been ever since the test turned positive. Apart from the night she told him, Felina,  and Trevor, they had not talked much about it; that was not how they did things, but his gentle care made her chest warm.

Sara rolled her eyes theatrically. "Fiiiiiiine," she said as though she were a recalcitrant cadet, but she popped the little bit of meat on a cracker into her mouth. She glanced at Derrick, catching his eye, and exchanged a conspiratorial grin.

Like many others, she still struggled to regain weight after months of lean rations. The medics had lectured her about it when she had gotten her implant taken out. Now she had even more reason.

“Is that Derrick?” Someone called out.

Sara and Derrick both turned. For a moment, they stared at the big orc woman. She wore no uniform, just a lightweight shirt, and a leather vest, but she stood and moved like a Horde officer. She tilted her head and grinned. “What, you don’t remember me? Or maybe you blotted me out of your memory. I wouldn’t blame you.”

“Huntara!” exclaimed Derrick, stepping forward as she opened her arms for a hug. She had been Derrick’s favorite instructor when he was a cadet-- he had gotten his certification as a gunner under her. She had been incredibly popular as a Force Captain; she disappeared during the Battle of Highcliff, out on the border of the Crimson Waste.

“We all thought you were dead!” Derrick said as they both pulled back.

“Nope, not yet,” she laughed. “But you look like you stole someone’s uniform. What idiot left you in charge of anything?” She turned to Sara. “Hey, there. Not sure we’ve met?”

“Yes, ma’am, we did. But only once,” Sara said, her cheeks heating a little. “You… ah. You gave me chocolate.”

The woman blinked, and then comprehension flowed over her face. “Oh, wait. You were Derrick’s squadmate. The one who tangled w—” She stopped, her eyes darting around, and then she finished quietly, “With Shadow Weaver.”

“Yes, ma’am.” Sara slipped her hand into Derrick’s. “It… meant a lot that day,” she said softly.

“Shit. You guys were hardly old enough for active duty.” Huntara’s eyes seemed distant for a moment, her grin fading. “You were just kids.”

“What happened?” A dark-haired man Huntara had been talking with asked, looking between the three.

“I…” Sara hesitated, unsure what to say. Usually, asking about scars and war stories was just small talk, but this…

“Sara here had a run-in with Shadow Weaver,” Huntara put in smoothly, her sharp glance silencing Sara’s hesitation. “She got hurt, and of course, since it was that fucking witch, it was… complicated.”

The man seemed to understand that anything involving Shadow Weaver was sensitive territory. He merely nodded.

“So, she comes stumbling home, and her squad goes to take care of her. Only, like I said, it was more complicated than they knew what to do with. This lunk comes to *my* office looking for help in a panic.” Huntara jerked her head at Derrick with a little smile. “And I go into the locker room and see what the old cunt had done. Fortunately, it was not nearly as bad as it could have been, so I told them what to do.” Her face softened. “I had scored a box of chocolate the week before, so I sent her a square.” She shrugged.

Sara smiled, sighing with relief and feeling warm at Huntara’s tact. “Yes, ma’am.” She squeezed Derrick’s hand.

Grinning wolfishly, Huntara said, “Don’t you ma’am me.” She nodded at Sara’s insignia. “You’re Entrapta’s Second?”

Sara was pleased. Not everyone recognized the new purple R&D insignia, so they didn’t always know who she was Second to. “Yeah.” Instinctively, she brushed her hand over the pin.

“I think that means you outrank me.” Huntara’s smile turned wry, and she saw someone over Sara’s shoulder. “Oh, hey. Blondie!”

“Hi, Huntara!” a familiar voice said. “And Sara! Derrick! Oh, I’m so happy you’re here!” Adora was hurrying over, clad in a long white gown trimmed with gold. Her hair was held back with a delicate filigree tiara with wire wings that framed her face, a little like the tiara She Ra wore but scaled down.

Indicating the man who had asked about the chocolate, Adora said, “Oh, I’d been hoping to introduce you! This is Bow! I really wanted you two to meet!” She smiled, but Sara saw the tension in her face.

The man shot Adora a faintly exasperated look before covering it with a warm smile. “Hi, Sara,” he said, extending a hand. “I'm Bow. I’ve heard a lot about your work with the refugee project.”

Sara took his hand, surprised but pleased at his easy demeanor. “Nice to meet you,” she said. “Entrapta talks about you, too.”

“Adora’s been telling me about your work at the refugee camp?” Bow asked. “You work on prosthetics?”

Sara nodded. “And cybernetics. Sometimes, a limb or organ can be saved. Other times, it can’t, and that’s where we focus on building replacements. The goal is to restore original function as much as possible.”

“How does it work?” Bow asked, leaning in slightly. “Is it magic?”

“No.” The word came out more sharply than Sara intended, and Bow raised an eyebrow. She grimaced, softening her tone. “Sorry. A lot of us are… edgy about magic. Entrapta’s helped us figure out the tech side of things. The only magic involved are the power supplies in the prototypes—and that’s not really magic.”

Bow tilted his head. “Not really magic? What does that mean?”

“It’s First Ones tech. It converts ambient magic into electricity. Like a solar panel, except it uses the magic field around us instead of sunlight.”

“So you’ve worked out the overload problem?”

“We’re using some new materials that are more resilient to it.” Sara shrugged, trying to sound casual. “It can overload if there’s too much energy in the environment,” she said. “Or cut out if there’s not enough. It’s fine as long as I don’t end up in an anti-magic zone—or, you know, a magical storm.”

“Entrapta told me about some of your innovations. She said you’re doing groundbreaking work out there.”

Sara’s cheeks flushed. “It’s nothing like what Entrapta does,” she said quickly. “I just modified her designs.”

Bow shook his head. “Entrapta’s impressed, and trust me—that’s high praise.”

Even as they spoke, Sara noticed Adora shifting beside Bow. A server came by, and Adora picked up a full glass of wine, which she drank like a canteen of water on a march through the Arid Plains. The blonde girl kept scanning the crowd as though looking for threats. Her hands curled into fists, her shoulders rigid. She nodded at Bow’s words, but her gaze darted toward the room's far corner.

Bow’s smile faltered for half a second, his eyes flicking to Adora’s clenched fist and empty wine glass. Still, he said nothing, letting the conversation continue as if he hadn’t noticed, although his eyes briefly locked with Sara as though checking to see if she had seen.

“Adora?” Sara asked softly, frowning.

“No… excuse me, I have to…” Adora trailed off, her voice tight and her eyes narrow. Without finishing her thought, she turned on her heel and fled for the door.

“Adora!” Sara called after her, reaching out instinctively. But Adora glanced back, signing *Stop. Don’t follow.* The motion was sharp

and authoritative—a gesture in the combat sign language every Horde soldier learned as a cadet.

Beside her, Bow froze, startled. When he broke out of his paralysis, he followed after her, apparently not understanding the sign. Sara didn't move- she would not buck that sort of order. Instead, the room to figure out what might have rattled Adora. Her eyes landed on Queen Angella, standing a few paces away, her gaze fixed on the door through which Adora had disappeared. Angella's face was composed, but there was a shadow behind her eyes—disappointment, maybe even pain.

Derrick drifted over to chat with a small knot of people near the bar. A server came over with a tray of drinks. "Do you have anything not alcoholic?" Sara asked. She would have loved something stronger, but the medics said it wasn't a great idea. They were probably right--the room was overly warm, and what Sara had eaten sat uneasily. Probably, she would be fine if she could sit for a minute and drink some water.

The server handed her a glass of clear liquid that fizzed and bubbled. It had no scent, and when she cautiously sipped it, she realized it was water. Bright Moon water bubbled?

Shaking her head at that, she looked for somewhere to sit and finally spotted a couch where she could take a break. She caught Derrick's eyes. " *Over there,"* she signed. She looked at the couch, and he followed her gaze.

*"Meet you later,"* he signed back.

Sipping the cold water, Sara let her eyes drift over the crowd. Felina and Trevor were still at the buffet, piling their plates high, probably for the third or fourth time. At least the kids seemed to be enjoying themselves.

As she crossed over to the couch, a voice said, "Sara, isn't it?"

Startled, Sara turned to find Queen Angella standing beside her. Even without her wings extended, the woman towered over her,

radiant and regal.

Sara nearly got down on one knee from reflex when Queen Angella approached before she remembered that Republic citizens no longer bent the knee to anyone, no matter how highly placed. Instead, she gave the Queen a sharp bow. “How can I help you, ma’am?”

Angella smiled warmly, but her gaze lingered on Sara in a way that made her squirm. The Queen’s eyes swept over her, assessing, before softening with what Sara could only describe as maternal concern.

“You seem pale,” Angella said gently. “Are you all right?”

Sara blinked, caught off guard. “I’m fine, ma’am,” she lied, gripping the back of the couch to steady herself. She couldn’t exactly tell the Queen of Bright Moon she was dizzy because of the little stowaway she and Derrick hadn’t told anyone about yet.

The Queen’s eyebrows furrowed. “Please sit with me, my dear.” Gracefully, she sat on the couch and beckoned.

Trying not to let her relief show, Sara gingerly sat beside her.

Angella tilted her head, her eyes narrowing slightly, and then, with quiet confidence, she asked, “Are you… in a condition?”

The words didn’t register for a moment. “I’m sorry, ma’am?” Sara asked, frowning up at her in confusion.

Angella bit her lip delicately as though weighing whether to clarify. After a beat, she leaned in, lowering her voice to a conspiratorial whisper. “I mean, are you with child?”

Sara froze. Her instinct was to deny it outright, but she realized the Queen wasn’t guessing blindly. But who would bring it up during an event like this?

Where Sara came from, you didn't talk about things like that. It was private. Some things you only talked about with the medics and your squad—people who you trusted with your life.

Her fingers clenched tighter around the couch. "I…" she stammered, casting around for something to say. "We haven't—" she glanced down at herself. It wasn't like she was showing or anything. "How did you know?"

Angella's smile grew serene and almost smug in its certainty. "My people are sensitive to those energies," she said, as though it were obvious. "You have a glow about you,"

*Glow?* Sara barely stopped herself from laughing out loud. *If by glow you mean throwing up every morning and falling asleep on my nose every afternoon, sure.* Sara swallowed hard, forcing a polite smile onto her face. Most hybrids could tell, now that she thought about it, but at least in the Horde, they had the manners not to mention it.

Shit, there were non-Horde hybrids in the crowd here. Would they gossip about it? There'd be a diplomatic incident if anyone she came with heard it.

Angella reached out, placing a warm hand on Sara's shoulder. "Congratulations," she said, her voice kind and earnest, as though she truly believed she'd just bestowed a blessing.

Sara's brain scrambled for a response that wouldn't betray her awkwardness. "Oh. Yes, ma'am. Thank you, ma'am," she managed, the words coming out stiffly.

Angella seemed satisfied, oblivious to the way Sara's stomach churned—not from nausea this time, but from sheer mortification. The Queen's wings shifted slightly behind her, catching the light as she straightened, her regal composure returning.

"I've heard much about your work with the permanently injured," Angella continued smoothly, changing the subject. "It's remarkable, really."

Sara nodded quickly, eager to latch onto a safer topic. “Thank you, ma’am,” she said cautiously. “It’s a group effort.”

Angella inclined her head. “I’d like to visit sometime,” she said. “To see the work firsthand.”

“Of course, ma’am,” Sara replied after a beat, her tone carefully neutral. Internally, she wondered what the Queen’s true motive was—curiosity? Diplomacy? Morbid fascination? “We would be honored.”

The Queen smiled graciously, and Sara swore there was a glint of approval in her gaze. “Thank you. Enjoy your evening,” Angella said, standing.

Sara hurried to rise as well, but the Queen touched her shoulder gently, stopping her. “Oh, no. Please, stay seated.”

Sara hesitated, then nodded, sinking back onto the couch with a faint sigh of relief. Her dizziness had subsided, but her energy was still flagging. She watched as Angella glided away, her wings shifting elegantly with each step, and she exhaled slowly, her pulse finally settling.

As soon as the Queen disappeared into the crowd, Bow was back. “Sorry about that,” he muttered, throwing himself onto the couch next to Sara. “I tried to catch her, but…”

“She was having none of it?” Sara finished, crossing her arms.

“This kind of thing is hard for her.”

“Shocking what you can do when you have no choice,” Sara said dryly.

“She’s never been great at… letting people see her when she’s not okay,” Bow murmured, almost to himself. He glanced toward the door, his brow furrowed. “But sometimes I wonder if she’s trying to convince us or herself.

“I can understand that,” Sara said, not committing to anything. Bow seemed friendly and like he cared about Adora, but she did not need Sara to spread gossip.

“It was good meeting you, Sara,” Bow said politely. “I should go find Glimmer.”

Glimmer? Did he mean Queen Glimmer? Yet again, she shook her head internally at the fact that she knew all of these people. All Sara said out loud was, “See you later.”

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“Adora?”

*Shit.*

Adora froze, her hand gripping the stem of her wine glass like it might steady her spiraling thoughts. For a moment, she considered not answering, pretending she wasn’t there, hiding like a cadet who’d skipped drills. But that felt childish. As childish as fleeing Angella’s reception in the first place.

She exhaled sharply. “I’m… sorry. I’m just not feeling well,” she called--that was not a lie. The room seemed to be gently swaying.

There was a pause on the other side of the door. “Can I come in?” Glimmer asked quietly/

Glimmer never asked to come in. She *popped* in, teleporting wherever she pleased.

“…Yeah. Okay,” Adora said. “Whatever.” The thought made her stomach twist with guilt, but the fog of the wine made it less oppressive.

The door opened, and Glimmer put her face around the door, spotting Adora in the room before she crept in with uncharacteristic caution. She was stunning in her gown—a shimmering violet thing that caught the light with every

movement—every inch a queen. But her eyes were uncertain, and she bit her lip.

She closed the door behind her and leaned against it, her arms crossed, her brow furrowed. For a moment, neither of them spoke.

"I'm sorry. I don't want to take you away from the reception," Adora muttered, breaking the silence. She couldn't bring herself to look at Glimmer, so she hunched over, her fingers tracing the patterns in the wood of the arms of the couch.

"It's fine. They can do without me for minutes at a time." Glimmer's quiet voice had a tiny curl of humor. "You, uh… left pretty quickly." Now, her tone was careful, like she was picking her way through a minefield. "I thought something might be wrong."

Adora shrugged, her eyes drifting back to the glass in her hand. "I just… I needed some air."

"Adora." Glimmer's voice sharpened slightly, and Adora flinched. "Are you okay?"

"I- uh- I drank a little too much. Needed some quiet. That's all."

"Don't lie to me, Adora. I know you better than that," Glimmer snapped, sounding exasperated.

The tone struck a nerve and made her hackles go up. Glimmer had yelled at Adora in that exact tone when they had argued on the battlefield, standing over a Horde soldier as he stared at them in terror.

Adora clenched her fists in her lap, her jaw tightening. " *Do you? Do you really?"* The words came unbidden, sharp, and ugly, muttered quietly. Adora tried to shove it down, but no sooner had it crossed her mind than it tumbled out of her mouth.

"Excuse me?" Glimmer asked. Adora could not tell whether Glimmer had heard her or not.

Adora's head snapped up, her frustration boiling over. "Why are you here?" she growled more loudly than she intended. "You've got a whole room full of people who want your attention. Why aren't you with them?"

Glimmer blinked, startled. "Because I'm worried about you," she said, the words slow and careful as though she wasn't sure how they'd land. "And because you're my friend." She hesitated, her expression flickering with something more uncertain. "And because… I can see you're struggling. I want to help."

Adora froze, her breath catching in her throat. She hadn't expected Glimmer to come right out and say it. For a moment, she didn't know how to respond. Then, slowly, she looked away.

"No." The word came out flat and bitter. Adora finally looked up, and the weight in her gaze stopped Glimmer in her tracks. "I'm not okay, Glimmer. I'm really, *really* not okay."

"Adora…" she started after a moment, her voice quiet and unsure. "What are you talking about?"

She drained her wine glass. She had the bottle open on the table but did not want to reach for it with Glimmer standing there.

Slowly, Glimmer crossed the room and dropped to sit in the easy chair. "Catra said you were really upset with Mom and with me." She sat right in front of Adora and pressed her lips together as if steeling herself. "I… Adora, I'm sorry if I upset you. I never wanted to hurt you, but I'm not sure what I did."

Adora's face felt tight and masklike and her feet were hot in her shoes. She toe-ed them off and shoved them under the couch. "Wait here," she whispered, standing. The room spun a little, and she was glad she was barefoot. It made her feel a little more stable.

She crossed the cool tiled floor to her desk, where the casualty report rested under a paperweight. Trying to resist rereading it, she held it out to Glimmer like a dead fish.

“What is this?” Glimmer said. Her eyes widened as she took it in. “Did Catra show you this?” Was it Adora’s imagination, or did Glimmer sound accusatory? Typical.

“I found it in her quarters. In her files.” Adora hung her head for a second. “I was snooping,” she declared. Then she shrugged jerkily, “So. You can’t blame Catra.”

“Are these… are these numbers accurate?” Glimmer asked, her gaze slowly moving from the paper to Adora’s face, looking pale under her makeup.

“Don’t you know?” Adora hissed.

“I mean… no. I don’t! I don’t even remember…”

“You don’t remember the battle?” Adora let out a sharp, bitter bark of laughter. “Of course you don’t!”

“Adora…?”

“Look at this, Glimmer?” She snatched the report back and jabbed her finger at it. “Sadistic tactics? I thought defending you was so much harder because you were the Queen. Turns out it wasn’t. It was because you established a *reputation* .”

Glimmer lifted her hand to touch the paper as if to verify it was real. “A… reputation?” Her lavender eyes lifted to meet Adora’s “I don’t understand.”

Something about Glimmer’s confusion made Adora want to scream. *Catra* had kept track of the casualties.  She agonized about every drop of blood she spent. She had studied the reports, made notes, and improved tactics. She had gone to the infirmaries to speak with the troops, to improve morale. *Catra* understood what it was like to be on the receiving end of a hostile spell.

“They called you a torturer,” Adora whispered. “Were they wrong?”

“I—” Glimmer’s voice cracked, and she stopped, swallowing hard. “I didn’t…” Her words faltered, and she shook her head, her hands curling into fists. “I didn’t *torture* anyone, Adora.”

Adora’s eyes narrowed, her jaw tight. “Then what do you call *this?* ” She shoved the report toward her, the paper trembling slightly. “ ‘Magical threats?’ ‘Spreading fear?’ *Toying* with soldiers? That’s what *they* said, Glimmer. And the worst part is… I *know* it’s not wrong.”

“I didn’t…” Glimmer faltered, her voice softening for just a heartbeat. A flash of something—regret? Fear?—flickered in her eyes before she hardened again. “I didn’t torture anyone, Adora.”

“Didn’t you?” Adora’s voice cracked. “Because I remember it, Glimmer. I remember the look on that soldier’s face. I remember how they begged you to stop. And you didn’t.” She gulped down the rest of her glass, resisting the impulse to smash it on the tile floor. She remembered the expression on Glimmer’s face as she had threatened a Horde soldier with magic; how the soldier had fled with a cry of terror. Glimmer could not even use the thin excuse that she had not realized how much magic would terrify the Horde troops. She had used their fear—the fear Shadow Weaver had planted in all of them—and twisted it into a weapon. No one asked if that was a war crime. No one dared.

"You got to walk away clean, Glimmer. No trials. No whispers behind your back. No one questioning whether you deserve to be here. Must be nice."

The door slammed shut as Glimmer stormed out, leaving the room heavier than it had been when she entered.

The shame was a weight on Adora's shoulders, crushing and suffocating. Her fingers fumbled for the bottle of wine on the table, and she poured another glass, her hand trembling. The silence pressed in like a vice. Adora stared into the deep red liquid swirling in her glass. She didn’t drink yet, just sat there, her breath shallow, the words she hadn’t said echoing in her mind.

The whispers Adora overheard in Bright Moon about Catra crowded to the forefront of her thoughts. The quiet grumbles that Catra shouldn't have been allowed to walk free. That whatever she'd done to help save Etheria didn't outweigh what she'd done before—the lives lost, the cities destroyed, the choices she couldn't undo. Those murmurs had twisted in Adora's gut like barbed wire, but she'd stood by Catra. She'd defended her—fiercely, without hesitation.

She'd believed Catra deserved a second chance.

So why was it so much harder to give that same grace to Glimmer?

And then, the bitter answer came unbidden: *Because no one else had suggested that Glimmer may have committed crimes.*

Adora's breath hitched as the thought sank in. That day at Spire, Catra had been put on trial *in absentia*. No one had even woke them up to let them know. They had talked about her and then oh so magnanimously decided that loyalty to your kingdom was not a crime. She had even waived her right to hear her crimes. Somehow the fucking Princesses expected her to take the fall for a war started years before she was born.

And everyone... Every single Princess had agreed that was *just.*

But Glimmer? No one had ever called her out. Not really. The Alliance had rallied behind her as their queen, and the Horde had blamed *Adora* for Bright Moon's tactics. Whatever Glimmer had done, no one had dared to put it in the light.

Adora swallowed hard, her throat dry, the edges of her guilt sharpening.

Maybe that was why it hurt more. Glimmer had walked out of the war with the weight of her crown, her grief, and her mistakes, but no one stopped her. No one asked her what her responsibility was. Not even Adora.

Adora exhaled shakily, the sound rattling in the stillness. Her head fell into her hands, her fingers digging into her scalp. The report lay crumpled on the floor, the words etched into her mind even with the paper out of sight. *Torturer. Spreading fear*. She didn't need to look at it again; the accusations burned behind her eyelids every time she closed them.

If no one else was going to care, Adora decided, she would. Someone had to. Someone had to look at all of it—the war, the choices they made, the people they hurt—and *own* it.

She stared into her wine glass, her hand trembling. The faint ripples in the liquid blurred her reflection. She closed her eyes, but all she could see were faces of Horde soldiers, terrified, pleading.

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"Adora?" Catra called as she and Melog came in.

"Hey." Adora's voice was flat, and she sat on their little couch, still in the white gown she'd worn to the reception. Her eyes were red, and the air smelled of salt.

"You okay? Sparkles was freaking out."

"Sparkles can fuck herself," Adore said the words so quietly that anyone but Catra would have missed it.

Melog and Catra exchanged looks. Wordlessly, Melog walked to the balcony; they had a bed where they liked to sleep in the moonlight. Catra sat down beside Adora.

"What happened?

"Greenhill Pass?" Adora slurred. "Glimmer and me… I was so mad at her."

This was not how Catra planned to end tonight, but she knew something terrible was happening when Glimmer, awash in tears, begged Catra to go to Adora.

“They called us torturers,” Adora whispered, her voice cracking on the last word. Her fingers tightened around the wine glass, her knuckles white. “They said we— *I* —spread fear. That I—” Her voice broke, and she shook her head violently, a bitter laugh escaping her throat. “Do you know what it feels like to see your name in a report like that?”

Catra froze, the words hitting her like a punch to the gut. Of course, she knew. Of course, she’d seen similar things in Horde reports. She’d *written* similar things. But hearing it from Adora—seeing how it tore her apart—was different. It felt… wrong. Unfair.

“You *were* better,” Catra insisted, her tone sharper now. “You’re sitting here falling apart over this because you *care*. That’s what makes you different.”

“Care?” Adora scoffed angrily wiping her face with the back of her hand. “Do you think that matters to the soldiers we left behind in pieces? Or the ones Glimmer—” Her voice caught, and she took another deep pull from her glass. The bottle on the table was three-quarters empty, and Adora’s cheeks were flushed. “Glimmer doesn’t even remember, Catra. That’s the worst part. She doesn’t remember.”

“What doesn’t she remember?” Catra asked, flopping her tail into Adora’s lap.

Adora swallowed hard, her grip on the wine glass tightening, but she began to pet Catra’s tail with the other. She had been drinking a lot- Catra could smell how much.

“What she did to them. She used magic—teleporting them into mid-air. Threatening to use magic on them.” Her voice trembled, growing quieter with each word. “*Using* magic on them.” She took another swallow, the buzz of the alcohol inside her insulating her against the guilt and shame. “They were terrified of her. Of us.”

Catra stared at her, her stomach twisting. She knew firsthand what it was like to be on the receiving end of magic like that.

Shadow Weaver's spells still lit up her nightmares.

There had been something *personal* in the way Glimmer used magic in battle. Catra had seen glimpses of it from afar—an anger that burned too hot, too recklessly. Catra had seen it when she fought Glimmer one-on-one, when she realized that Glimmer had cold-bloodedly used She Ra as bait. After that, DT kept Catra well informed of Glimmer's mental state and the rift between Adora and Glimmer.

When Catra and Glimmer opened up to each other on Prime's ship, Glimmer talked about her regrets. How she had mistreated Adora and Bow, and how she had listened to Shadow Weaver. Even during the war, Catra had seen Shadow Weaver's fingerprints on a lot of the bullshit Glimmer was pulling.

Adora reached for the bottle on the table and poured herself another glass.

"Did you eat?" Catra asked. She rolled her eyes when Adora shook her head."If I get some of that party food sent up and put it in front of you, do you think you can eat it?"

Adora nodded, but she looked unwontedly disinterested. Catra crossed over to the shelf that held her tablet and quickly ordered something sent up. Adora was going to be sick as shit at this rate. Maybe if she transformed and then ate? Could Adora *get* alcohol poisoning?

Surreptitiously, Catra texted Aunt Casta. She'd be busy at the reception, but Catra wanted to give her a heads up in case this turned into something she and Melog couldn't handle.

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Halfway through the evening, Bow found Sara again as she sat at a table in the corner of the hall. Derrick, Felina, and Trevor were still on the dance floor, but Sara needed to rest fShe watched the dancers, absentmindedly stirring her water with a straw. Bow sat

across from her, leaning on his elbows, his ordinarily bright expression dimmed by concern.

"Everything okay?" Sara asked softly, breaking the silence between them. "I mean, Adora. Is she okay? She didn't look good."

Bow sighed, running a hand through his curly hair. "Adora's always been good at... holding it together. Even when she shouldn't have to." His voice was quiet but heavy. "She doesn't like people worrying about her."

Sara didn't answer for a moment, weighing how much she should say. Entrapta had always spoken highly of this Bow person and clearly he cared about Adora. Still, some things were difficult to speak of. Finally, she grunted, setting her glass down hard. "Someone should worry about her."

"She's been through a lot," Bow said gently. "But she's stronger than you think."

"Stronger than I think?" A spasm of exasperated laughter burst from Sara. "Do you even hear yourself? She's hanging on by her fingernails."

Bow winced, his gaze dropping to the table. He seemed to have no words to counter that—because he knew it was true.

Sara's voice softened, but the edge remained sharp enough to cut. "She's lost." The condensation from her glass left wet circles on the table, and she idly traced her finger through one. "We're all trying to figure out who we are without the war, but it's tougher for her."

"What do you mean?"

Sara paused, debating how much to say. Bow's concern and anger simmered in his eyes, and she decided to keep going.

“Her whole life, she was Shadow Weaver’s project. That’s its very own house of horrors.” Sara tapped her finger once on the rim of her glass, her expression grim. “There were a lot of rumors about her. Ugly ones.”

Bow nodded slowly, his jaw tightening. “I know Shadow Weaver played a lot of mind games.”

“Mind games?” Sara scoffed, tossing the little stirrer from her glass onto the table. “That’s an understatement. That woman broke people.” Her voice dropped, heavy with disgust. “From what I hear, Adora wasn’t just another cadet. She was Shadow Weaver’s project. Her experiment.”

Bow leaned forward, his brow furrowing. “What do you mean?”

“I know people who worked in the creche in Adora’s section.” Sara’s tone was low, deliberate. “They never even saw her.”

Bow blinked, confused. “What do you mean they didn’t see her?”

“Shadow Weaver didn’t let Adora interact with most other cadets. She only got hand-picked companions. If you didn’t measure up, you were… disposable.”

Bow’s breath caught, his expression rippling with shock. His hands tightened on the table like he needed to anchor himself. “Disposable? You mean…?”

“I mean exactly what it sounds like,” Sara said grimly. “Shadow Weaver burned through people. Adora came up to her standards. But I wonder…” Her voice faltered. “What would’ve happened if she didn’t?”

Bow’s face hardened. His ordinarily warm and open expression was replaced by something cold and angry. “I didn’t realize it was that bad.”

Sara’s mouth twisted. “Whatever you’re thinking,” she said grimly, “the reality is much worse.”

Bow opened his mouth to reply, but Sara cut him off, her voice softening, tinged with unease. “Adora... the night I met her... she got drunk and spent a good twenty minutes telling me things I cannot repeat.”

Bow’s eyes widened in alarm. “What kinds of things?”

“Not my story to tell.” Sara looked away, her fingers tracing a slow circle in the condensation on her glass. She to weighed her words for a moment, debating how far to go. Finally, she said, “But, listen… Shadow Weaver…” She ground her teeth, struggling to find the words. Old memories—ones she’d buried deep—were clawing to the surface. “She left a long line of victims behind her.” Sara’s tone turned flat, matter-of-fact. "Dark magic leaves scars—on the body and the mind. Some of us carry them in places no one can see."

Bow frowned, his confusion apparent. “I mean, yeah, she was cruel, but—”

“No.” Sara’s gaze snapped back to his, sharp and unflinching. “Listen to me.” Her voice dropped even further, nearly a whisper. “I mean… everyone knows she was into dark shit. Not just magic.” She glanced around again; she could not help it. “I mean, the kind of thing you can’t talk about in polite company.”

Bow’s expression changed—realization dawning slowly, painfully. Then intelligence flooded his face, and his voice came out strangled. “Oh… oh, you mean—”

Sara nodded tightly, her relief palpable. “As I said.”

“That… Explains some things.” He sighed and rubbed his chin, his thoughts turned inwards.

# Good Night

Chapter Summary

Angella's reception comes to an end. Plans are made clear.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Glimmer?" Bow called softly, stepping into the Queen's Residence and closing the door behind him. "Are you here?" The place was dark, but it felt like someone was there.

A cleared throat and a soft "Back here" answered his question. "In the window."

"Are you by yourself?" he asked, surprised; he thought Adora would be with her. On the other hand, it would be the first time Glimmer had voluntarily been alone since Prime's ship, and thus, a minor triumph.

He flicked on a light so he wouldn't trip over anything, the soft glow illuminating the room's lavish furnishings.

"Yeah." Glimmer's voice sounded small and sad, coming from the tiny library that served as the monarch's private office. The book-filled room, with its wool carpet and soft furnishings, was warm, quiet, and serene.

A round window looked out over the entire palace grounds, and the city of Bright Moon dominated the room. Beyond the city, the misty distance revealed the faint twinkle of lights from the towns and villages that pledged their allegiance to Bright Moon. Most of the palace's windows faced inward toward the comforting glow of the Moonstone or the shelter of the Whispering Woods. But this one was meant to remind the Monarch of the scope of their domain—and its weight.

No light in the office, and Glimmer didn't say anything at Bow's entrance- she just sat in the cushioned window seat, her shoes on the floor, her stockinged feet propped up. Her silhouette seemed smaller than usual as she stared out of the window.

"You okay?"  Bow's voice was gentle, but Glimmer flinched. She looked down at her hands twisted in her lap, her fingers fidgeting with the hem of her dress.

"I'm fine," she said quickly, the words brittle and unconvincing. "It's nothing."

"Please don't do that," he said, too worried to beat around the bush. "You don't have to pretend to be fine. Not for me." He reached out and covered her hand with his."Were you able to talk to Adora?"

Glimmer's eyes filled with tears as she nodded. "I'm worried about her, Bow," she whispered, her voice cracking. "She's so mad at me." She buried her face in her hands.

"Mad?" Bow asked, but Glimmer didn't respond. The room was silent except for the soft sound of her sobs.

"Hey, hey." Bow gathered her in his arms and was gratified when she let him.  "It's okay, let it out."

Glimmer scooted toward the window to give him room, so they sat shoulder to shoulder, resting their backs against the padded backrest. He put one arm around her,  waiting for her tears to slow while staring at the tranquil scene below.

They had both cried a fair amount since the war ended, and he had been waiting for this breakdown since Angella's return. Though a source of joy and jubilation, it had complicated Glimmer's life exponentially, especially since no one wanted to address whether Angella would retake the throne.

It took a long time, but Glimmer eventually quieted. She pulled her hands away from her face and whispered, "I'm sorry."

“What happened?” Bow asked softly.

“Adora found a casualty report in Catra’s files,” Glimmer said, her voice breaking. “She thinks I was hiding it from her, that I lied on purpose.” Her hands twisted in her lap. “But the worst part is… I wasn’t.”

“What do you mean?” Bow asked carefully.

Wrapping her arms around herself, she shivered as though cold, even with Bow pressed to her side.

Bow opened his mouth to respond, but Glimmer shook her head, cutting him off. “That’s why Adora’s so angry,” she said, her voice uncharacteristically flat. “She thinks I hid it from her, but what I did is so much worse.” Her breath hitched, and she curled in on herself, her arms wrapping tightly around her knees. “I didn’t even look, Bow.” She let out a sharp, bitter laugh that made Bow flinch. “Because what if I looked, huh? What if I saw their faces? Their names? Then what?” Her hands twisted in her lap, her grip tightening until her knuckles went white. “Easier to think of it all as a game.”

“Glimmer…” Bow said softly, reaching out to cover her hand with his, but she pulled away.

“Don’t,” she said sharply, her voice trembling. “I don’t deserve—I *chose* this, Bow. Shadow Weaver told me I had to choose what kind of Queen I wanted to be. And I…” Her voice cracked again, a bitter laugh escaping her lips. Her breath hitched, a bitter laugh escaping her. “I chose not to look at the costs. I stopped caring about the cost.”

“I know,” Bow admitted quietly, his voice heavy with the weight of his guilt.

She froze, her tear-streaked face snapping toward him. “What?” she whispered, her voice breaking on the word.

“I mean, yeah,” Bow said, his voice softer now but no less pained. “You didn’t exactly hide it.” The words felt harsh as they left his mouth, and he winced internally.

Glimmer stared at him for a long moment, her lips trembling. Then she let out a hollow laugh, her shoulders shaking. “Of course you did,” she said bitterly, her voice dripping with self-loathing. “Of course, you knew. Everyone knew, didn’t they? And no one stopped me.” Her laugh turned sharp and manic, echoing in the quiet room. “No one stopped me because I was the Queen. Because Shadow Weaver told me I was strong, and I believed her. Because I was too stubborn and too stupid to see the truth.”

“Shadow Weaver poisoned everyone she ever spoke to.” Angella’s voice out of the darkness made Bow and Glimmer jump. They turned to see Glimmer’s mom step into the room, her face shadowed and drawn. Micah followed close behind, his expression grim.

Bow hastened to stand, but Micah raised a hand. “Thank you, but we won’t be long,” he said, his tone soft but firm. There was an uncomfortable stillness in the room, as though everyone in it could feel the weight of the raw emotions hanging in the air.

Angella’s eyes brimmed with unshed tears. “You made mistakes,” she said. Her voice was scratchy and thin.

Glimmer opened her mouth to reply, an instinctive defense rising to her lips, but Angella lifted a hand, silencing her before she could speak.

“We all did,” Angella continued, her gaze steady but glistening with unspoken regret. Beside her, Micah reached for her hand, giving it a reassuring squeeze. “I’m afraid you inherited many of ours. But you’ve done something neither your father nor I could do—you’ve bridged the gap.”

Her words hung in the air, heavy and bittersweet. Glimmer’s throat tightened, but she said nothing, her eyes fixed on her lap

as if afraid to meet her mother's gaze.

Angella's hand moved gently to Glimmer's shoulder, her touch light but grounding. "Glimmer," she said softly, her voice dipping lower, "I do want to talk more with you about this—and Adora—but I fear she is not ready yet." There was a pause, her voice growing almost inaudible. "I never knew…" Angella hesitated, her shoulders slumping slightly. "I thought I was guiding her, but I see now… I may have only made her feel more alone."

The quiet words fractured something inside Glimmer. She glanced up, her eyes glassy with tears that had not yet fallen. Reaching out, she laid her hand lightly over Angella's.

Since Angella's return, mother and daughter touched each other constantly, making small gestures to reassure themselves of the other's presence. This moment was no different. Their hands rested together.

Breaking the silence, Glimmer's voice came, soft and uneven. "Did Aunt Casta tell you they're leaving?"

Micah nodded slowly. "Casta said they will head out to that camp near Spire to help. They just talked to Perfuma and Scorpia about it. Officially, it will be billed as one of the reparation efforts."

"Reparations." Glimmer scoffed bitterly, her voice edged with frustration. Throughout the treaty negotiations, the Alliance had fought the idea tooth and nail. In the end, there was no other choice. The Horde wouldn't accept any aid if they saw it as pity. "So, I guess She-Ra is going to pay Alliance debts again." Her tone was as dry as morning in the Crimson Waste.

"I doubt Adora sees it like that," Micah said gently. "From what Casta said, she's really excited."

Bow saw it before he heard it—Glimmer's hands twisted in her lap, her fingers tightening until her knuckles went pale.

"Of course, she's excited!" Glimmer's voice rose, sharp and bitter. "She gets to run off and be She-Ra, saving the day like she always does, while I'm here signing treaties and pretending everything's fine." She crossed her arms across her chest.

"That's not fair, Glimmer," Bow said quietly. "Adora's been through a lot too. She's doing this because she wants to help."

Glimmer scoffed, but the fight seemed to drain out of her. She slumped back against the window seat, her voice softening. "I know. I know…. But sometimes it just feels like... I don't know… like she's off  doing her hero thing, and everyone wants me to let Mom have the throne back." She looked out of the window. "Like, no one trusts me even after everything I've done." Her eyes went to her mother. Widening, almost as though she had forgotten that her mother was there.

For a moment, Angella said nothing, but Bow saw the way her hand faltered where it rested on Glimmer's shoulder, her grip tightening slightly.  "Do… do you really believe that, Glimmer?" she asked softly, her voice thick with something Bow couldn't name.

The question knocked the fight right out of Glimmer. Her shoulders dropped, the defiance draining from her posture. "No," she said softly, almost too quietly to hear. "Not really. "

Bow saw how she hunched slightly, her gaze fixed on her hands, fidgeting in her lap as if she couldn't bring herself to look at her mother.

Bow's heart twisted. He knew she didn't mean it, but hearing her lash out like that still hurt. And Angella… She was trying; Bow could see that, but they weren't quite meeting each other in the middle. A brittle silence followed; it was as if the world might shatter if anyone said the wrong thing.

"Then what is it?" Angella asked gently, her voice quieter now.

Glimmer's fingers tighten around each other, but this time, she didn't snap. "Since you got back… I keep feeling like everyone is looking to you," she admitted, her voice barely audible. "People have been talking. Tonight, the Horde First Counselor asked me to my face. Wanting to know if you'll let me keep the throne. Like she just can't wait."

The King and the older Queen exchanged looks.

"We were going to speak to you about it," Micah said heavily. "It's just…" he trailed off and looked toward Angella.

"I feel you  misunderstood the Horde counselor's intent." Angella sighed softly, her hand lingering on Glimmer's shoulder. "They wanted to know if you would cede the throne to me. If so, they wanted to inform me they would have to consider pulling out of the treaty."

Glimmer's head whipped back around, and her breath hitched in her chest. If the Horde pulled out of the treaty, that would set them back months. It was possible that hostilities would break out again.

"What are we going to do?" Glimmer gasped. "We can't let them do that!" Bow could see her bracing herself like she used to whenever she had to argue with Angella about tactics during the war.

The King and Queen exchanged glances. Micah gave Angella a small, encouraging smile.

"That's true, we can't. After speaking with Scorpia, I think it would be wise for us to step aside." Angella bit her lip, waiting for Glimmer's answer.

Glimmer's jaw dropped. "Y-you mean that? You… don't want to be Queen anymore?"

"I fear the isolation we have both experienced has left us ill-equipped to rule," Angella admitted quietly. "There have been too

many changes."

"Yes." Micah nodded in agreement. "We can help. We can advise. We can even be regents if you must be away from Bright Moon. But, people trust you." He took Angella's free hand. "Sadly, neither of us can say the same."

"You showed me that isolating Bright Moon was a mistake," Angella confessed. "You drew a hard line in the sand against the Horde. You and Adora created the Alliance."

Micah nodded, his expression grim. "But then, you did the impossible—you've bridged the gap. That's something neither of us could have done."

"What do you mean?" Bow asked curiously.

"The Horde Republic Council says that Bright Moon's treaty was signed and negotiated by Glimmer. Not me or Angella. They… ah… they took a dim view of my part in Catra's trial." He shrugged and put his arm around Angella's waist. "If people are talking, perhaps we would announce our plans tonight? I think the speculation is probably adding a lot of stress." He shook his head. "I know it's adding to mine."

Glimmer nodded, tapping her lips with her index finger. "That might be a good thing."

"But, Glimmer." Angella put her hands on her daughter's shoulders. "Please, do not let us burden you.  If you are too distressed by what happened between you and Adora, I can give your apologies. An announcement can wait."

Glimmer shook her head. "No." She cleared her throat and stood, carefully brushing the wrinkles from her shimmering gossamer gown.  "If I'm still the Queen, this Is still my job."

"Let me go fix my face." She gestured at herself, where her tears had caused her makeup to run. She padded over the thick carpet to her bedroom.

When she emerged again, her makeup was restored, and her face was a composed mask of dignified interest. Bow offered her his arm. Micah and Angella fell into step behind them.

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The reception stretched almost until midnight, with Glimmer staying until the last guest had departed. Some headed home, while others retired to the guest rooms within the palace if their journey back was too far. She had smiled and nodded through every farewell, but Bow could see that the weight of the evening hung heavily on her shoulders.

Neither Adora nor Catra had returned, and Bow lingered in the silence that followed the last guests. The echo of laughter and music faded into the distant halls, leaving him alone with his thoughts—and they weren't comforting. His mind kept circling back to the conversations he'd had throughout the evening. Sara's quiet words gnawed at him. Her concern for Adora had mirrored his own, each observation she made about Adora's behavior slicing through him like a blade. Adora's increasingly erratic actions weighed heavily on him, stirring memories of the war. The last time she had been like this was after Glimmer's disappearance, and they had almost lost her then.

At least Angella's announcement had been met with overwhelming enthusiasm. The response from the Hordefolk had been striking. Bow had overheard more than one comment about Glimmer and Catra's unlikely friendship and how clearly Bright Moon's young Queen had been influenced—for the better—by Catra and Scorpia.

"She's not her parents," Councilor Cobalt said to Bow. They initially met at the Spire Encampment for the treaty negotiation, and Bow found him to be a thoughtful, interesting person. "I fought Micah and the first Alliance," he had told Bow, "He was *terrifying.* Queen Glimmer's got guts to go up against her father," he finished approvingly as they stood applauding after Angella's short speech.

One of the other Horde council members nodded as he put in his opinion."The Water Princess and the King were ready to start the whole war over," he had told the group. "And the Queen talked them out of it."

Yet again, Bow could not believe how lucky they had been that Catra had wanted peace.

The stories circulating through the reception painted a picture of Glimmer standing firm, arguing for restraint, and demanding that the Etherian Horde be given official recognition rather than treating their leaders as criminals. It was such a far cry from the position the Horde had expected from Brightmoon's royalty, and it gave Bow hope—for Glimmer, for the Alliance, and for the fragile peace they were all desperately trying to hold together.

But as Bow glanced down at Glimmer's trembling hands, his optimism wavered. She was running on empty, holding herself together with sheer determination. Adora wasn't the only one struggling to face the truth. Glimmer carried her own burdens, and Bow wondered how long she could shoulder them alone.

Gently, he offered her his arm. She took it, looking up at him with a tired smile. "Thanks." Instead of teleporting, they walked.

"What're you thinking?" Bow asked. Glimmer liked to walk when she was thinking something through.

"How the Horde sees Catra and me." Glimmer hesitated. ""Catra's the hero," she said, her voice low. "She's the one who broke the cycle. And me? I'm just… the Queen who has to earn their forgiveness." She laughed bitterly.

"I don't think it's about forgiveness," Bow said softly. "I think it's about seeing who you are now. "

"Yeah. Maybe." She shook her head. "It's funny, isn't it? How people decide who needs forgiveness and who doesn't." She smiled faintly. "Remember when we met Adora?"

“Yes.” Bow did not know where she was going with that.

“She said how terrifying Princesses were. I never thought about that before, you know? How we looked to the average soldier?” Her steps faltered, just for a moment, and Bow tightened his grip on her arm to steady her. The way her shoulders slumped told him everything. “I don’t think they’re wrong,” she whispered so quietly it seemed she had not meant him to hear.

Together, they walked back to the Queen’s residence. The palace halls were mostly empty now, save for the occasional staff clearing away the remnants of the evening. “I’m so tired,” Glimmer admitted after a moment. “But I was going to try to talk to Adora before they left."

“I wouldn’t. She’s probably asleep.”

Glimmer nodded thoughtfully. “Yeah, she was drinking a lot. I bet she passed out right after I left her.” She nodded graciously at a pair of cleaning staff as they passed, her smile faint but polite. “But that just means they’re even more likely to leave stupid early.”

“Maybe you could send her a letter,” Bow suggested. “Leave it in her skiff?”

“That… sounds like a good idea. What should I say?”

Bow blinked, surprised. He’d expected her to stew on it for days or brush it off entirely. Instead, she was asking for his help—a rare thing.

“Well,” The archer chose his words carefully. “I think… you should tell her how you feel. Be honest. Adora needs to hear that from you.”

Letting out a shaky breath, Glimmer tightened her grip on Bow’s arm. “Honest… Right,” she murmured, her tone more hesitant than he’d expected. “What if it just makes things worse? What if I say the wrong thing?”

Bow stopped and turned to face her, placing a reassuring hand over hers. “You won’t say the wrong thing,” he said firmly. “Adora’s been through a lot, but so have you. She knows that. I think she’ll understand—if anyone will, it’s her.”

Her lips pressed into a thin line, and she looked down at the polished stone floor, her free hand fidgeting with the hem of her sleeve. “I don’t even know where to start,” she admitted quietly.

Bow’s gaze softened. “Tell her you’re sorry about the fight tonight but also that you’re worried about her. Let her know you care.”

Glimmer hesitated, her eyes flicking up to meet his. “And if she doesn’t care back?” she asked, her voice barely above a whisper.

Bow’s chest tightened at the fear he heard in her voice—the fear of rejection, of losing someone else she loved. He shook his head, his voice gentle but resolute. “You know she does. She wouldn’t have been so mad if she didn’t care.

For a long moment, Glimmer stood there, staring at him, her expression caught between uncertainty and something deeper, something raw. Then she nodded slowly. “Okay,” she said, her voice steadier now. “Okay. I’ll write it tonight.”

Bow smiled softly, giving her hand a supportive squeeze. “Good. You’ll feel better once you’ve said what you need to say.”

As they resumed their walk, Glimmer’s steps seemed a little lighter, though her shoulders were still weighed down by the events of the night. “Thanks, Bow,” she said after a moment, her voice quieter now, but warm. “For… everything.”

“You don’t have to thank me,” Bow replied gently. “I kinda think it’s my job now.”

A tired chuckle emerged from Glimmer’s lips. “Yep. That is true.”

As they walked back to the Queen’s residence, the palace quiet now except for the occasional echo of distant voices, Bow glanced

down at Glimmer's hand resting lightly on his arm, he could feel the tension in her grip.

"You okay?" he asked gently.

Glimmer hesitated, then nodded, though her smile didn't quite reach her eyes. "I'm fine." But her voice was less brittle than before.

Bow didn't press her. They'd been through enough tonight, and she needed time to breathe, to process. So instead, he said, "You know I'm not going anywhere, right?"

Her hand tightened briefly on his arm, and for the first time that evening, her smile softened, reaching her eyes. "I know," she said, and for a moment, she sounded like herself again.

"I'm glad that Mom and Dad decided to retire." Glimmer said softly.

"Yeah?" They had not had time to talk about it yet.

Glimmer smiled wryly. "Moving all my stuff to my old room would just be such a pain."

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The hallway outside Adora and Catra's room was quiet. The reception downstairs was winding down. The sounds of conversation and music were far enough away to fade into a gentle white noise. Moonlight spilled through the arched windows, painting the polished stone floor in silver. The tiny glass beads on Castaspella's gown caught the light, glinting faintly. Catra, by contrast, stood stiff and restless, shifting her weight from foot to foot as her tail flicked in sharp, uneven motions behind her.

"How is she, Catra?" Castaspella asked softly.

"Asleep," Catra replied, her clipped tone betraying nothing but the sharp twitch of her ears. She glanced over her shoulder toward the door.

Aunt Casta nodded, her hands clasped loosely in front of her. "Probably for the best."

Catra hesitated, her tail flicking sharply behind her. She should've just said goodnight, gone back to her room, and pretended nothing was wrong. That was easier. Safer. But Aunt Casta was still looking at her, waiting, and suddenly, the ache in her chest felt too heavy to carry alone. She glanced back at the door, then at the floor, then finally at Castaspella. Her ears twitched slightly, and her weight shifted again. "Do you have a minute?" she asked, her voice quieter now, almost hesitant. "I know you probably need to get to bed, but…"

"For you? Always," the sorceress replied, her smile sincere.

The magicat's throat tightened, and she opened her mouth to say something—anything—but the words tangled with the ache rising in her chest. Instead, a small, choked sob slipped out before she could stop it. Her eyes widened in horror, her ears flattening against her head as her cheeks burned. Slapping a hand over her mouth, she cursed herself silently. Her tail lashed sharply behind her, betraying her irritation—not with Castaspella, but with herself.

What the hell was wrong with her? Aunt Casta probably thought she was falling apart.

"Catra?" Castaspella's gentle voice cut through Catra's spiral. When Catra shook her head and stepped back, trying to escape, the sorceress reached out and caught her arm with a firm but careful grip. "Come on," she said, her tone leaving no room for argument. "Let's sit down."

Catra wanted to argue, to snap that she was fine, but the lump in her throat was too thick to speak past. Reluctantly, she let herself be guided into the room.

The space inside was dim, lit only by the faint glow of a small nightlight burning near the bed. The sheer drapes were tightly shut around it, muffling Adora's snores. Melog's head poked out

through the opening, their luminous eyes catching the light as they chuffed softly in approval before curling back into their spot at Adora's feet.

Casta led her to the small couch by the wall and gestured for her to sit. Catra sank down, her knees pulled up slightly, her arms wrapping tightly around herself. She stared at the floor, her ears flicking, and tried to focus on the soothing rhythm of Adora's breathing instead of the gnawing ache clawing at her chest.

Castaspella sat beside her, close but not too close, the way only someone practiced in comforting others could manage. "We shouldn't leave her alone. Can I use a spell so we won't disturb Adora?" she asked gently.

The fact that Aunt Casta always asked before using magic warmed Catra in a way she couldn't quite articulate. It wasn't something everyone bothered to do. She nodded. "Yeah. That'd be good."

The sigil Castaspella traced in the air glowed faintly, painting the room in soft purple light before fading. A shimmer settled around them, barely perceptible before disappearing entirely.

"There," Casta said, leaning back slightly. "We can talk freely now. We'll still hear her if she needs anything."

"Thanks," Catra muttered, blowing out a breath as her shoulders slumped. The room felt colder than usual, or maybe it was just her nerves. She pulled her arms tighter around herself.

"Are you all right?" Casta asked gently, watching her closely.

Catra shook her head, her ears flattening again. "Adora got stupid drunk tonight. She and Glimmer had a huge fight."

"Yes, I heard." Castaspella's voice took on an uncharacteristic grimness. "I spoke to Glimmer just before Angella made her announcement."

“Announcement?” Catra’s tail flicked sharply, her curiosity piqued.

“They’re officially stepping aside from the throne in favor of Glimmer.”

Catra blinked, processing that. Then she let out a long breath, feeling her shoulders relax. “Finally.” She slumped back against the couch, tilting her head to stare up at the ceiling. “The Council’s been losing their minds about it all week.” Catra had not put a lot of thought into how many people would jump to the conclusion that, of course, Angella would retake Brightmoon’s throne. Had she realized it was going to stress everyone out so much, she would have asked them to keep it on the down low. As it was, Scorpia and Perfuma had to talk several of them out of panic attacks when they broke the news. “They don’t trust Micah or Angella—they only know Angella as the evil queen, and Micah is a sorcerer.” She shrugged.

Castaspella looked sad at that. “I hope that we can eventually help the Hordefolk become less afraid of magic.”

“The only sorceress most know about was Shadow Weaver.”

“That explains the general fear of magic, then,” Aunt Casta said dryly.

“Pretty much.” Catra agreed. “But Glimmer? They think she’s redeemable.”

“Redeemable?” Aunt Casta’s tone carried quiet curiosity, but there was no judgment in it—only an invitation for Catra to continue.

Catra nodded, her tail flicking once behind her before curling tightly around her ankle. “Yeah. They talk about her fighting dirty, but they say she didn’t have a choice. She had the war dumped on her, and everyone gets that she wasn’t about to just say, ‘Okay, fine,’ and surrender.” Her voice was even, but the tip of her tail lashed, betraying the emotions beneath. “They know she wasn’t fighting for power; she was desperate.”

Casta tilted her head slightly, listening intently, her hands resting loosely in her lap.

Catra leaned forward, her claws drumming lightly on her knees. “Perfuma’s a genius when it comes to people. She talks about how Scorpia went—‘on my orders,’” she made little air quotes with her fingers, her tone dry, “to Bright Moon to offer a chance at negotiation, which Glimmer accepted.” Her ears flicked back, her gaze dropping briefly to the floor. “That’s what everyone thinks the fight I had with Hordak was about and why Prime captured the three of us. I'm not going to tell them any different."

Her voice dipped, quieter now, threaded with something softer. “And then Glimmer helped save me. She fought Prime with me. That’s enough for them to believe she can change.”

Castaspella’s eyes softened. “How do you feel about that?”

Catra shrugged, the motion sharp and defensive. “It’s smart. It works. People believe it.” Her ears tilted back briefly, and she avoided Castaspella’s gaze. “It’s not like they’re wrong.”

The magicat’s tail flicked, her claws digging into the couch cushions. “I’m not sure folks around here,” she waved her hand to encompass the whole of Bright Moon, “want to give me the same courtesy,” she muttered. “The Horde is willing to look at her and see someone trying to do better. But, sometimes I feel like the folks here, they look at me, and… they’re still waiting for me to screw up.” She scoffed bitterly.

Looking stricken, Castaspella asked, “Has someone said something to you?”

Catra’s tail lashed again, and her ears pinned back. “No, nothing like that.” She looked away, her eyes fixed on some distant point on the floor. “Not out loud, anyway. But I walk into a room, and all of a sudden, all I can smell is fear.”

Castaspella’s face softened, her brow furrowing with concern. “That sounds hard.”

“Yeah. I knew it would be hard when I came.” Smiling wearily, the magicat brushed her bangs back. “Mystacor’s different,” Catra said, her voice quieter now. “People there… they’re more interested in their magic and their books than in me. They don’t look at me like I’m some wild animal waiting to pounce.” She paused, her ears flicking. “It’s easier to breathe there.”

“I’m glad to hear that.” Aunt Casta smiled. “I would be very annoyed if they were giving my family a hard time.”

“I… what?” Catra stared at Castaspella, not quite understanding.

“Catra.” Aunt Casta caught and held her eyes. “I know we haven't known each other long, but I am very fond of you.” She hesitated as if weighing her words. “I see the way you look out for for your friends. The way you take care of them—even when it’s hard.” She stopped and looked down at her hands as if surprised that she was not holding knitting needles. “Glimmer told me a little of what happened on Prime’s ship. How you came to be captured.” Her lips curved into a soft smile.  “You have a good heart.”

Heat rushed into Catra’s cheeks, and she bit her lip, trying to get herself under control. Nevertheless, tears ran down her cheeks, and she was shaking. “That… Th-thanks.”

Slowly, Aunt Casta shifted closer. “Can I…? Would you like a hug?”

Catra’s breath hitched, and her ears flicked back. Almost against her will, she nodded, her tail lashing once. “I’m not exactly… good at this.”

“I already think of you as family,” Castaspella said, her voice soft but steady. When Catra’s eyes widened, startled, Casta hesitated, her expression almost shy. “I… hope that’s all right?”

Catra opened her mouth to respond, but her voice caught in her throat. She wasn’t used to this—words like that, warmth like this. Her tail flicked nervously, wrapping around her ankle as she tried

to think of something to say. “Yeah,” she finally managed, her voice quiet and rough. “It’s… it’s all right.”

Castaspella smiled as she wrapped her arm around Catra’s shoulders. “Good,” she said. “Because you are.

It was *more* than all right, and Catra leaned into the unaccustomed affection. In the back of her head, Catra felt Melog’s gentle approval. They really liked Aunt Casta.

“So, tell me about Adora.” Castaspella prompted, squeezing the magicat’s shoulder.

Catra nodded and explained Adora’s plan to work at the refugee camp.

“I’m glad you’re going with her,” Aunt Casta told Catra, her voice warm with approval. “It’s an excellent idea. And I think it’ll be good for Adora to be back among her own people for a while.”

Catra tilted her head, her ears flicking. “Her people?” she asked, unsure if she liked how that sounded.

“Yes,” Castaspella said, smiling gently. “Adora grew up surrounded by Hordefolk, didn’t she? They’re a part of her, just like Bright Moon is. Maybe now she’ll get to see the part worth *belonging* to.”

Catra frowned, her tail curling tighter around her ankle. “Belonging?” she gritted, her spine stiffening. “In the Horde?”

For a moment, Aunt Casta was silent, and then she sighed. “I must confess, I was one of those people who was somewhat suspicious of Adora at first.”

Catra looked up at the sorceress quizzically-- she had always wondered how Adora had managed in those first few months.

“I could not understand how she could just walk away from everything she had known.”

“Join the club,” muttered Catra, crossing her arms over her chest, almost but not entirely pulling away from the older woman.

“When I found out that Shadow Weaver had raised her, it made more sense,” Aunt Casta finished in almost the same tone.

Something about the tenor of Casta’s voice arrested Catra’s spiral. She looked up, her ears flicking uncertainly. “I don’t understand.”

“She was very good at isolating people,” Castaspella said quietly. Her hand moved to stroke Catra’s hair—a soft, grounding gesture—but her scent spiked with distress, a sharp tang of emotions kept tightly in check. Her movements and expression remained serene, but Catra could sense the tension beneath them. She did it to Micah and me. Right under the noses of everyone at Mystacor—people who should have seen it but didn’t.”

Casta’s voice faltered momentarily, her gaze fixed on some far-off memory. “We were both considered prodigies, you know. But Shadow Weaver saw that. She made Micah believe he was invincible and made me believe I was a failure. I thought I was the problem—I wasn’t good enough and didn’t belong. It worked.”

Catra’s breath hitched, her claws digging into the fabric of the couch. The words were like ice water down her spine, each slotting into place with things she already knew and had tried to forget. Memories of Shadow Weaver’s voice clawed their way to the surface. Her manipulations, her lies, her punishments disguised as lessons. The way she’d made them fight for her approval and made them believe they weren’t enough—not without her.

“She…” Catra swallowed hard, her voice cracking under the weight of the admission. “She did the same thing to us.”

“I know.” Casta’s reply was quiet, reverent even, but her sorrow was palpable, threading through every word. Her gaze softened,

though her back remained straight, her posture that of a ruler even here.

She leaned forward slightly, her long, elegant hands resting on her knees. The movement was precise, controlled—a habit drilled into her from years as Mystacor's chief sorceress, where poise and authority were essential tools. "When I finally thought about it, I realized… of course, Adora had no loyalty to the Horde."

Her tone turned bitter, sharp edges cutting through her otherwise calm demeanor. "Her loyalty was to Shadow Weaver. All of it. And when that finally broke—when she saw through Shadow Weaver's lies—" Casta paused, her lips pressing into a thin, trembling line. Her next words came heavier, almost a whisper. "It broke her entire world. She had nothing left. I think she went into a kind of shock."

Catra's claws dug into the couch, her ears flattening as Casta's words carved into her like a blade.

"And do you know what I hate the most?" Casta asked seriously, a note of steel in her tone. "Adora gave that loyalty to us—to me, to Glimmer, to Bright Moon—because it was the only way she knew how to survive."

Catra's chest tightened, her breath catching painfully in her throat. She could see it now—Adora standing on that first day in Bright Moon, stiff and formal, her shoulders squared like she was bracing for inspection, desperate for approval, for someone to tell her she'd made the right choice. Standing alone, ripped away from everything she'd ever known and trusted, with nothing to anchor her except the faint hope that she'd landed somewhere safe.

It wasn't hard to imagine. In fact, it was far too easy.

Casta's voice softened, though it remained steady. "And I am ashamed to say, we did not help her as we should have. *I* did not help her as I should have. In those early days, I failed her."

Catra blinked, startled by the vulnerability in Casta's voice. The chief sorceress of Mystacor—the unflappable Castaspella, known for her commanding presence in every room—sounded like she was trying to steady herself, to bear the weight of an irreparable blunder.

"I didn't see it. None of us did. Or if we did…" She hesitated, her eyes distant as though recalling something painful. "We didn't want to look closely enough to understand. We were so busy seeing her as *She-Ra* that we didn't stop to ask what was happening to Adora."

Her gaze dropped briefly before she straightened, pulling that poise around her like a cloak. "I only put it all together after Adora broke the Sword. After I saw what that *fucking cunt* said to her."

Catra's head snapped up at that. Hearing such venomous language from someone as composed and dignified as Castaspella was like a slap. For a moment, she just stared, wide-eyed, trying to reconcile the words with the woman in front of her.

But Casta's expression didn't soften. If anything, it hardened, her jaw tightening as her hands folded tightly in her lap.

"She didn't just manipulate Adora," Casta said, her voice trembling now, teetering between rage and despair. "She shattered her. Piece by piece. Made her believe she was nothing without the Sword. That her value only existed in what she could do for someone else."

Her voice broke slightly, but she pushed forward, years of discipline keeping her composure intact, but the swirling chemicals in her scent said she was anything but calm. "And she did the same to me. To Micah. To Mystacor itself."

Casta inhaled sharply, closing her eyes for a moment. When she opened them again, her gaze was fixed on Catra, unwavering.

"And you…" She leaned closer. "She saw your strength, your fire—and she couldn't stand it. So she tried to snuff it out. Made you

think you were broken."

Catra's throat tightened, her vision blurring. She wanted to pull away, to retreat into the safety of sarcasm or indifference, but she couldn't. She didn't want to.

"It doesn't feel like it," she muttered, her voice cracking. "It still feels like… like I let her win."

Casta's hand moved to Catra's shoulder, squeezing gently but firmly. "You're still here," she said, her voice steady and resolute. "You and Adora are together. And that's so much more than she ever wanted for either of you. That's how I know you didn't let her win."

The shame in the sorceress's scent evaporated, leaving only anger.

And you…" She turned, her fierce gaze locking with Catra's. "She saw your strength, your fire—and she couldn't stand it. So she tried to snuff it out. Made you think you were broken. That you needed her to fix you, but she was wrong, Catra." Casta's voice broke, and she cupped Catra's cheek with a gentleness that almost undid her. "It was never about you. Or Adora. It was about her. It was *always* about her."

Catra's throat tightened, her vision blurring. She wanted to pull away, to hide, but she couldn't. She didn't want to. "It doesn't feel like it," she muttered, her voice cracking. "It still feels like… like I let her win."

Casta's hand moved to Catra's shoulder, squeezing gently but firmly. "You're still here," she said, her voice steady and resolute. "You and Adora are together. And that's so much more than she ever wanted for either of you. That's how I know you didn't let her win."

Catra was silent for a long moment, her chest tight, her mind swirling with too many emotions to name. She leaned into Aunt Casta's touch, her head resting against the older woman's

shoulder. “Thanks,” she muttered, her voice barely above a whisper.

Casta’s arm wrapped around her, holding her close. “You remind me of me, you know,” she said quietly, her voice tinged with something wistful. “But you’re stronger than I ever was.”

Catra let out a soft, shaky laugh, her tail uncurling slightly as the tension in her body eased. “Not sure about that,” she muttered, but a faint smile was on her lips.

“I know. It is not easy.” Casta said firmly, her tone leaving no room for argument. “But you have time.”

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Late into the night, Queen Glimmer sat at her desk writing, each word a struggle. She hoped the words would help.

*Dear Adora,*
*I’ve been sitting here for what feels like forever, trying to figure out how to start this. How do you put into words everything you should have said years ago? How do you untangle all the things you wish you could forget but know you need to remember? That’s the hardest part, I think—remembering.*

She stared at the words, her heart pounding in her chest. Her fingers hovered over the paper, ready to tear it apart. What the hell was she even trying to say? This wasn’t going to fix anything. It wasn’t going to change the past.

“This is garbage,” she muttered, her voice cracking in the silence. She threw her pen at the window, the sharp clatter breaking the stillness.

Dropping her head into her hands, Glimmer let out a shaky breath. She wanted to stop—wanted to leave the words unwritten and pretend none of this mattered. But her mind wouldn’t let her rest.

She could *see* them. The battlefield. The armor. The faces she never allowed herself to imagine. The way the Horde soldiers had become nothing more than obstacles to her, their humanity stripped away by their helmets and uniforms.

Her hands trembled as the memories pressed down on her. She could never see their eyes, so she had been spared seeing the fear in them.

Now, she could see them every time she closed her eyes.

She swallowed back a sob, glancing at Bow, asleep on the little couch across the room. She couldn't wake him. Instead, she picked up another pen in her shaking hand.

Her mother's voice echoed faintly in her memory, something Angella had said long ago: *"We build the future with our choices. The good ones—and the bad ones. Never forget that."*

Never forget.

Glimmer sat up straighter, her gaze hardening. She would not forget. She couldn't. If there was one thing she owed Adora, owed herself, it was to face this head-on. To stop hiding from it.

She kept writing. Not because she believed it would fix anything or even take the weight from her own heart. No, she realized, this was not for her. This was because some things shouldn't be buried.

Her heart still felt heavy when she finally folded the letter and tucked it into an envelope. But there was a strange sense of relief, too—like she'd chipped away at the weight pressing on her chest, even if only slightly.

She blinked down to the courtyard where Adora and Catra kept their skiff and left it on the dashboard so that Adora would not miss it. Then, she returned to her study, steering a groggy Bow to their bed.

On the nightstand sat a framed photo of her, Adora, and Bow from before the Portal, before her mother disappeared, before she had to take the throne. Before she listened to Shadow Weaver. For a moment, she just stared at it, her fingers brushing the edge of the frame.

"I won't forget," Glimmer whispered as she climbed into bed, pulling the covers up to her chin. The battlefield still loomed in the corners of her mind, but she wasn't running from it this time.

Some memories were meant to stay. Even the painful ones. *Especially* the painful ones.

To forget would mean losing the pieces of herself she was still trying to understand.

Chapter End Notes

We say farewell to Bright Moon for a while.

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